

Phil 307 The Centrality of Goodness

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 307 • Dr. John Vervaeke

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Lecture 1: Goodness and Being

At a glance — Vervaeke opens the second part of his trilogy on goodness and being.

- 1.1 Welcome to the course, The Centrality of Goodness. Now, this is two parts of a trilogy that I'm doing for the Peterson Academy. The first was The Primacy of Beauty, which has already been done, and then the last one we called The Ultimacy of Truth. And so, I owe this to a good friend of mine, D. C. Schindler, who wrote an essay called "The Primacy of Beauty, the Centrality of Goodness, and the Ultimacy of Truth." We're going to talk about him and his work in this course.
- 1.2 This course also integrates with two other courses I've done on the Peterson Academy, the course on the Introduction to Intelligence and the course on Intelligence, Rationality, Wisdom, and Spirituality. And all of that will be, I'll be doing a bit of review for you as we get into the course. So I just want to give credit to D. C. Schindler and thank him and acknowledge his work. We're going to be talking about a lot of important people, but let's get into it.
- 1.3 Let's start with this title. David's like that— this title, what does he mean by this enigmatic proposal? The centrality of goodness. Like, what does that mean? Imagine somebody saying that to you at a party. "I work on the centrality of goodness." You'd probably just like, "Oh, I hope they go away." So each one of these terms—the primacy of beauty, the centrality of goodness, the ultimacy of truth—they're all superlatives. They're all like, this is the very best.
- 1.4 So there's a relationship they all have to each other. Somehow they are all different, but they're all superlative. And there's something to which they are related that makes them all superlative together. That's very interesting. So what's going on there? He's alluding to a way of thinking about these things that's ancient, and it's not very much alive for us right now. So part of what I'm going to be trying to do in this course is wake you up to alternatives that have slipped into the background, so that we can again recover. What do we mean, and how can we experience the centrality of goodness?
- 1.5 So immediately we're into three questions here. What is this goodness? We all use the word. "That's good. Don't do that, that's bad. Oh, you're evil." We're using this too. You can't go through a day where you can't use this term. You can't use this concept. So you're very familiar with it. The fact that you're familiar with something, of course, doesn't mean you understand it deeply. And so, we have to ask: what is this goodness that he is provoking us to think about? And how does it relate to this everyday sense of goodness that we're using?
- 1.6 When you say, "Oh, that's a good apple. Oh, that's a good apple." "So tell me about the centrality of the goodness of the apple." And you'll look at me like, "What are you talking about? That doesn't make any sense. What's going on?" Yet, D. C. Schindler is a brilliant man and a sensitive heart. How does the centrality of goodness, how does

goodness relate to truth and beauty? Why does he link the three together in his title? What is, what is it that all three are pointing to, that they have in common, they have a common unity? They're in a community together. That's what common unity, that's what community means, a common unity. What is that?

1.7 Immediately, we can say he's alluding, he's trying to get us to remember, there was an ancient and medieval view of what was called the convertibility of the transcendentals. What does that mean? Well, first of all, these three were considered the transcendentals—truth, goodness, and beauty. Why?

1.8 Well, they were all considered to be the highest categories, the most important categories, that applied to being, not individual beings, individual things, but being itself. Already, notice I have to rely on this gesture. Being itself—what are we talking about here? And the convertibility means that somehow the true, the good, and the beautiful all interpenetrated each other. They all mutually supported each other in some fashion. So they all were interwoven such that they all point to being. But how do they point to being? And what is being?

1.9 Now, I'm going to try and do a convention that's in quite a bit of the academic literature. I'm going to use a capital B to talk about Being. And a little B, for being. So this is a being. This exists, right? This is a being. Now just an initial pass. This is, too, right? So that and my coat, your shoes, these are all beings. And yet they're all together in Being, yes? And what is that? What is that?

1.10 Let's start with some initial ideas that relate to truth, goodness, and beauty. Part of what we mean by being is being real. It's real. This is all real. All of these things are real. Do you agree with me on that? They're all real. There's another aspect that was really important: they're all knowable. So to be is to be real and to be knowable. Can you come to know this? Can you? Yeah, of course you can. You could study it, learn about it, so that, that being knowable—we need this term. We're going to use it a lot.

1.11 The technical term for that is intelligibility. It's related to intelligence. Intelligibility means this: I can make sense of this. This has the potential to be known. So to be at least is to be real and to be intelligible. Is that, is that making sense? It's not enough. Philosophers for literally thousands of years have been spilling ink, trying to figure out what being is. Does it even make sense to say that being is? This is, and this is, but being? So we're in really murky waters here.

1.12 Now I'm going to take to be real, realness, and to be intelligible, and I'm going to use a term that says both of them at the same time—realization. You're probably familiar with this very readily. Like, "I just realized that.. I got an insight. I know, I understand. It's intelligible to me now."" But we also talk about "his dreams were realized." He brought them into reality. Does that make sense?

1.13 So, when I use this term, in order to try and point to this, I'm going to point through that meaning and that meaning, so that we can almost like the two eyes; we're

stereoscopically looking at this— realization. Is that making sense? So, being as realization, it's happening right here, right now. And somehow, the centrality of goodness is wrapped up in that and the primacy of beauty and the ultimacy of truth.

- 1.14** This all sounds very strange, which I've been trying to emphasize. This all sounds very—we don't talk this way. We don't think this way, right? It's all, it sounds very strange to our modern or even our postmodern ears. I'm going to critique both what's called modernism and postmodernism in this course. Let's try and provoke and deepen this sense of strangeness, this goodness of being as realization. Let's try and provoke it.
- 1.15** What I'm going to do is turn to a scientific study. So this was done by Yaden et al., meaning a bunch of other authors in 2017, fairly recently. Yaden's doing a lot of work. He'll come up several times in this course. A lot of really careful experimental, empirical investigation. Now, the title is also going to be strange. This is a scientific article, so I'm not reading from some ancient philosophical document. This is academic. This article is cited a lot, so high impact.
- 1.16** But here's the title of it: "The Noetic Quality: A Multimethod Exploratory Study." The noetic quality of what? And what is noetic? And how does it relate to realization? So what he's talking about is, he's talking about people who are having mystical experiences.. So, one of the areas that's had an explosion of academic research in it, some of it overlapping with psychedelics, some of it overlapping with visionary experiences or mystical experiences—I do a lot of work in this. We've done some work in my lab. I'll talk about it briefly in the course—and they're looking at all the features.
- 1.17** People talk about, they have a profound sense of oneness and things like that. We'll come back to that. But he wants to talk about the noetic quality of these experiences. Obviously, he chose that word carefully because it's not familiar to you, I imagine. So, why this? What is this word? Well, first of all, let's pick up on the quality, and that will help us with this.
- 1.18** He finds that, in all of these experiences, there is a central shared property or quality that hasn't been talked about very much, even though it's so—and I keep using this word—central. Even though it's so central. People say the experience they had was really real. "This is the most real experience I've ever had in my life. It was the ultimate reality. This is really real." And then they struggle because it's ineffable. They find it difficult to put it into words, but they want to.
- 1.19** We'll come back to this, but it's so weird because normally this is what we do. We have our normal waking consciousness, which we use as our benchmark for being in touch with reality. I'm awake right now; I'm not dreaming. And if we get an altered state of consciousness, like we're dreaming or we're drunk, when we come back to waking consciousness, we go, "That was weird. Those aren't real." And notice, by the way, that real is comparative. So I need you to note that down. Real isn't like red. That's red. To say that something is real or an illusion is to compare two things together. It's like tall.

If I'm saying that's real, I'm comparing it to something else that's an illusion. If I'm saying that's an illusion or weird or strange, I'm comparing it to something real.

- 1.20** So we say the dream or the drunken state was weird, illusory, because this state of consciousness is real. Is that OK? And why do we think this one is real? Because our normal state of consciousness gives us so much realization. It puts us in touch with things and helps us make sense of the world as a whole. So normally what we do is, when we come back to normal consciousness, we say, here's the touchstone for realness. Those things were illusions.
- 1.21** But let's go back to this work. People go into these altered states of consciousness. They've probably never had it before in their life. About 40% of the population can have this spontaneously, higher if you're doing mindfulness practices, higher if you're doing psychedelics. So this isn't insignificant. This is the first time they have it. They come back into normal waking consciousness, and they don't say, "That was weird." They say, "This is unreal because that was really real." They do the exact opposite.
- 1.22** That's the quality that he wants us to pay attention to. The really real, the deepest realization that people experience; and what people do is, they say, "This experience was the most, or at least one of the most, significant experiences of my life." That's the quality. So, noetic comes from a Greek word—there's going to be a lot of Greek, because we're going to keep dipping back. Notice what he's doing, what Schindler's doing. He's alluding back to the ancient world: the Greek world, just like David Schindler was. Noesis.
- 1.23** We're going to talk about this as well. Sorry, I'm prefiguring a lot for you. English is kind of clunky in some ways. Like, we have one word for love. "I love this cookie." And then you go to your, like, my beloved Sara. "I love you, Sara. I love this cookie. I love you, Sara." What's going on there? We have this one word "know." The Greeks had multiple words because they had different kinds of knowing.
- 1.24** So this is noesis. What do we mean by noesis? It's not theoretical, argumentative knowing. It's not the kind of knowing that we associate with theories that we're building or an argument that we're making, like I'm doing right now. I'm building an argument. I'm trying to change your beliefs. This is propositional knowing, what we're doing right here. I'm proposing things to you. I'm giving you propositions. Propositions are claims that could be true or false. And then we evaluate them, and we look at arguments, and we look at evidence. That's not what noesis is. It's not argumentative, theoretical knowing. It's not that kind of knowing. What is it? Well, what I want you to get, first of all, is a very interesting idea about how is it that they're claiming that this is an important kind of knowing? It's not propositional, it's not even conceptual, because they can't put it into words. Just pause on that. "I'm knowing this is the most knowing I could ever do. It's really real." And yet I'm not giving you any arguments, any reasons. I don't have any concepts or any words. That's a strange kind of knowing, isn't it? What kind of knowing is that? What kind of knowing is that?

- 1.25 I had a series and then a book called *Awakening from the Meaning Crisis*. You might have heard of it, published last year, which, myself and my fellow author, Christopher Mastropietro, we talked about propositional tyranny. We think there's only one kind of knowing. Our culture, part of the modern framework that is making it hard for us to see this—that's why we keep going to the ancient stuff—part of our modern framework, which goes with us only having one word, so there's only one kind of knowing, propositional knowing: knowing that cats are mammals.
- 1.26 Whenever you say "knowing that," and then you give a proposition, knowing that cats are mammals—do you know that cats are mammals, by the way? Now, what kind of memory do you have of that? How many of you— put up your hands—how many of you know that cats are mammals? Put up your hands. How many of you can remember when you learned that, the specific day? You might make inferences or guesses, but you can't go back and relive it. Compare that to: what did you eat for breakfast this morning? Do you remember? And what are you doing right now? I'm looking at my breakfast. I would go back, and I'd relive it.
- 1.27 So one of the things I want to challenge in this course is that presupposition. Here's another term we're going to need to share. What's a presupposition? It's a kind of assumption. What is it when you assume something? You're taking it on board. You're assuming that you don't have evidence or an argument. A presupposition is an assumption that is shared and is doing a lot of foundational work for you. It's a very deep and widely shared assumption.
- 1.28 So we're going to challenge the presupposition that there's only one kind of knowing. Why do I call it tyranny? Because it blinds us to things. It's blinding us to this in an important way. Now that propositional tyranny is a presupposition that's shared both by modernism, and I'll explain what that is, and postmodernism. They both assume propositions are central.
- 1.29 So two of the most common and common frameworks that are at war in dominating our thinking right now, dominating our seeing, both blind us, the tyranny, to having a kind of knowing that is somehow non-propositional, non-conceptual, non-linguistic; and yet, puts us into an awareness of the really real, that people regard as one of the best and most important experiences of their life. D. C. Schindler is alluding to all of that. The guy is brilliant, and what's so nice about him is that he's such a nice guy. We've had multiple conversations. It's really wonderful to meet people that are astonishingly brilliant and don't totally realize that they are. They're fun to hang around.
- 1.30 So now I've put you off, what is noesis, but I wanted to set you up for it. It's knowing by seeing. But in the sense of orienting and noticing. So, when I orient and suddenly notice that she has a bracelet, it's a little bit like an aha. "Oh, aha!" Like an insight. Notice the word, in sight, insight, seeing. It's not visual seeing, although I'm visually seeing. What we're trying to pick up on is the act of knowing. I suddenly have oriented and noticed.

"Ah." That's noesis: orienting and noticing. That's how you're knowing, by how you orient and notice. It's a moment of reorientation and noticing. It's a moment, one of the best translations of it, of "in-sight," when we're seeing into a situation in a way that we have realized something.

- 1.31** Now what's going on in that? When I orient and notice, I'm doing what Matson called "sizing up," from his book *Sentience*, 1976. You're automatically oriented, you're sizing up, so you are foregrounding and backgrounding. Yes? So hopefully you're foregrounded on me, and then there's some background here. And then there's like, really, almost fairly in your awareness, the floor and stuff like that. You're doing that.
- 1.32** It is a term that I've been using since *Awakening From the Meaning Crisis*. I borrowed it from Ramachandran, the neuroscientist, "salience landscaping." So what's salience? Salience is when something is perceptually relevant to you; it calls your attention, or you make something salient by paying attention to it. So, for example, ready? Your left big toe. Left big toe. Now you're aware of it. It's salient to you. A moment ago, unless you're really weird, you weren't thinking about that or noticing it. But you see what happened when I said your left big toe? You oriented to it, you noticed it, and now it became salient. It became perceptually relevant to you, and it stood out for you.
- 1.33** And then, there's ways how you're sizing things up, foregrounding and backgrounding, and how you're making them salient. Why do I call it a salience landscape? Because it's like a landscape. There's peaks of salience, like perhaps my face, there's lower things, like perhaps my body, and then there's things that have very low salience, like the floor. Sizing up, salience landscaping, as I'm orienting, and within all of that, I'm noticing. Does that make sense?
- 1.34** I call this perspectival knowing. Because what you're doing—we have a phrase for this—you're putting things into perspective, perspectival knowing. It's not propositional knowing. I'm not claiming any propositions. I'm orienting, sizing up, salience landscaping, and noticing, and potentially having insights. Have you ever had an insight? I'm sure you have. Like, "I thought she was angry, but she's afraid. Turns out she's afraid." You have that aha. How many of you have had insights? You all have. It's one of the reliable differences you have from artificial intelligence. So, if you failed that question, I need to check and see if you're wired up.
- 1.35** Now think about when you've had a really powerful insight, not the conclusion you came to, but the process of insight. You don't know. You don't know. Here's the famous one: the 9-dot problem, drawing all nine dots with four straight lines. People think it's very easy to do. Yes, yes. Very easy. Yes. Oh, four lines, 1, 2, 3, 4. Wait. I missed the middle. 1, 2, 3. Wait. 1, 2, 1, 2. Oh, oh, four straight lines. What's the problem? Here's one line. Here's two, here's three, and there's four.
- 1.36** Why was that hard? Because of your noesis. You put it into a particular perspective: it was a square, and you focused on the square. You foregrounded it. You backgrounded

the non-square space as irrelevant. It didn't stand out for you. The square stood out, and then that bound you. Do you see that? And then, I provoked an aha! "Oh, the square!" There is no square there, actually. You had a realization. There is no square there, actually. Realization, yes?

- 1.37** And when you have that aha moment, can you tell me what you're doing? You can tell me what you're doing when you're reasoning. "Oh, I do this premise, and it goes to this premise and this," but this is how people describe insight. "Well, I didn't know it, and then I did." Ineffable, non-propositional. Another way of putting this, a little bit shorthand, but noesis is knowing by insight. It's that kind of seeing. That's why it makes sense that it happens when people are having mystical experiences.
- 1.38** So what's going on in perspectival knowing? I'm going to give you a quick schema and, oh, here it is. I was looking for the eraser. So, perspectival knowing. This is a lot of work that I have done with a good friend of mine, Dan Chiappe. We've published three articles in some high-impact journals. We're working on another article that we have in revision right now, which means the editors are asking us to revise it before publishing it. It's some of my cutting-edge work on orientation and rationality.
- 1.39** But what's happening in a perspective is, you have a standing. This is somewhere you are standing. Now, we're not talking—I mean, we can be talking literally. But when I'm saying insight, I'm not saying literal sight; I'm using sight as a metaphor for sizing up salience landscaping, all that stuff. So there's a standing. There's a place from which you have your point of view and your perspective.
- 1.40** When somebody tells you, "Take a different perspective on inflation," they don't mean that your point of view is here in Phoenix, but that you have a point of view from which you're standing. Does that make sense? So you have your standing. Now, what that is is your point of contact. So let's use the literal to help us understand the metaphorical.
- 1.41** When I'm standing, this is where everything is close to my touch, and I'm literally in touch. So I've got some stability here because I'm in touch. I'm grounded. So try to hear the cognitive versions of those. When you say somebody is grounded and stable cognitively, you don't mean physically. You mean, oh yeah, they have—another thing you might say is, "Oh, you have a very solid position." You don't mean they're actually standing on something solid. Is that OK? All right, so you have your standing. This is where you are present. You have a sensed presence.
- 1.42** And then you have, what we say is, we take a stance towards something, a stance. We also talk about having an attitude, but I'm going to try and do this because these metaphors all fit together. These all relate to stand. I have a stance. What's going on in stance? We'll come back to this. Also, a lot of the things, we're going to keep circling around them and going around and coming back to them and deepening them, because we're trying to zero in on this centrality of goodness.

- 1.43 So, I'm a martial artist, so sometimes I take a stance. There's one— it depends on which martial art you're doing. Notice I don't actually fight with this. I can't do it. Why do I do that? What do you think? Any ideas? Why do I stand this way in a particular stance? What am I doing? Yeah. I'm preparing.
- 1.44 So first of all, let's say you're a threat. I hope you're not. So I'm taking a stance towards you. So notice I'm orienting and I'm trying to size him up and make the right thing salient. I'm trying to get into a position that makes a bunch of different things I might need to do readily and equally available. I may need to strike. I may need to block. So what I've done is, I've got an orientation, and I've got a poise that gives me the best— it's like I'm trying to be at the point in a network of possible things I could do, and I'm trying to be at that nexus point. So no matter what I need to do, I can get to it quickly. Is that OK?
- 1.45 That's what your stance is. What you're trying to do is, put yourself—you're standing on something, your presuppositions, by the way, you're standing on your presuppositions, and then you're orienting and you're trying to set yourself so that the various things you might need to do towards whatever it is are well— you're in a state of well-preparedness. You're ready. Does that make sense? OK. I'm going to give you a way of talking about this because it's going to connect to some technical terms.
- 1.46 When we orient towards something, we face a problem. Whenever we orient, we also blind. When I'm oriented towards her, I'm blind to him. And when I'm oriented to the front of her, I am blind to the back of her. So making something obvious is always also making other things oblivious to me. So notice, you actually never fully see this object. Do you ever actually see it from all the possible aspects you could see it from? No, because each aspect blinds you to the other aspect.
- 1.47 Have you ever thought about that? You never actually see anything. You see aspects of it. Here's the interesting thing: these aspects somehow belong together. There is—here it comes—a center to them that's not a literal center. Somehow they all, all those different aspects belong together. Now, what you have to do is, you have to decide which orientation gives you the best balance between. I don't need to see her back right now. So this is a good orientation to her. I need to see her face because her face is probably her best way of understanding if she's following me, whereas her feet aren't doing much for me, helping me in that task. So I'm going to try and make this central, and I'm going to ignore this, this. That's like positioning something.
- 1.48 This is called optimal gripping. And again, we're not talking about physically gripping, but we could be. We're talking about: how am I cognitively grasping something? And I'm trying to get the best balance between what's hidden and what's visible to me. Are we clear on that?
- 1.49 Now, what I'm doing in a stance is, I'm doing—sorry for this, but we're going to have to use this—I'm doing meta-optimal gripping. I'm not taking an optimal grip on her. I'm

setting myself up so I can take multiple optimal grips, depending on what she does. Does that make sense? I'm setting myself up so I can do multiple optimal grips, depending on what she does. So, if she stands up and pulls a knife, I can shift back and open up the space. If she starts to close to me, I can move to one side so that she has to radically orient, and in that moment of reorientation, I get an opening. Does that make sense?

- 1.50** Sorry, this lecture will not be violent, I promise you. It's just that, when you do something really graphic, it often helps people with sensorimotor, and you'll see why in this course, it really helps people understand, by the way, relate to standing, understand, gives them something to stand on, so that they can take a stance.
- 1.51** So every moment of consciousness that he's having is taking a stance on the world. He's trying to get into a mental state that gives him meta-optimal gripping. Like, what is John going to do and say? I've got to try and get my mind poised so that wherever which way he goes, I can follow him and stick with him. I can keep an optimal grip on the lecture. Is that making sense?
- 1.52** So then, I have my standing, I have my stance, and then a way. Notice we use this word to mean a path, but also a method, a way of doing something. We have a way. What that is, is, if I get the right stance, I see a bunch of possible standings I can move to. So, literally, if I'm trying to make my way, if I'm doing what's called wayfaring, I'm here. I need to get over there. How do I? Oh, I can go there. And then I can go, and it opens up.
- 1.53** That's called—another, sorry, we have to deal with the academics, and they love this adjective "meta." This is called meta-stability. It means, I try to put my place not where I'm going to stay permanently, but that would allow me to be stable here. And they get stable here, from which I can get stable here, from which I can get stable here. We're going to need all these when we talk about some more technical stuff happening in the brain. But I'm trying to feed two birds with one scone here, get you to understand this, but also prepare you for using these later.
- 1.54** And then you have a horizon. When I have a perspective, it reaches out to the horizon, the limits of what I can see. But the horizon is also meta-stable because when I move, the horizon moves. There's a bound. There is that which is not in your perspective right now.
- 1.55** Are you thinking about Frederick the Great right now? No, it's outside of the horizon. Could you think of Frederick the Great? Sure, but you're not. It's like when you're standing, and you're looking out, you don't see the whole world. There's a bounding. When all of that's together, you have a perspective. That's perspectival knowing.
- 1.56** Somehow, this has something to do with the realization of the centrality of goodness. That's what's going on in this word noesis. And all of that, I believe, was backgrounded way over here, because even though I can point to all kinds of things in your experience

and your knowing, that's not what your culture calls knowing; it calls propositional statements knowing.

- 1.57** Now, what if that propositional tyranny blinds us to goodness in some really important way? So what we need to understand is something I've been demonstrating to you, which is the way we keep using sensorimotor orientation and navigation to talk about cognition. Cognition means knowing, how we know the world. Is that just a coincidence? Is that just a metaphor? No, this is a term.
- 1.58** Sorry, I'm going to give you a term, that's part of what's called the new biology. Biology is the science that's going through a scientific revolution right now. So if you want to see this, read Philip Ball's book, *How Life Works*, or watch some lectures by Michael Levin, L-E-V-I-N. I have some conversations with him, but this is also something that's a term being used in cognitive science. It's the term "exaptation."
- 1.59** So let me give you a quick biological example. What am I doing with my tongue right now? What am I doing with my tongue? I'm speaking. Do other creatures have tongues? Cats, dogs, birds? Do they speak? No. So did tongues originally evolve for speech? Nope. They evolved for tasting and for moving food around. So you've got a highly sensitive, flexible muscle, and it's in the air passageway. So what you can do, what evolution can do, speaking anthropomorphically, so that's why I'm doing this, is, it can repurpose the tongue for speech. That's exaptation.
- 1.60** Evolution doesn't make things from scratch. It takes things that already evolved for one use and repurposes them for a new use. Exaptation. Now here's the thing—and this is the work of Michael Anderson and a whole bunch of other people— your brain is constantly doing this. Your brain is taking areas that evolved, and also for you, developed in your development for sensorimotor orientation and navigation, and then repurposing them to help you understand the world.
- 1.61** What's the evidence for this? Well, you can take a look at a good book by Barbara Tversky called *Mind in Motion*, where she does a whole bunch of empirical research to back this. That's one thing. Another is conceptual metaphor, the work of Lakoff and Johnson. We think in metaphor: I hope you see what I'm saying. I hope you get my point. But maybe it's too hard for you. Maybe you can't make your way through it. You can't really follow what I'm saying. Maybe, but maybe you do understand me.
- 1.62** Everything you say and do is conceptual metaphor. Your brain is continually exapting all the time. So if we have a kind of knowing, propositional tyranny, that blinds us to the non-propositional, it actually disconnects us from the fundamentals of our knowing. It severs us from the fact that our knowing is exapted out of our embodied non-propositional interaction with the world. That's another reason why it's a tyranny.
- 1.63** What's some more evidence? We say things like this. "Hey, look, the road runs all the way up the mountain." Roads don't run. We run on the roads. But the road runs all the way up the mountain. It's not doing anything, but we talk that way. And nobody goes,

"What did she mean?" Oh, yeah. You're right. Or you say, "No, you're wrong. It doesn't go all the way up. It only runs to that part." It's called fictive motion.

- 1.64** Have you noticed that my hands keep doing stuff while I'm talking? But I'm actually not doing anything with my hands. I'm not actually, I mean, sometimes I'm doing something. I'm writing on the board, but most of the time I'm doing all this stuff— what—gesture. You're gesturing all day long. In fact, if I limit you from gesturing, Susan Goldin-Meadow, if I say, "I want you to explain this to me, and you have to hold onto this pole," your performance degrades. You're pantomiming all day long. You're gesturing. Have you noticed that people gesture even when they're talking on the phone? They're gesturing.
- 1.65** Why are you gesturing? Because you are using sensorimotor to exapt, to enable your cognition. The degree to which I sever that is the degree to which I disable your cognition. If I were to ask Lawrence, "Can you tell me what you're thinking right now? Can you? Yeah. What do you do?" He'll say something like, "Listen to this." He'll say something like, "I look into my mind, and I see in there—" Right? Is he literally looking? Is there, if I open his head, do I—"oh, that's what it is." Is there any light inside? What's he talking about?
- 1.66** That space is not a real space. But it's not just an illusion because that is how you actually know what you're thinking, and that's central to your rationality and your responsibility. If you can't know what you're thinking, you can't be reasonable, and you can't be responsible. So this, this is not just some silly thing we do. It's absolutely—here it comes—central to being a person.
- 1.67** I'm going to need a phrase for this. This is from Henry Corbin. When we're using images this way, they're not imaginary; they're imaginal. Imaginary is when you form a picture in your mind, like picture a sailboat. Are the sails up or down? That's not what we're talking about here. We're talking about images you're not looking at; these are images you think through. I'm going to use the word imaginal as what happens when we're doing exaptation.
- 1.68** So now we can fill out noesis again. Perspectival, imaginal knowing that is exapting our spatialtemporal seeing. That's what they mean by seeing. It's right. It is perspectival, imaginal knowing that is exapting spatial temporal orientation and sizing up and grounding. Is that landing for you? By the way, that was a metaphor. Because it's landing where you are standing, so that you are in touch with it, and it is present to you.
- 1.69** OK, let's go back to Yaden. As I said, people find these experiences of the really real the most important of their life. So what they do, and notice my language here, they do things to become—they say, "I want to be closer to that. I want to be in contact with that reality." They change their lives. They change their jobs, their relationships,

sometimes their identity. They change everything so they can be closer to that reality, so they can be more in touch with it.

- 1.70** And what you can see, because we can do some objective measures, is that their lives do get better. They're healthier. Their relationships are healthier. Everything about their life gets better. So they transform many aspects of their lives and identities in order to conform to and participate in this reality.
- 1.71** Here's one of my favorite poets, one of the greats, Rainer Maria Rilke, a German. I won't read it to you in German because that would be silly. I'm going to read you the poem in English. But his poetry is so powerful. Even the translations are like, because he's having one of these experiences. So he's looking at an archaic bust of Apollo, like a sculpture. I presume he's in a museum. He says, "We cannot know his legendary head with eyes like ripening fruit." So it's a headless bust. "And yet his torso is still suffused with brilliance from inside, like a lamp in which his gaze, now turned to low, gleams in all its power. Otherwise, the curved breast could not dazzle you so." Who's he talking to? He's talking to himself.
- 1.72** "Nor could a smile run through the placid hips and thighs to that dark center where procreation flared. Otherwise, this stone would seem defaced beneath the translucent cascade of the shoulders and would not glisten like a wild beast's fur." So this is like he's having an epiphany. It's like the beauty of this is, like, whoa! "Would not, from all the borders of itself, burst like a star; for here there is no place that does not see you." And then a separate sentence. "You must change your life." You must change your life.
- 1.73** We did work in my lab. We presented it at academic conferences. Everything was going, and then Covid. And then, people drifted away. We're going to still try to get the band back together and get it published. But what we found was that the number of mystical experiences that people have is predictive, correlates with how meaningful they find their lives. Nobody had bothered to do that research, by the way. It seems obvious, but right.
- 1.74** Now, what we know about meaning in life is that meaning in life is about being connected. We want to be connected. As people say, "I want to be connected to something bigger than myself." Susan Wolf talks about this in her book. I think it's 2012, *Meaning in Life and Why It Matters*. Now, people don't mean this literally. If I take Lawrence and chain him to a mountain. He goes, "Ah, now I'm connected to something bigger than myself." It's ridiculous. So what do they mean?
- 1.75** Well, we use "bigger" in this really important way. It's connected to two words we have: enlightenment and awakening, which are words for profound realization. When I awaken, I was previously in a small world, the world of my dreams. And then I go to a larger world from which, remember, realness is comparative? I can say, "Oh, that little world wasn't real. This one is." Now I'm connected to something larger than myself because it's showing me what's real.

- 1.76** Awakening. The Buddha is the awakened one. When they met him on the road, "Are you a god?" "No." "Are you a divine messenger?" "No." "Are you a holy prophet?" "No." "Are you an ordinary man?" "No." "Well, what are you then?" "I am awake." That's how he got his title. Enlightened, universal, noesis, vision. See the connections? You're in a dark room and you're in a little world. I turn the light on, and now a lot of illusions have been dispelled. And I've realized that how I was previously seeing was limited and insufficient.
- 1.77** We want to be connected to that which helps us realize. Do you think that might be really good, when you're connected that way? Yeah, that might be really good. So, James Matthew Wilson, in his book *The Vision of the Soul: —noesis—Truth, Goodness, and Beauty in the Western Tradition* from 2017, says, but what's going on? He says, he asks us, "Do you want your life to be meaningful? Do you want it to be as meaningful as possible?" So you want to be connected to what helps you most realize reality. And that's really good. Why?
- 1.78** To say something is good means it's satisfying a need that's central to our being. What need is it? He calls it, we have a hunger for reality. Hunger for reality. This actually goes back to Plato in *The Republic*. Plato noted that we have—sorry, it's coming again, another meta word. We should have a little fanfare or something for whenever we have a meta word—meta-desire. A meta-desire is, in addition to whatever is satisfying a specific desire, you have a meta-desire for all of your specific desires. Meta-desire. Is that OK? You have a meta-desire that whatever is satisfying your specific desire is real and not an illusion or fraud or deception.
- 1.79** I regularly ask my students this. I'll ask them: how many of you are in satisfying romantic relationships, because romantic relationships are our surrogate for God and tradition right now. "The romantic partner, she"—I'm straight, so I'm doing that—"she will be the one," and all that. And then, of course, you ask people what causes the most suffering in your life? My romantic relationships. But anyways.
- 1.80** So I asked them: how many of you would want to know if your partner was cheating on you, even if that meant the complete destruction of this satisfying relationship that you're in? What percentage do you think want to know? All of them. Sometimes, one or two people don't, and when I go and talk to them, something is going wrong. I won't get into the details because that's sort of clinical. And when I ask them why, because you're losing this thing you really value, and they go, "Because it isn't real."
- 1.81** I forget your name. Gayane. Well, that's a pretty name. How old are you?
- 1.82** I'm 32.
- 1.83** 32. So let's say she turned 21 some time ago. I'm not saying anything about her economic success, but she was living with her parents at that time still, for some reason. Many people do when they're 21 still. So I'm not insulting you in any way, I hope. And they say to her, "You've just turned 21. Come here. We have to show you

something." What? They take her to a part of the house, the hallway she's been down many times. And they stop at this one place, and they press [a button], and a door opens that she's never seen before.

- 1.84** They go in, and there's all these cameras and there's these screens and there's pictures and there's charts of her, and they say, "We were hired by the government to have you, and we were taught how to talk to you. It's all been acting. It's all acting, and we're required by law to now tell you. We don't love you or care about you at all. But nothing's going to change. We're going to go back and keep saying everything we said to you, and we're going to keep taking care of you financially."
- 1.85** You go out the door, they close it, they say, "OK, back to normal now. Love you, love you. See you at dinner. Love you." How do you feel right now? You're devastated, right? Because notice what's not happening. Nothing has actually changed. All the care, all the words, all the gestures are all the same, but it's not real.
- 1.86** There's a great science fiction novel which has been made into a really good movie in Russian, and a really horrible movie in English starring George Clooney. Don't watch it. You'll be wasting a part of your life. But they go to this planet, and it's got this ocean that's somehow sentient, but they can't communicate with it. And then it does this really weird thing. It makes exact duplicates of people they love who have died. How do you think they react to these people? Are they happy? "Ruth. You're here." No. What do they experience? Horror. Because although this person has all the properties, it's not really the person. It's not real.
- 1.87** Robert Nozick has a famous article about the experience machine. "Here, you can step in this experience. This machine will give you experiences as if, like the Matrix, as if your life is wonderful and everybody loves you, but it's all just an illusion." Would you live in the machine? No. What do people in the Matrix want to do? They want to get free from the Matrix, even though the real world is crappy. They have to eat slop. What does the villain want? Cypher, which means a symbol that doesn't translate, he wants to go back into the Matrix. What's his one condition? "I don't want to remember. I don't want to know that it's not real."
- 1.88** Do you see what he's talking about? We have a hunger for realness. This is the platonic meta-desire. Now, we don't want merely abstract theoretical realness. We want real presence. That's why right now I'm missing Sara. I know she's still there. I know we're great. I know she loves me, I love her, but I miss her, because she's not present. The theoretical propositional isn't good enough—isn't what? Good enough. It's not good enough. It's not good enough.
- 1.89** Meaninglessness is a loss of reality. Meaningless is to feel your world is absurd. But that makes it less real. You're alienated from things. You're suffering existential anxiety. You're suffering, perhaps, anguish. You've lost something. And so now there's a disconnect between reality and goodness. What is this goodness? What is it? There's

something about our satisfying our need to, for meaning in life and participating in reality and having things present so we can be in contact with them.

- 1.90** Notice this is not what we typically, and too much, mean by goodness. Oh, good means moral goodness. He's a good person. Means he behaves morally. That's what good means. It means moral. Wolf argues very convincingly that this goodness I'm talking to you about is not moral, because meaning is not reducible to moral. Look, you can have a person who is moral, but he finds his reality absurd. Meaning is going down. He's moral, but he's lonely. He's homesick, meaning he's going down.
- 1.91** He's moral, but he's foolish. He's been honest, like the idiot in Dostoevsky. He's honest and speaks the truth. But he's an idiot. Moral but frustrated. I've been a good person, but everything I've tried to accomplish hasn't—a moral person, but failed. The people who are being moral aren't guaranteed to succeed in what they're trying to accomplish.
- 1.92** This goodness is somehow the really real. It's not due to anything these people are doing or how they're treating other people. When people in the Yaden work are going, oh, they're not doing anything, they're not saying anything, they're not thinking anything. They're not treating other people in any way. There's no morality here. It's not that they're being immoral; they're in an amoral place. And yet it's profoundly good. This non-moral goodness is associated with great beauty. Great beauty, the beauty of realization.
- 1.93** We need a new term for this goodness of the really real that is not moral goodness. I've coined a term, I'm sorry, it's clunky, but it's called "ontonormativity." I need to use this because I need to use this instead of always having to say this long phrase about "the goodness of the really real that's not moral goodness" and it's associated highly with beauty. Onto is the Greek word for being. Normative—I don't mean statistically normal. I'm using this to mean normative in the sense of what guides us and orients us, tells us how we ought to follow, what rules we should follow.
- 1.94** So it constrains us and orients us. It constrains and orients us by guiding us to something good. We should follow it. It rules over us. This is our new term for the goodness of the really real that satisfies our meta-desire for reality, and we find the promise of this realization and satisfaction of the meta-desire very beautiful. That's noetic vision. That's the first lecture.
- 1.95** My question is, I work with people with autism, and we're talking about optimal gripping and being able to take a stance in a meta-cognitive way. And so, I guess I'm interested in hearing your perspective on how that applies in people that are neurodiverse.
- 1.96** Yeah. So I happened to have a paper published on that from 2022 with Brett Anderson, Mark Miller, and John Vervaeke, because what you can actually see is that people are on a continuum. This is what people nowadays say: everybody's on the spectrum, and it's autism at this end, and non-autistic psychosis, what's called schizotypal psychosis

here. So what this means is, autistic people tend—these are all tending terms—they tend to be focused on features, details, and they tend to miss important patterns.

- 1.97** Psychotic people are focused on the big picture, and they tend to see patterns that aren't there. So they're missing patterns. They're mistaking patterns. They are future-oriented. They are gestalt-oriented. What you can see is, what we argued is that this pattern actually makes sense in terms of something I'm going to teach you in this course, that's in the two other courses I've mentioned, the course on intelligence and the course on intelligence, rationality, wisdom and spirituality. This has to do with relevance, realization. This has to do with, we're all on a continuum, with how we orient, how we size things up, how we salience landscape. These are all dimensions of relevance realization, which is the fundamental way we're trying to realize and make sense of the world.
- 1.98** Why this diversity? So the idea is, think of this like a magnet, and these are the poles, and there's a polarity. We all need the polarity. If you were always to focus on the features, that's dangerous. If you're always to focus on the gestalt, that's dangerous.
- 1.99** The trouble is, they're in a trade-off relationship. As I improve one, I'll pay more attention to the gestalt. Remember, remember optimal grip? As I pay more attention to the gestalt, what do I become more and more oblivious to? The features. I'm going to focus on the features. What do I become oblivious to? The gestalt. So this is why, for example, autistic people—you, are you statistically norm?
- 1.100** I think so, yeah.
- 1.101** Well, I mean, I don't want to insult anybody. You brought it up. So it's fair for me to ask you. So when you're looking at me, you can do this with eye-tracking, you're skipping all over my face. You're zooming in, zooming out, zooming in, zooming out, because you're trying to optimally grip my face, because you don't know what my face is going to do next. If you're autistic, there's a very high probability you'd be hard focused on my mouth. You miss a lot when you're doing that.
- 1.102** Now, there are advantages, by the way. If you want—sorry, this sounds like we're using people. And so I'm not talking about political; I'm talking about evolution, biological evolution. It's useful to have some people like this because they can work at the detail level. It's useful to have some people like this because they can work at the gestalt, and it's useful to have people spread out to balance. The price we pay for that is that we get people that get stuck at the poles.
- 1.103** But all of this is about noesis. So it's going to radically affect the way they feel in touch with the world and what's present to them and what they can realize and not realize. Did that answer your question?
- 1.104** Yes.
- 1.105** Thank you. There's another question? Lawrence.

- 1.106 When it comes to being properly fitted to a situation, and its relation to non-propositional knowing, are we trying to rediscover non-propositional ways of knowing, or are we inventing new ones? Yeah.
- 1.107 I'm trying to get you to recover them. And we'll talk a little bit more about this, but this is actually Tolkien. Lord of the Rings. Fantasy writer. Because he wanted his works to be imaginal, not imaginary. He didn't want people to be using his world as an escape. He wanted people to go into that world and look at this world through that world.
- 1.108 Let me give you an analogy. An anthropologist goes to another culture. So they're wearing their cultural glasses, and then they go to another culture, and those glasses don't work. This is what happens when you're on pilgrimage. I just got back from one. And so, you have to put on other glasses. And then what the anthropologist does, and this is what you do in ethnography—I did anthropology in graduate school—and then when you come back to your home culture, you keep your glasses on, and you can see things in your home culture you couldn't see before. You recover your culture.
- 1.109 Does that make sense? See how this is a noetic insight, by the way? That's what Tolkien wanted fantasy to do. You're supposed to go into Middle-earth, keep those, wear different glasses, and then come back and see this world. That's his theory of recovery. I'm trying to get you to recover the non-propositional ways of knowing that will involve, potentially, you learning new practices. I'm not going to teach you those, but we can talk about them. I do teach them elsewhere.

Lecture 2: Connecting to the Real

At a glance — Connecting to the real — the enigmatic centrality of goodness.

- 2.1 Welcome back. So we've been really probing on this mysterious, enigmatic, but hopefully tantalizing centrality of goodness, and we've gotten to how we have to try and know it with this noetic vision and non-propositional. It's a different kind of knowing, and it's a different kind of goodness. So we put that all together in this term, "ontonormativity," the goodness of the really real that satisfies our meta-desire for realness, to be in contact with it, and that makes our lives more meaningful, and it's significant to us.
- 2.2 We've been looking at it already through two frameworks: the secular scientific framework, Yaden and the scientists, and then an artistic framework, a great poet. And now I want to take a look at something that is probably being suggested to you, which is a religious framing.
- 2.3 Why am I doing all these different framings? Well, first of all, if multiple independent perspectives converge on something, we should take it seriously. That raises the plausibility of it. Secondly, modernity likes to keep these three isolated from each other: science, art, and religion. And we're challenging that. So, I'm actually trying to see if— do they at times point to the same thing?
- 2.4 I'm picking Christianity. I could pick other religions. I'm picking Christianity because I'm betting that it's the one that is most culturally familiar to people. That's it. I'm not advocating for Christianity, neither am I criticizing it. So you've heard it, I'm sure, though. Genesis, God said, "Let there be light." And what does God do? He looks at it, and then He pronounces the light good. The light is good. It's a very odd thing.
- 2.5 Now, it's probably so familiar we just sort of, "Oh yeah, that's nice. How nice of God to do that." Right? Wait, what's going on there? Let's pause. Notice that it's not His act of creation that He is pronouncing good, which is what people tend to think. But that's not what the text says. God doesn't say, "Hey, my act of doing this was good." It's not what He says. He says, "The light itself is good." So this goodness is not ethical. It has nothing to do with any action. It's somehow a property of the light. Light isn't ethical. That doesn't make any sense. Nor is light aesthetic. Maybe all God means is, "Hey, that's really pretty. That's beautiful." He doesn't say that, but maybe that's what we try to hear.
- 2.6 The problem is—and this is kind of intriguing. We'll have to put aside God because I'm not trying to speak too much on His or Her behalf, but we don't actually see light. This is a big metaphor from the Neoplatonic tradition— we see by means of light. We see because we and other things co-participate in light. We're both in light. We're both in the light. We see things because of lighting. There's a lot of lighting in this studio right now. And because of lighting, there are colors. Lighting and coloring can be beautiful,

but light itself? That's not quite right. So remember that. Light somehow gets the visible and the seer together. We're both participating in the light. Now, lighting enables— sorry, vision. I said it again. I keep coming back to this.

- 2.7** Presumably, God doesn't have eyes. Does that make sense? So, what's going on here? My good friend Jonathan Pageau would say, "Well, this is because this is symbolic," and then he would do what he does, and it's joyful, and I love being in his presence. But what do you mean? Light makes things visible because we and the lighted thing are both participating in the light. We're joined together somehow. We don't actually see the light, but we see by means of the light through participating in the light, both the world and the viewer.
- 2.8** I'm saying this multiple times because I'm trying to make it really obvious, because then I'm going to do a bit of a move here, which is light is a symbol for intelligibility. That which makes things—light makes things visible by having the lighted thing and the viewer co-participating in the light. Yes, Jake? Does that make sense?
- 2.9** What's God doing in Genesis? He's creating. He's bringing things into being. Being is like light in that it is making things, it's making intelligibility possible. Does that make sense? So what's actually happening is things are coming to light in creation. In the light, we can realize. So this is creation as realization. It's very different from some of the surrounding myths where there's a being and it gets hacked apart and the gods parcel things out. This is a much more interesting, initial beginning.
- 2.10** That's why there's another book in the Bible that begins with "In the beginning." There's Genesis. Does anybody, any of you, know the other book? John. In the beginning was what? Pardon me? Right. But that's, it's not a bad translation, but the Greek is logos, where we get words like logic from, where we get all the -ologies, like anthropology or psychology. Logos is intelligibility. All that is going on.
- 2.11** And what's going on is another kind of knowing, knowing by participation that's underneath. So noesis—the metaphor for that is vision—but what's underneath the noesis that makes it possible is the participation. You and the thing co-participate. You both come into the light. You're both touched by the light, the lighting. So, underneath the perspectival knowing is participatory knowing. This is knowing by participating in.
- 2.12** I keep having to use the same stupid English word: knowing. The Greeks have a different word for a different kind of knowing. But you know this word because it shows up in English words you're familiar with. So first of all, I'll give you the Greek word. I'll tell you what's a little bit scary about it. And then, I'll give you how you are actually aware of it without being aware of it.
- 2.13** This kind of participatory knowing is gnosis. What's scary about it is it's associated with this movement called Gnosticism, which was an ancient movement that was the grandest of the conspiratorial theories that we're—it's the Matrix again, by the way. This world is an evil world. We're trapped in it. It's a prison, and we need a special kind

of knowledge, gnosis, to get free from it. That sets up a whole bunch of dangerous patterns for human beings. So I'm not talking about Gnosticism.

- 2.14** But this word, you've seen it before. You go to a doctor, what are you after? Diagnosis. So, what's the doctor doing? He's participating with you. He's trying to participate in your health. That's why we talk about bedside manner. We want somebody who's going to come into contact with us. Often, the doctor has to touch us or probe us, has to have an intimate kind of knowledge, which is why we have to put all these safeguards around our interaction with doctors, because they have to have a kind of intimacy with us.
- 2.15** So, gnosis is to know by participating in the realization—both senses of the word realization—of something. So the doctor is participating in you in order to realize something in you, in order to help liberate you or heal you. So notice the doctor has got wisdom. The doctor has to see through the symptoms, see through the appearances, into the underlying reality. He has to realize—or she has to realize, sorry for the sexism — she has to realize what's really taking place, what's really going on. Gnosis.
- 2.16** But they're not sitting back doing theoretical work. They're not. They're participating. Because the point of this knowledge is for the doctor to participate in Lawrence's health so he can be restored to wholeness, which is what health means. This is gnosis. This light is ontionormative.
- 2.17** By the way, in the Book of John, the Logos is also compared to the light of the world. Okay, so this keeps going on. This light is ontionormative because it makes intelligible realness possible, and we can follow its appearances into the depths and contact, come into touch with, so that we can actually intervene in what is really going on. That's gnosis. Is that okay?
- 2.18** Now, here's something—and I go into much more detail about this in the Primacy of Beauty course—but let's just for a moment recover an ancient sense of beauty. The ancient sense of beauty was something that you could be struck by. And that was a moment of confronting a reality that was—well, Rilke says it in one of his great poems. He says, "Beauty is an angel that can kill you but decides not to." It's like, what?
- 2.19** Why? Because the ancient notion, which is very different from ours—we have a deep suspicion of appearances. Appearances can be deceiving. Reality—it's down there—and appearances are distorting and distracting. This is called by Paul Ricoeur the hermeneutics of suspicion. We're suspecting the appearances. Everybody has a secret motive, a hidden agenda. But the problem with that is that real is a comparative. I can only say something's an illusion or deception by comparing it to something that is actually real. Does that make sense?
- 2.20** So, in order to say, "That's an illusion. That's a deception. There's something else going on," in order to be cynical and modern and all of what we are right now, I have to have an instance that I'm comparing it to, an instance where the appearances don't distort

and distract, but they disclose what's real. They disclose what's real. That's the ancient model of beauty. Beauty is when appearances disclose some underlying reality.

- 2.21** So there's something going on here that is also beautifying. When the doctor heals Lawrence—I'm sorry, I'm not trying to come on to him or anything weird like that— but he gets more beautiful. He looks a lot better. So notice we're coming into the same constellations. It's been helpful because it's got us another kind of knowing, the participatory knowing that makes the noetic knowing possible, the notion of contact and participation.
- 2.22** Nevertheless, the religious framing is converging with the artistic framing and is converging with the scientific framing. But of course, the religious framing brings up all kinds of problems for us. I want to bring up one in particular, and it's a problem that goes all the way back to Plato, because Plato brings it up. He writes an entire dialogue about it. It's called the Euthyphro.
- 2.23** Euthyphro is this guy who claims to be pious and all of this. And Socrates does what he normally does. He comes and asks the person questions and gets the person—shows the person is all confused and tangled in the thinking. But what in particular comes out is what's become known as the Euthyphro paradox.
- 2.24** So when God—I'll use God rather than the gods, but the argument transfers. In fact, it's better with God than the gods. When God pronounces that light is good, let's think about this. You can almost imagine Socrates. And remember, they killed Socrates because he could be really annoying. I really aspire to being like Socrates. I wonder what that means for me.
- 2.25** So he said, "Oh, does God pronouncing the light good make it good?" So whatever God pronounces good is good, so if God says murdering and torturing—sorry, other way around—torturing and murdering millions of babies is good, that makes it good, right? "No. God's not some arbitrary despot." "So when God pronounces it good, that's because it's good independently of him?" "Yeah." Oh, so God is actually having to obey something and follow something. So there's something greater than God.
- 2.26** And of course, Euthyphro goes, "But no, that can't be right either. Nothing can be greater than—so God can't be a despot, but nothing can be greater than God." And he goes, "Ah!" And then he does what everybody does. He says, "Sorry, I gotta go, Socrates," and he runs away. I'm not going to let you run away. What do we do with that? What's going on here? Is God making it good? No. If God's recognizing that it's good, he didn't make it good. Then what's that goodness? Where did it come from? And what's God? Is God good?
- 2.27** So we can worry about that, and people do for thousands of years, but I'll give you a solution that came from what's called the Neoplatonic tradition, the tradition that we're actually bumping into again and again and again, meaning people that basically tried to integrate Plato and Aristotle and the Stoics. It was like the grand unified theory

of ancient philosophy, and it's the backbone of Christian mysticism, Jewish mysticism, Islamic mysticism. So it's really important.

- 2.28** Here's the solution. They said—and now you'll see why we're talking about this—the only way out of that paradox is not to say that God is good. It's to say that God is goodness. That's the only way out of it. And everybody goes, "Yes, that's right." And I get that. That's the only way out of that. God is goodness.
- 2.29** Okay, you solved the paradox. What does that mean? Whenever we experience goodness, are we experiencing God? They kind of said, "Yeah, you are." That's weird. I bet you don't think that when you experience something good. I just had an apple during the break. It was really good. It's gone. But something's going on here, and it's really interesting. Really, really interesting. So what they basically did is they made—they used an idea from Plato, two ideas from Plato.
- 2.30** One Plato called "the Good." This was Plato's way of talking about goodness itself, the ontionormative goodness of being that we're trying to get a grip on. And then he also had this idea of "the One." The One is his term for the really real. Why? The basic idea is what makes something to be and to make it knowable, is it being One. So this is a marker. It's One. All of its parts and features fit together to make it a marker. There's a oning from reality that makes it be, and that oning makes it knowable. Intelligible. So oning is where the coming into being and the coming into being knowing are one. And you can't know the One, 'cause it's like light. You know everything in terms of the One.
- 2.31** So this is ontionormativity. This is the really real. And then, the Neoplatonists said basically this—Plato doesn't actually tell you this, but they said that: the Good and the One are somehow at one with each other. They're not logically identical, but they're at one with each other. The really real and the ontionormative are bound. Now, we're getting pretty abstract here, but we are talking about God, so we have to stretch it a little bit.
- 2.32** Now, Christianity takes this up. It becomes Christian Platonism, or I would actually say Christian Neoplatonism. And by the way, that book I pointed to you by James Wilson, *The Vision of the Soul*, he is a conservative. I'm not going to do American politics. First of all, I'm Canadian. But conservatism for him doesn't mean some idolatry of the free market or something like that, the way it typically means. He means people who are trying to conserve the Neoplatonic tradition. That's what he's trying to do. He feels we are losing the vision of the soul. We have to recover it. That's how he is trying to conserve it and be a conservative.
- 2.33** I tell you that in case you read the book, because the first chapter is like he's trying to lay out what conservatism is, and you might not care, but there's a reason for that. Anyways, this is the tradition that he is trying to wake us up to. His point is that the degree to which we have lost touch with it and forgotten it has tremendous political, cultural, and ethical consequences.

- 2.34** Now, what's the problem? Well, there's a problem for modernity. God's very problematic. One of the hallmarks of modernity—this is the work of a great Canadian, yay, Charles Taylor, philosopher—is God is optional for us in the way God was not optional in the past. God's problematic. And even for people who believe in God—and what does that mean? That's fraught. And what is it they're believing in? So, very problematic.
- 2.35** These non-propositional kinds of knowing—gnosis, noesis—have been marginalized in the modern world. Because of those two things—this is his point—we have problems with truth, goodness, and beauty. We find them problematic. We ask ourselves, sometimes mostly semi-consciously, sometimes nervously, how can they be real? Is there real beauty? Is there real goodness? Is there real truth?
- 2.36** So now we can ask ourselves this question. Notice how we work, and then it gives us another question. And then we work, and it gives us another question. I'm following Socrates, by the way. Hopefully, you won't kill me. So why did we reject the ancient philosophical religious view that still can sing to us so artistically? Why did we reject it? Why did we reject it?
- 2.37** It seems to fit so well with the empirical data from science: Yaden's work on people in mystical experience, and that goes with a whole— he's surveying a whole bunch of empirical research. It goes with a lot of our cognitive experience. I've tried to show you it's throughout all of your experience. Why did we reject it?
- 2.38** So we have a modern framing or framework, however you want to say it, that makes ontognormativity problematic, even though there is a lot of convergence from philosophical argument, artistic endeavor, scientific evidence, religious understanding, and mystical experience. So all of these things are converging on this, and yet we find it problematic if we even think about it at all. Why does modernity do this?
- 2.39** We could have a horrible view, which is: "a bunch of evil people and conspiracy." I'm not going to do that. What were the reasons why people did this? Because we can't answer the question what goodness is until we understand why we are where we are that makes ontognormativity so deeply problematic to us when in so many convergent ways it is deeply attractive and resonant to us.
- 2.40** What are we to make of noesis and gnosis, perspectival and participatory knowing? Why are they bound up with the spiritual senses? Notice I did that, because that's a problematic word, even though almost everybody and their uncle describes themselves as spiritual but not religious these days. Do you know what that's from? That's because of this problem. Spiritual means I'm attracted to it. Religious means I don't trust the institution or the tradition. Do you see that?
- 2.41** What do I mean by it? I mean that we have imaginatively exapted our senses. That's noesis and gnosis. Noesis is the exaptation of sight. Gnosis is the exaptation of touch,

contact. That's why the doctor should exercise tact when they're examining you.
Contact, tact.

- 2.42** We're talking about vision, noesis, touch, contact, conformity, the way the light and the seer are brought together, sharing in, conform, sharing the same form, sharing in, participating in the light. Now this exaptation points to something that I'm now going to name, and insofar as I'm naming it, I'm showing you what kind of cognitive scientist I am. I do 4E cognitive science—not just me. I didn't invent it. We owe a lot to people like my good friend, who was a colleague of mine at the University of Toronto, Evan Thompson.
- 2.43** What does it point to? It points to that your cognition is actually embodied. Your embodiment matters—notice the word I just used: matters to your knowing. You are embedded in your environment. You're standing and orienting and navigating. This is constantly evolving for you, because you're exercising metastability. You're enacting your cognition. Your cognition isn't in your head. It's between you and the world, just like life. Just like life.
- 2.44** The standard 4E's are: your cognition is embodied, embedded, enacted, and extended. It's not inside you; it's between you and the world. I'm going to add a couple more E's later on, 3 more E's in fact, but right now that's the standard. So modernity is somehow pushing all of that aside, too. It's pushing all of that aside with propositional tyranny, it's severing us from kinds of knowing, and it's severing us from ourselves. The loss of goodness is not an abstract problem over there for which we should engage in ideological warfare. It's a wounding in us here and now.
- 2.45** What is it about the modern framework that marginalizes the non-propositional kinds of knowing and the embodied, embedded, and active, and exaptive, and evolving nature of our cognition? Why is it doing that? Why does the modern and postmodern framing make the ancient medieval worldview and onto-normativity so problematic? Why does it give us that suspicion and the hermeneutics of suspicion that blinds us also to beauty?
- 2.46** Do you want to live in an ugly world where there's no goodness? Of course not. So we've got to do a quick historical functional analysis of this pervasive framing. This framing is largely transparent to us. It's like my lenses. I don't see them. I see by means of them and through them. They are transparent to me, but they affect everything I can see. I'm trying to get us to do this and look at the framing and the lenses that modernity makes us wear without us even realizing it.
- 2.47** So we have the European Enlightenment—notice the word, by the way—the European Enlightenment of the 17th to 18th centuries in Europe. That's where modernity was born, the idea of modernity as in contrast to the medieval and the ancient.
- 2.48** You get the three R's: the Renaissance, the Reformation—the Reformation sets off the Thirty Years' War, maybe the bloodiest war in European history, proportionally. I mean,

World War I and World War II are bad, but the Thirty Years' War, the religious civil war, is devastating. It's because of how devastating it is that the heads of state afterwards get together and say, Let's become secular states instead of being religious states, because as long as we're religious and Protestant and Catholic, we're going to kill each other. Let's try and put that behind us.

- 2.49** The Protestant Reformation uproots us from a long tradition. It uproots us from the Neoplatonic tradition, which was held by the Roman Catholic Church. I'm not here venerating the church. So the Renaissance, the Reformation, the revolutions— the Scientific Revolution, then the Technical Industrial Revolution that's taking place in London, and then the American and French political revolutions. So we have Renaissance, Reformation, Revolution. They remake the world radically. If you want to see this in more depth, take a look at *Awakening from the Meaning Crisis*, either the series or the book.
- 2.50** What comes out of all of this is a rejection of a fundamental picture that had run through the ancient and medieval worlds. I call it the two worlds mythology. So by myth, I don't mean fable. I mean a picture that is deeply presupposed, a deeply presupposed, deeply shared picture, a pervasive and presupposed picture. Modernity has its myths as well, as we'll see.
- 2.51** What is the two worlds? It's a dualism: there is the supernatural world, and there's the natural world. Why did I draw it like this? Because super means "above." So, although this is ridiculous to do, if you ask people to point in which direction is heaven, what do they do? What are they pointing at? Mars? They're pointing to the myth. They're pointing to this. And the idea is these are totally different worlds, and they operate according to different principles. This emerges in the Axial Revolution in Greece, and also in ancient Israel, and then it gets taken into the medieval period. These terms are not unfamiliar to you.
- 2.52** What is one of the hallmarks of this change, this change to modernity? It's the rejection of this dualism. It's the rejection of having to rely on this in any way to explain or understand that. So the cosmos—that's what this used to be. What does cosmos mean? Cosmetics. Beautiful order. Beauty and goodness. It gets replaced by the universe. There's one. There's one. The Latin word for "combined into a whole," that's what universe means.
- 2.53** No two worlds. One. We can use the natural world to understand the natural world. Everything we need, we can get from the natural world. In fact, the supernatural world becomes more and more absurd to people and irrelevant. This is the hallmark of modernity. It's a rejection of a dualism.
- 2.54** Now, let's get clear about what dualism is. Dualism is a dichotomy, not merely a distinction. A distinction is when two things are not logically identical. We can't think without distinctions. That's why I'm making this distinction between distinction and

dichotomy. Size—sorry, shape and size, do they mean the same thing? Do they mean the same thing? No. Can I have one without the other in reality? No, you can't. Wherever you have a shape, you have a size. Wherever you have a size, you have a shape. So there's a distinction here, but there's no dichotomy.

- 2.55** Dualism is a dichotomy. These are separate realities, and they divide all of being. There's these two and only these two, and they are completely other to each other. This is completely different from this; this is completely different from that. That's a dichotomy. It is a separation that claims that the two parts are all that there is. But you cannot find this in this, and you cannot find this in this. Do you understand what a dualism is, what a dichotomy is? It's not just a distinction. I need you to understand this, because the reason why this was being rejected—there's all these historical reasons—the reason why this is being rejected is because they are trying to come up with a new way of understanding the natural world.
- 2.56** Now, we have to get rid of this dichotomy, this dualism, because it's drenching the world in blood. It's not going well with the scientific world that we're now getting. When I'm running any of my experiments, I'm not involving the supernatural. It's not doing well with these political revolutions that are creating secular states. If the United States government has a separation of church and state, and it's supposed to be secular, do you see? We can't keep going back. I'm trying to summarize a lot of history really quickly. So the flag of modernity is to reject that dualism. So when anybody says they don't believe in the supernatural, they are making the quintessential statement of the modern outlook.
- 2.57** Now, there's a problem. There's a baby with the bathwater problem. When you throw this out, that's the bathwater; there's a baby that's going with it. What's the baby? Well, this was doing a lot of important work. This was doing a lot of important work. It explained the appearance-reality distinction. This is how the ancient and medieval world explained the difference between what is appearance and what is really real. Why? Because this, this is a fallen world, but it's not real. It's ephemeral. It's mere appearance. This is where the reality comes from— appearance and reality. That's why you're not supposed to get attached to this world, because it's not the real world.
- 2.58** What's meaning? The reason we find things in this world meaningful—I know this is strange, but let's keep going—is because they shine from here. When something here is a sign, or for Jonathan Pageau, a symbol of this, that's what makes things meaningful for us.
- 2.59** What's wisdom? Wisdom is how to see through the illusions into the reality. Wisdom is about transcendence. What does that mean? To go up and over. We're going up and over the barrier, up and over the chasm. So we can explain people's experiences of meaning, transcendence, their experiences of the distinction between appearance and reality; this is doing really important work. So when you throw out the bathwater of

this, you're throwing out the baby of all the work it's doing for you. Does that make sense?

- 2.60** It was also explaining another problem, which the ancient world was really intrigued with, that we started with, and then modernity puts aside. It's called the problem of the one and the many. We started the course with this: how is it that there are many beings, but there's only one Being? How? How is it all one and many at the same time? Well, the answer is, the manys, each one of these comes from some One—remember the One?—comes from some One that holds it all together. It's doing all this work. It's doing all this work. But we get rid of it because of all the Rs.
- 2.61** Modernity has to somehow try and do some of that work. It has to replace the baby. So what does it do? What does it do? It generates a manifold. What's a manifold? A manifold is when each part predicts and supports the other parts—a manifold of dichotomies. A manifold of dichotomies.
- 2.62** So Copernicus says the Earth is turning and going around the Sun, and everybody freaks out. Why? Because we can all do the following: we can all be stone-cold sober, nothing wrong with our eyes, and we all agree that we're seeing the Sun emerge there, go overhead and go over there. We all agree, we're all sober, our eyes are all working, and we're all wrong. It's an illusion, a mass illusion that is so—what else is an illusion? Maybe your mother never loved you at all. See how the suspicion comes in? The hermeneutics of suspicion.
- 2.63** So what are we going to do? Well, Galileo—oh wait, wait. What's working in Copernicus? The math is working in Copernicus. We can trust the math. Does that sound familiar to you? We can trust the math. So what we have to do is we have to divide reality up into what we can trust and what we can't trust: the properties that are mathematically measurable and the ones that are not mathematically measurable. These are the primary ones, meaning we can trust them; they get us to reality. And these are the secondary ones. They don't get us to reality; they're the source of illusion.
- 2.64** So now, notice what's happening here. We've got a dichotomy between the math, which is objective, and all the other stuff that makes our experience meaningful, meaning, the way we're making sense. But that's only subjective. That doesn't exist out there. It only exists in here. These are the appearances, and this is the reality. What gets us through isn't supernatural. What gets us through is the math and measurement. That's how we can become wise. That's what gets us through.
- 2.65** So now let's put this on a board. Let's line up the whole manifold. I want you to see how this is the grammar of your life, at least your cognition. This is the grammar that you use every single day to make your way through everything. Subjective, objective—those are the master categories. You can see Descartes getting those worked out. He picks up on Galileo, basically invents a lot of modern science—experimentation, mathematical observation, astronomy.

- 2.66** This is subjective; that's where the appearances are. So we can now use subjective as saying something's merely an appearance. "Well, that's just subjective," meaning it could be an illusion because it's just an appearance. This is reality, so we will use objectivity as a synonym for reality—objectivity. This is where the meaning is; this is where the measurement is. This is mind—this is famously Descartes—and this is body. The body is objective. I can measure it. Your mind, that's all that subjective stuff. Can't do science on that. This is where the values are, because you value things; this is where the facts are. This is where ought exist; this is what is. Religion, because religion is private and subjective, what's out here? Science. These are the dichotomies that take over the baby.
- 2.67** So Kant, Immanuel Kant, comes along, influenced by especially Descartes and Locke and Hume, and says that math's a problem— that's how Galileo made the distinction— because how could I possibly know the mathematical truths? Science is about doing experiments, gathering observations. That's how we get knowledge. Where is that happening? Where is it? How many of you believe this is true? Point to it. Show me how you—point to it. Oh, see what he did? The problem is, if it's here, how is it giving me objective reality? This is Kant's central problem. Science depends on math, but math seems to only exist here. How could that possibly work? This really bothers him.
- 2.68** He has an answer, and he does it in his famous critique: the Critique of Pure Reason. In fact, he does three critiques. We're going to talk about critique. Critique of Pure Reason. You're engaging in pure reasoning here. That's the critique of it. What's the answer? The answer is— I mean, it's very complicated, so I'm giving you the gist, because that's all I need for the culture—your mind projects math onto the world. Your mind filters everything, so only the mathematical stuff can get through.
- 2.69** You're actually projecting math. If your mind can't make it mathematical, it can't get into your mind. Your mind is projecting math onto the world. So it's like, here's the world, and what he says is that we don't know what the world is like in itself. We project math onto it because that's how our mind works. That's why everything seems to be mathematical to us and why we can know that everything is mathematical, but it can only exist in our minds. That's his solution. It only exists in your mind, but you see it as applying to everything everywhere because you're projecting it onto reality. You're projecting it onto reality.
- 2.70** And so you become completely autonomous. Oh, we love that word: autonomy. That's the hallmark of the European Enlightenment: autonomy, autonomous, self-ruling, self-government. And then we want that virtue of being autonomous: authentic. Are you authentic? Are you authentic? You'd better be authentic. You'd better be completely self-governing, self-enclosed, self-interpreted, authentic. "Be your real you," whatever the hell that means.
- 2.71** This, the idea of projection: what we're doing is we're actually projecting all of this onto that. So now we get everybody making critiques. We get a guy named Feuerbach. He

said, "God is how we project our ideal version of humanity onto the world." That's Feuerbach. You say, "I don't know who Feuerbach is." You know how you get Marx? According to Marx, you take Hegel and Feuerbach and put them together. That's how you get Marx. Maybe you've heard of Marx.

- 2.72** Speaking of Marx, Marx tells you everything is a projection. It's a bourgeois projection. The fetishism of commodities and all—everything is a projection. There's a secret agenda. You're being exploited. Religion is the opiate of the masses. You get Nietzsche: God is dead. There is no truth. Everything is a projection. Everything is a will to power. Freud: You know what you're doing? You're just projecting. You really have got problems. This isn't about them. This is about you and your mother when you were 5, and you're just projecting it onto her, and she doesn't know why. Yeah? Freud.
- 2.73** When you get all these guys together, you're in the middle of the hermeneutics of suspicion, because appearances are nothing but deceptive. But remember, that can't be the ultimate truth, because you can't say everything's an illusion. That's like saying everything is tall. It makes no sense. Remember? Real is a comparative.
- 2.74** So I can only say these are illusions by comparing them to something that's real. But what's real left in this picture? Well, your autonomous self is real. "I know myself." Do you? And now you're in a really weird position that out there is real, but it's based on in here. About what's really real. Uh, uh, oh, uh, whoa! What's going on there? How's that working? How can it be simultaneously the case that what's most real is how your mind knows itself and what is outside your mind?
- 2.75** So what we get is we get the hermeneutics of suspicion, and we get what Han in his book *Saving Beauty* called—I talk about this in *The Primacy of Beauty*—he calls it the flattening of beauty. The flattening of beauty. So what does beauty become? Why flattening? Beauty becomes the smooth. The smooth. Look at how smooth this is. Look at how smooth it is. Look how smooth this is. Smooth. Everything's smooth. Why do we want smooth?
- 2.76** Well, when something's smooth, I only need to have a shallow interaction with it. I don't have to worry about any underlying depths that might be deceptive, that I might not know of, that might be threatening me. I mean, maybe I can't even get to those depths, but I can be on the smooth. It's easily satisfying, easily gratifying. So I make everything smooth. We reduce beauty, and we're into the hermeneutics of suspicion.
- 2.77** So what does that mean for us? It means that modernity is—we're going to develop this, so I'm just introducing this—modernity is, denuding the world of beauty, it's flattening the world, it's removing the possibility of ontogenormativity, and it's severing us from the world and from our own bodies. Because what it's actually doing is it's taking the grand dualism of supernatural and natural and replacing it with all these other dualisms.

- 2.78** This is where postmodernity comes in. I'm going to criticize postmodernity like I'm criticizing modernity. But what postmodernity says, it says, so you're the postmodernist, and you say, "Hey, modernist!"—you're the modernist right now—"You rejected this dualism because dualisms really mess everything up." "Yes," say the modernist. "There is no supernatural; there's only the natural." But in order to do that, you invoke a whole bunch of other dualisms, which the postmodernists call binaries. But they're just as bad. So I'm going to critique not only—I'm not only going to accept your critique of the ancient world; I'm going to critique you in your critiquing. That's how you get post-modernity.
- 2.79** So we're getting into a place where goodness and beauty are very, very hard for us to talk about, let alone God or ultimate reality. But that means all of the stuff we've talked about that is through the art and through the religion and through your experience and through people's mystical experience, what do we do with all of that? We ignore it. We put it over there. We marginalize it. Because to not do that is to fall into subjectivity and woolly thinking and not being realistic. Listen to the word: not being realistic, meaning not being on this side of the board.
- 2.80** Okay, that's the lecture. Happy place to end, eh? Maybe you have some questions.
- 2.81** In recent times, I feel like we've had a return to the understanding of vertical causation. There's been less of the flattening.
- 2.82** I've participated in helping to reinflate.
- 2.83** Yes, yes. I guess my question is, how do we bring that about more and more, and is it good to bring that about more and more?
- 2.84** Yeah, I think that's an excellent question. So I've been trying to make a whole bunch of arguments with a lot of other people like Michael Levin, Alicia Juarrero, Eric Hoel, that are basically bringing back a Neoplatonic view where we no longer have a flat world, but is not simply taking us back to the ancient view. So it's not nostalgia. It's about, can we come up with arguments that are actually germane to our best science and our best philosophical reflection and our best lived experience that nevertheless we could legitimately call Neoplatonic? I call this a post-nihilistic Neoplatonism.
- 2.85** I think it is very viable, and there is an increasing number of—not that long ago, get this, Jonathan Pageau, this weird in a really wonderful way, I love Jonathan, but he's basically like a church father from the Eastern Orthodox world of the 5th century, somehow in Canada, and he's talking about symbolism in all of this. You got this weird guy here, John Vervaeke, doing all this really weird cognitive sciences. A lot of academics, they are like, "John does good stuff, but he's always doing the weird stuff." And then, you've got Michael Levin, who's a cutting-edge biologist.
- 2.86** And we're all on Jonathan's channel talking to each other because the Neoplatonic framework is emerging in all three places and giving us a common language by which

we can talk to each other. More and more of that is happening right now. I call that the advent of the sacred. I think the sacredness is trying to come into—it's trying to be born in a new way for us, as a way for us to respond to the meaning crisis. So doing what we can to appropriately afford that advent is my answer to you. That is what I think we should be doing. That is what I have taken that I should be doing. Does that answer your question?

- 2.87** Yeah. Yeah. Is this coming back and this rediscovery inevitable then, or do we have to bring it about?
- 2.88** Oh, it's not inevitable. It's not inevitable. There's titanic forces of modernity and post-modernity at work in the world. And I don't mean like a conspiracy, ha ha ha. I mean there are whole systems that are dynamic and complex and self-perpetuating and self-defending that are in place that we're wrestling against, wrestling with. So there's a lot that has to be done.
- 2.89** Part of that is to try—part of the way of contributing to that is this course. This course is attempting to enable you to come into a philosophically profound, yet deeply livable relationship to goodness in the onto-normative sense, as a way of empowering you. And I don't mean politically; I mean in terms of giving you courage and motivation to cultivate a virtuous relationship to other people, yourselves, and the world.
- 2.90** I had one that was not as deep, but it was about—Jonathan Pageau actually talks about how we abstract ideas and bring them down. But you were kind of creating this image that the meaning and the more fundamental truths—
- 2.91** Go bottom up?
- 2.92** Yeah.
- 2.93** Yes. So what I'm actually going to argue in this course is that it's both: it's bottom up and top down. To use one of my favorite examples—and this is how your mind actually works— is this. Quickly, when I write this, as soon as I'm done writing it, you have to read it out. Read it out aloud. What does it say?
- 2.94** A cat. Here's an H, here's an A. How'd you do that? Notice, well, in order to read the word, I have to read the letters: bottom-up. But in order to disambiguate the letters, I have to know the word: top-down. So reading should be impossible to you. But you just did it because you're simultaneously going bottom-up and top-down. That's the logos. Bottom-up, top-down. That's going to be my answer.
- 2.95** And the goodness— just to foreshadow—the centrality of goodness has to be that through-line that binds the bottom-up and the top-down together. That makes realization in both senses of the word possible for you. How's that?
- 2.96** That's great.
- 2.97** The centrality of goodness.

Lecture 3: Stranded Goodness

At a glance — Stranded goodness — how modern and postmodern lenses blind us to the ontological.

- 3.1 Welcome back. So we're trying to get at why the lenses of modernity, and even postmodernity, blind us to ontonormativity. And we got into how we got into this framework that I hope seems very natural to you. This is a, this is the way you think. This is the way you eat. This is the way you live and move and have your being, right? But we're going to see that this is very problematic. This is very problematic, very problematic.
- 3.2 My point is, as we solve the problem that this causes for us, and the way we have to solve it, we have to basically smash the lenses and put on other lenses, put on other glasses. Those will allow us to see ontonormativity and perhaps also beauty again.
- 3.3 Now let's look at this. Let's look at where goodness lands for us in this manifold of dichotomies. You want your life to be meaningful, don't you? But it's over here. And good things are the things we value, yes? It's over here. And you ought to do what is good, yes? Which one of these? Goodness is stranded over here. Do you see that? Goodness is stranded.
- 3.4 Now we'll get into this more deeply, but that means, this is the opposite. This is what I need to—we've done all this so I can get you to see, this is the opposite of ontonormativity. This is the opposite of that reality and the world are good. This is, no, no. Out there, no good. Only in here.
- 3.5 See? Do you see why you can't see ontonormativity if you're wearing those glasses? Because goodness is stranded behind the glasses. There's no way to see goodness in the world or in the way reality is most real to you. And it doesn't make any sense to say that the really real is only subjective. That doesn't make any sense.
- 3.6 But let's remember Plato. We talked about this last time. We can only say that something's an illusion by saying that something else is real. We can only say that the hermeneutics of suspicion is all illusion by pointing to some instance where appearances actually disclose reality. The hermeneutics of suspicion actually depends on the hermeneutics of beauty. If there was nothing where appearance is disclosed reality. We couldn't say that's merely an appearance, because we're relying on an instance where appearances show us reality. That's beauty.
- 3.7 That is—now you understand it—the primacy of beauty. You have to start with beauty. It has that fundamental primacy. So now you can see how this course is, again, tightly wound to the other one. Because remember, I wanted to explain, how is it that all three of these are in community together—the primacy of beauty, the centrality of goodness, and the ultimacy of truth? You're going to have to wait for the ultimacy of truth. Sorry.

- 3.8** So let's see a little bit more about what's going on. So goodness is stranded over here. So Kant writes three critiques, the Critique of Pure Reason, which we've already talked about. Then he writes the Critique of Practical Reason, which talks about basically ethics, and then the Critique of Judgment, where he talks about aesthetics. And what he basically does is, he severs the true from the good and the beautiful, because this is severing everything.
- 3.9** So notice that we think that, when we're talking about the truth, it has nothing to do with ethics. We say that's the facts. So you'll hear a scientist claim, "I'm a scientist. I'm not telling you what you should do. I'm just telling you the facts." We should just—and I'm doing this because it was provocative and controversial— we should just "follow the science." Notice how tangled that is. We should, ought, just follow the science, which is only about the facts, because that's somehow good.
- 3.10** It's all mangled and a mess. But the true, the good, and the beautiful get separated from each other. So we think that they are— and here's Kant's beloved word— autonomous from each other. Art for art's sake. Oh, yes. Stephen Jay Gould: "Religion is about how things ought to be, and science is about how things are, and they have nothing to do with each other." They're independent and completely autonomous from each other. That was his solution to the problem of the conflict between religion and science.
- 3.11** Of course, there are important thinkers that said, "This is a disaster. You can't really separate truth from goodness and beauty." Let me show you. Do you want truth? Because you think it's good to have truth. Oh, wait. Truth and goodness are bound together. When I'm trying to come up with a good theory—oh, a good theory. Oh, it's hard, a good theory in science.
- 3.12** What do I need? Well, I need a model that is just right. What do you mean? I don't want to exclude anything that's relevant. And I don't want to include anything that's irrelevant in my model. That's Occam's razor. Although people don't understand Occam's razor. They think it means just get the simplest. That's too simplistic. Notice what you want. I want a theory that gets it right. If it's a good theory, nothing should be taken away from it, and nothing should be added to it. Is that OK?
- 3.13** So that's a good theory, and good theories are likely to be true. Good and true are bound together. So, that from which nothing should be added and from which nothing can be taken away—that's a good theory. Do you know what a medieval definition of beauty is? That from which nothing should be taken away, and nothing should be added. When you say, "That's a beautiful statue," you're saying, "I shouldn't add anything to that, and I shouldn't take anything away."
- 3.14** You're actually, by the way, talking about a meta-optimal grip. It really makes meta-optimal gripping possible. And notice, as I try and talk about science, I'm doing the true, the good, and the beautiful, all interwoven. So people like Habermas have been saying,

"Look, we can't have all of these separate from each other. They're not autonomous. They interpenetrate each other." But you can't talk that way, because when you talk about the interpenetration of the true, the good, and the beautiful, you're talking about the convertibility of the transcendentals.

- 3.15** And that's a medieval way of talking. And we don't talk that way because we do this. We do this. You can't separate them. So Kant had a great critic, Schelling, deeply influenced by Platonism and Neoplatonism. Schelling. Let's go over here. Here's the Kantian picture, and then Schelling says, "Well, wait. If it's all projection, how do I know the projection itself? Is there an even deeper projection that's creating that projection?"
- 3.16** And the answer is no, that's ridiculous, because the critique depends on the projection actually being what? Real. It's really there. The projection is really happening. Do you see? Not what's here, but the act of projecting. The process of projecting has to itself be real. You have to know that it's real. How does your mind know that it's real, if all your mind is ever doing is projecting? So, Schelling says this. So the fancy word for projection, for German philosophy, was ideal. That's why it's called German idealism—sorry, that's really badly written.
- 3.17** Schelling says, "We have to have the ideal that's actually also real." The ideal real. He's trying to say that there's something wrong with this model. We're dividing things that we ultimately can't divide. If I'm projecting, if my mind is projecting, my mind has to be real in order to do the projection. But how am I knowing that my mind is real? If I can know my mind is real, why can't I know that the world is real? Because the mind is over here, and the world is over there. But it makes no sense. Do you understand? It makes no sense.
- 3.18** So, people have been worrying about this from the beginning. We're going to try and collect their voices, help us to get clearer about this. We're not over here projecting. There's something real about this, but this is not the real side. If the mind is real, why is it on this side? And the true and the good and the beautiful are interpenetrating with each other. Where? How are they interpenetrating with each other?
- 3.19** So postmodernism comes from people like this saying, "Wait." As we said last time, your dualism, your dichotomy, your manifold of binaries, is just as bad as the one you rejected. So they're basically accusing—and now I'm introducing a new idea for you—they're accusing the modernists of engaging in what the philosopher Whitehead called a performative contradiction. Schelling was doing the same thing over here. I gave you an instance of it.
- 3.20** Now, the important thing about a performative contradiction is that it's not our normal contradiction. Our normal sense of contradiction is when two propositions are such that, if one is true, the other must be false. Right? They can't both be true together;

they can both be false, but that's another thing. Performative contradiction. Anyways. This is not a contradiction between propositions. That's our standard model.

- 3.21** So if I were to say this, $2 + 2 = 5$, that's a contradiction. The proposition—this is five, and this is four, and this is equal—they don't go together. Is that OK? Now, a performative contradiction is different. It's when there's a contradiction between the perspective you are participating in, the place you're in, the perspective you're participating in, the place you're standing, and what you're proposing.
- 3.22** I'll give you one because this is very abstract so far. Let's do a concrete. So here's a performative contradiction. I am completely unconscious right now. Could that possibly be true when I say it? No. Because what do I have to be in order to speak? I have to be conscious. So, where I'm standing isn't consistent with what I'm stating. Does that make sense? Where I'm standing isn't consistent with what I'm saying. That's a performative contradiction.
- 3.23** Where the modernist is standing, according to the postmodernist, contradicts what they're stating. "We reject dualisms." But you're standing on dualisms. You're standing on dualisms. It's a performative contradiction. Now, why are performative contradictions really important? Because they tell you that non-propositional knowing matters. Notice the language I use. It's when the perspective I am participating in, my place, contradicts my proposing. Here's propositional knowing, and here's the non-propositional, perspectival and participatory knowing. They're in contradiction with each other.
- 3.24** What does that tell you? That tells you that they need to fit together and be consistent. Is this landing? Is this making sense? Because I need you to understand that performative contradictions are as important, if not more important, than propositional contradictions. But all we care about in modernity, according to Whitehead, are the propositional contradictions. "Oh, you're contradicting yourself." Because we have blinded ourselves to non-propositional kinds of knowing, we blind ourselves to performative contradictions. Is that OK?
- 3.25** And so, that's what the postmodernist is basically accusing the modernist of doing—engaging in a whole series of performative contradictions. I'm going to show you this, and then I'm going to also show you how postmodernism also engages or falls prey to performative contradiction.
- 3.26** Why? Because, while postmodernism rejects this, it still presupposes propositional tyranny and the hermeneutics of suspicion. It basically says, "Yes, this is all ruined, but the only place you can live is in the ruins. Welcome." There was, I can't quite remember. There's something to the effect of a book about postmodernism called "Living in the Ruins." Living in the Ruins of Modernity.
- 3.27** So both modernism and postmodernism are making this a very inhospitable place for us to try and realize ontognormativity. I want to show you how these performative

contradictions work in this. So let's take the one made famous by René Descartes, this one. And it's the big problem of cognitive science and neuroscience, which we all hear about, and it even bumps into the AGI issue.

- 3.28** Are they conscious? Are they conscious? And then somebody will say, "But what do you mean by consciousness? And what is consciousness? And how can consciousness possibly exist?" Consciousness, consciousness is where all of this is. Subjectivity is the place of—sorry, consciousness is the place of subjectivity. It's all here in your consciousness. How can consciousness be objective? But it has to be objective, because if your consciousness isn't real, like, what? Oh, no. So that's the consciousness debate. Sorry, a lot of people are working on this. I made it sound like— but I'm trying to show you why it's so problematic. It's problematic because we're in this.
- 3.29** Let's do Descartes, the original version, because I want to show you why you can't live in this manifold. Every moment that you try to live in this manifold, you're in performative contradiction. Profound, constant, pervasive performative contradiction. It's not livable. This is basically Descartes in a nutshell. So, mind has intentionality. What does that mean? My mental states are about something. I can think about things. I can understand things. My mind is directed to something other than itself. Matter doesn't do that. It's not pointing at anything. Mind does. So no intentionality.
- 3.30** All the secondary properties are here. Remember them from Galileo? Like, the beauty of the sunset, that's here. The sweetness of the orange, that's here. All that. These were called the secondary qualities. Philosophers—now you've probably heard this—call these qualia. That's where it comes from. Consciousness is made up of qualia, like the blueness of blue and the greenness of green and what it's like to taste an orange. That's all here.
- 3.31** Are there—? No. Matter doesn't have any of those properties. I act on purpose. That's one of the things the mind has. I do things on purpose. John's thirsty. John goes over here and gets a drink. Act on—do things act on purpose in physics? No. They just happen. So no purpose. I am normative in the philosophical sense. I care about what I ought to do. Yes? You should not steal—I'm not saying you do—you should not steal. Would you ever say that to a purely material thing? "You shouldn't do that. You ought to do this." That makes no sense. That makes no sense.
- 3.32** What about, well, this has extension. This takes up space. Does your mind take up space? Well, this has electromagnetic forces. Now, be very careful here. I'm talking about your mind, not your brain. Do your ideas have electromagnetic forces? What? I mean, only people that are confused about reality think that.
- 3.33** Your body weighs something, is subject to gravity. How much does your mind weigh? [Mumbling] Lookit. These are exact opposites to each other. This is Descartes. Here's the problem: they don't share any properties by which they can come into causal contact. There's nothing from here that can touch there, and nothing from here

touches this. How could an idea move your body? "Well, it moves my brain." OK, that's another part of your body. How does an idea move your brain? "Well, my consciousness." OK, let's do it then. How does your consciousness move your brain? "I don't know, I don't know what consciousness is."

- 3.34** So, this means they can't; this is what dichotomies do. They so radically separate that they can't possibly touch each other. There's no causal contact between them. This is called the mind-body problem in philosophy. But here's the thing. It has to be false. Notice I'd be engaged—look, this is called Cartesian dualism. The mind and body do not causally interact. I just did a performative contradiction. Because I had an idea in my head, and it made my matter, body, move to make physical sound waves go through.
- 3.35** If this is true, I can't say to you that it's true. Do you see? And notice it can't possibly be true that, because John wants water, because he's feeling thirsty, that that somehow makes his body go over here and get the glass, but I did. Or here's another one. Ready? Purely physical event. "Ow," it caused pain. How much does pain weigh? What color is it? It's purely an event in consciousness.
- 3.36** So every moment shows you that this is false. And everything you do means, whenever you utter it, whenever you say "this is true," you're engaged in a performative contradiction. This dichotomy is not livable by you. Do you see that? Every moment denies it. Everything that you do, say, feel, experience, everything is a performative contradiction to that. It can't be true.
- 3.37** So the two strategies we've tried—and this is not a course on the philosophy of mind, so I'll just say them briefly— is, "Oh, this is all an illusion, and all that really exists is this. There's nothing but matter." It's like, where is the illusion? Is the illusion itself real? Remember Schelling? The illusion has to be real, not what the illusion is claiming, but the illusion itself has to really exist. Where does the illusion exist? How do you get illusions in matter? What? "Well, no. All that really exists is mind. It's all just mind." Really? And what do you do about the deep past, when there aren't any minds? Do you think that the theory of evolution is false? Do you think that atomic theory is—come on.
- 3.38** I mean, both the idealists and the materialists are growling at me right now, but they haven't succeeded. They haven't been able to convince the overwhelming consensus of philosophers and scientists that either one of those options is right, and the dualism is clearly wrong.
- 3.39** Now here's a different conclusion. Instead of saying the dualism is right, or saying the dualism is wrong but we keep the grammar, we keep the lenses, and we just smash one of them, why not say the whole picture is wrong that gets us into all of those troubles in the first place? That's what I'm trying to get you to see. Once you start to realize these two things together, all the dichotomies form a manifold; they're all bound together. I'm going to show you this, by the way, how much they depend on each other. And

once one of the core ones, mind and body, I could equally do subjectivity, objectivity, I make you suspicious of it, you should be suspicious of the whole picture. You should be suspicious of the whole picture in a really radical way.

3.40 One of the things that's really interesting about this is the way people describe these dichotomies. They always say things like, "It's the fact-value dichotomy," or "It's the is-ought dichotomy." They always prioritize the objective side, which means this looks like it's just a dichotomy this way, but it's actually a dichotomy this way. It's actually a hierarchy. How different is this from the supernatural-natural dichotomy? Is it really that different after all?

3.41 Let's take a look at the dichotomies that strand goodness. We're going to take a look at the fact-value dichotomy. And here we're going to make use of Putnam's excellent book, "The Collapse of the Fact-Value Dichotomy." Hilary Putnam, P-U-T-N-A-M. But before I do that, I want to make use of an argument by somebody who—you know, they say you should never meet your heroes. But I've met David Schindler, D. C. Schindler, and I'm happier.

3.42 One of my great philosophical heroes is a guy by the name of William Desmond, who will show up throughout the remaining lectures. Deeply, deeply influenced by him, and I got to meet him, and we've actually recorded a conversation. He's a wonderful man. I'm happy that I met him. I want to make use of something that he does. It's another way of saying what I've said to you, but it converges.

3.43 So let's take the fact-value dichotomy, objective facts, subjective value, and let's put it back into the modernist picture. So what does that actually mean? It means, there are no values in the world. There are no objective values. What do I do? I project value onto the world. Whatever meaning there is, you have to make. You make all the meaning. You make all the value. You project it. It's Kant, autonomy, projection.

3.44 But wait, I'm not satisfied, because what that means—this is William Desmond— is, I'm projecting onto a reality that is actually valueless, and projection is an illusion. So it's an illusion, and it's an illusion that is being done by me, who has no objective value or significance. That, William Desmond says, he calls default atheism. If you have that picture, I think a better word right now is, you have—and here we now finally get to it—you have nihilism. You have nihilism.

3.45 There really isn't any values. There really isn't any truth, goodness, beauty. There really isn't any meaning. There really isn't you. None of that. Because where is it in this picture? Where is it in this picture? It's not out there. It's not in the projection, because the projection is an illusion. And it's not in me because I'm objectively nothing, insignificant. Nihilism. Nihil. Nothing. There is nothing of real truth, goodness, or beauty. Nothing.

3.46 There's no real meaning, goodness, beauty, and any truth we might have is totally absurd in nature. All we have is incomprehensible power, which is ultimately absurd. So

if you want to read this in more detail, you can read his book, "God and the Between," the between. "God and the Between." Notice, in the title of the book, he's undermining the dichotomies.

- 3.47** Now notice what he's saying here, Desmond. It opens up a possibility we should take seriously. So this is classical logic. If P, then Q. P, therefore Q. That's valid. This is called modus ponens. If it's raining, then the streets are wet. It's raining, therefore the streets must be—if these are true, this must be true.
- 3.48** Now there's another valid form of argument. If P, then Q. Not Q, therefore not P. If it's raining, then the streets are wet. The streets are not wet, therefore it cannot be raining. This is also valid. This is always true, just like this is always true. These are mirror versions of each other. This is called modus ponens. This is called modus tollens. These are the two valid forms of conditional reasoning. That's all the logic I'm going to do right now. Is that OK?
- 3.49** Now let's plug this in. If the fact-value dichotomy implies or maybe even entails nihilism, and nihilism is false, then the fact-value dichotomy must be false. Do you see that? If the fact-value dichotomy implies nihilism, Desmond just showed it such that it did, and nihilism is false, then the fact-value dichotomy must be false.
- 3.50** Nihilism—I'm going to make a better argument, but just initially, to get you to think about, is this plausible? Should we take it seriously?—nihilism seems to be nothing but an endless performative contradiction. How could I know that nihilism is true? Why would it be good to believe that nihilism is true? If nihilism is true, could we actually experientially know that? Wouldn't it be absolutely, incomprehensibly absurd to us?
- 3.51** So maybe this involves a performative contradiction, which means the dichotomy must be false. If the dichotomy implies nihilism, and nihilism is just a large performative contradiction, then nihilism is, in some important sense, false, which means the dichotomy must be false. Is that OK? I'm trying to give you a really tight argument here. Now we've got to do more work on this, but I'm trying to make it at least intuitively plausible. This is what we're building on. Wait, we don't have to embrace nihilism. And if we don't have to embrace nihilism, then we should be rejecting the fact-value dichotomy.
- 3.52** Postmodernism is no help for us here, because if we remain trapped within propositional tyranny and the hermeneutics of suspicion, we disengage. We're actually not in nihilism. We engage in performative contradictions. This is a very well-known criticism of postmodernism. You do all this, then you invoke social justice. And you say, we should be doing social justice and protecting people from abuse of power. So we're invoking justice, which is good, and power, which is not good. And that's how the world is. That's how it really is.
- 3.53** Where are you standing to make that claim as a postmodernist? Where are you standing? Are you saying that reality has ontornormativity, that there's really goodness

in reality? Are you saying this is all in people's heads, and it's just an illusion? If it's just an illusion, why should I care about what you're saying? Where are you standing? What place are you in to make these pronouncements?

- 3.54** So we get the reduction of beauty and goodness, and it's wedded to propositional ideological power struggles. That's what's being offered. What do you have when you get the flattening of beauty, according to Han? You get pornography. Pornography is the easily consumable pleasure in which you have no concern for the depth of the reality. In fact, you don't want there to be any reality to the pornographic object, because if there is, they might have a secret motive. They might get you. You might have to be responsible to them. You want them to be easily consumable. Pornography is what you get when you degrade beauty to make it into the smooth. He's got a book about that called "The Agony of Eros."
- 3.55** So this is our age. We have pornographic, nihilistic, ideological bullshit. Now, that last term was meant to shock you, but I'm using it in a technical sense. I'm using it the way Harry Frankfurt has inspired a whole bunch of people to talk about this, because Frankfurt distinguishes bullshit from lying.
- 3.56** When we wrote the book on zombies as a modern myth for the meaning crisis in 2017, I wrote it with Christopher Mastropietro and Filip Miscevic. We actually did a Google search. And what happens is, the use and report of bullshit is going up exponentially. So people are increasingly feeling like the world is filled with bullshit, and AI slop is only making that ten times worse.
- 3.57** See, the bullshit artist is different from the liar. The liar depends on your commitment to truth. If she can get you to believe something that isn't true as true, that will actually affect your behavior, because you're committed to the truth, because you have a hunger for reality. It's really wrong to call a lot of what's going on as lying. Obviously, there's lying going on because human beings lie, and now with social media, we can lie a lot more, to a lot more people. But a lot of it is actually technically bullshit, because what we're actually doing is, we're doing—everything is becoming advertisement.
- 3.58** Look at a standard commercial. Let's put this alcohol. Here it is. It's a bottle. It's sitting right in the center of the shot. And for some reason, who knows why, water is on it. Oh look, it's obviously cold. And around this bottle are happy, beautiful people. They're gorgeous. And there's a mixture of men and women, so some of them have got to be sexually attractive to you. So they're attractive, and they're there. All of them are clearly sober, because they're happy and they're—and you know it's not true.
- 3.59** The way to know it's not true is to go into a bar. That's not the way it is. You know it's not true. They know you know it's not true. What's going on is, they're not trying to convince you that something is true. They're trying to get you to not care whether or not it's true, because it's so attractive to you. It's so attractive. The bullshit artist makes things attractive to you.

- 3.60** Notice how I'm playing on beauty here? They're attractive in a way that is not connected to your concern for the truth. That's how I bullshit you. I get you caught up in something that's attractive to you, while making you unconcerned with whether or not it's true. I make it salient and catchy, attractive. It's a perversion of beauty; it's a perversion. So that's what I mean when I say, our age is an age of pornographic, nihilistic, ideological bullshit.
- 3.61** This is what I call the meaning crisis. This structure of modernity leads us to default atheism, default nihilism, the meaning crisis. Because if you can't, if there is no ontognormativity, there is no place that grounds meaning. It's all just an illusion. And your pursuit of it is an illusion. And your pursuit of anything that is meaningful to you, like justice, is also an illusion. Well, we have, like the New Atheists, Richard Dawkins and Sam Harris, Alex O'Connor is, he's moved far away from—I love Alex. He grows, he changes.
- 3.62** My students, here's the hallmark of somebody who's actually rational, in a reasonable sense. They engage in deep self-correction. They will change their position. That's the hallmark of rationality, somebody who is willing to say, "I was wrong about that." He does that. But what was going on in New Atheism? Well, "truth, truth, truth. We've got scientific truth. That's what will save us. We may not have beauty, we may not have goodness, but we've got truth. We've got truth, man."
- 3.63** Yeah? So [mumbled]. Was that true? You don't know, because you don't know what it meant. There is no truth without meaning. How can you have truth when meaning is an illusion? "Well, I mean propositional meaning." Oh, so we're back to that. Let me understand your model of truth, and tell me how it's purely propositional, purely syntactic meaning; and how could that syntactic meaning actually float free of lived meaning, experiential meaning? "Well, I don't know." But let's try it.
- 3.64** What's your theory of truth, modern person? That's what the New Atheists are; they are the defenders of modernity against ancient religion and against postmodernity. That's why they hate the postmodernists as much as they hate the religious, because they're defending modernity on both ends. I'm criticizing everybody; I don't know what that makes me.
- 3.65** So, what's your model of truth? My model of truth is, inside your head, you have a bunch of propositions, and they all—that's your head, by the way; that's your mind, I should say— and they all cohere with each other. They're all logically coherent, logically, mathematically coherent—I'll just use logically. And then this corresponds to the world. This picture is the way the world really is. So I get my propositions together, and the structure they make is actually the structure of the world. So the world is actually like that. That's the coherence correspondence theory of truth.
- 3.66** And ever since Descartes and the birth of modernity, they've been arguing. Some people say, and you'll see why, this doesn't work, so it must just be this. Other people

say, this doesn't work, so it must be that. John Vervaeke is going to say to you, both sides, both of these don't work. Now again, I'm going to try and summarize hundreds of years of philosophy really quickly.

- 3.67** This goes to work done by Christopher Cherniak in a book called *Minimal Rationality*. Christopher Cherniak. How many beliefs do you think you have? Do you think you have more than 138? You probably have thousands and thousands. For example, you probably have beliefs you haven't even realized you believe. You believe that it's false that there are superintelligent mosquitoes currently building rockets to go to Mars, to move the planet to destroy us. It's false. Yeah, you believe that, don't you? Yeah. Now, I hope, I hope you'd never thought of that sentence on your own. So you have a lot of beliefs. So you have to check, and try and see if all your beliefs are possible.
- 3.68** He's shown, even if you have only 138 beliefs—just doing this for the math—and you could check between each belief to see if they're coherent, logically coherent with each other, checking all possible combinations—this is called combinatorial explosion—the number of possible combinations dwarfs anything you could do. The entire history of the universe, future history of the universe, billions of years, would not be enough time for you to check to see if your 138 beliefs were logically coherent with each other.
- 3.69** This is the problem of combinatorial explosion—so you don't require people to constantly check to see if all their beliefs are coherent. You only require them to check to see if their relevant beliefs are coherent. So we're getting into relevance realization, which, of course, we're going to get into relevance realization. So you can't do it.
- 3.70** Let's say you could. There's this other guy, Reichenbach. He pointed out that as long as your data set is finite, so non-infinite, as long as you have a finite data set, how many models that are logically coherent can you apply to that data set? Do you understand? Think about it this way. Here's a data set. Finite. How many lines can I draw on that?
- 3.71** I could draw this line, the line of best fit, which actually doesn't touch many of the dots. I could draw this line that connects some of them. I could draw this line that connects them more. How many lines do you think I can—? How many different curves could I—? Infinite. The proof is, it's infinite. So first of all, you can't do it. But even if you could do it, the chances that your coherence and her coherence are the same are infinitely small. Is that how truth works?
- 3.72** And then you'll say, well, you should—listen to your language, by the way—you should. You ought to. Good, good, good. You ought to pick this line. The line of best fit. Why? Well, because it helps me. It's relevant to my projects of generalizing, interpolating, extrapolating, etc. Relevance, relevance, relevance.
- 3.73** What about the correspondence theory of truth? Let's do it. Here's your idea in your head, and here's the world, and they correspond. So there's three parts to this. Here's the idea, the world, and the relation. So you have to see this. You have to see that your idea and the world match. Where are you standing to see that? Are you in here? No,

because you couldn't see this. Are you here? No, because you couldn't see this. Are you here? What does that mean? You can't see any of these. You can't see this picture. You can't actually do it.

3.74 Notice, let's say somehow you're out here. I don't know where this is, but here you are. You have to directly see that. You can't be representing it to yourself, or I get an infinite regress. So now this corresponds. Well, how do I know that corresponds? Well, there's another guy over here, checking it [mumbled]. This doesn't work. We have these pictures—and this is Wittgenstein. We like the pictures. We think they make sense. Yeah, coherent set corresponds to the world, matches. A picture has us in its grip.

3.75 We do this all the time; this is Wittgenstein's point. What time is it on the sun? We picture a guy on the sun, looking at his watch. That makes no sense. What time it is is dependent on where you are on the Earth. That's why I have jet lag right now. What's north of the North Pole? Let's wonder about that. Nothing. It doesn't make any sense. You can have a picture. Got some guy in space. No, that's not how north works. The fact that you can form a picture doesn't mean you understand something. The pictures are being created by the grammar, but the pictures don't work, which is another way of saying, the grammar doesn't work.

3.76 So, how can truth possibly save us? Not the modern notion of truth. You know what I need? I need something radically other than this. I need a model like the ancient model that, when I know something, what I know and my knowing of it are both participating in each other, like the way we both participate in the light. I need a contact conformity model of knowing, not this "I'm inside my head, making representations."

3.77 Look at the word. Look at the word. It's not actually present to me. I have to re-present it to myself, because the world isn't actually presenting it to me. That picture has got to go. We have to actually go back to noesis and, underneath it, gnosis—participation. We're participating in the light of intelligibility, both the world and the knower. But that would mean bringing back the centrality of goodness.

3.78 So how do we get out of this? We're locked in. The picture has us in a script, but the picture isn't working. The picture doesn't work, and it gives us nihilism, which doesn't make any sense. Literally, that's what it claims. Things don't make sense. What are you doing? Who are you talking to, and how are you talking if you believe that? It's all absurd. Was that sentence absurd? So what are we doing?

3.79 This is Charles Taylor again. I'm going to use another word that has noesis in it, and it's got meta attached to it. Meta, noesis, meta-noetic. This is the word in the Bible used, by the way, for conversion. When somebody moves from one whole way of being to a totally new way of being, "metanoia". It is going beyond the normal way in which you were doing perspectival knowing. Meta, beyond. So meta-noetic passage is, I need to do something.

- 3.80** This is Taylor's point. If I try to argue with you, within the framework, the grammar, of modernity, I can't do it, because the grammar is a picture that leads us into nihilism, into performative contradiction, and the picture makes no sense. If I try to work in there, I can't get any way of going. We'll just circle around inside the prison. I have to deconstruct. That's a bad word. That's postmodernism. No, it is, but I don't need to rely on postmodernism. I have to deconstruct; I have to take apart.
- 3.81** That's what I'm actually doing with you. I'm showing you how it was constructed, so that we can deconstruct it. We can take the picture apart. That's metanoia, and it also is pilgrimage. What I do is, I move you from here—this is standing in modernity and postmodernity—and I move you to here. This is like waking up, and I get you to look back on that picture, and you go, oh, from here I can see why that is limiting, why it was distorting, why it was preventing me from realizing. This is why pilgrimage is so important, literal pilgrimage is so important, because it helps you practice doing that.
- 3.82** So, this involves something we're going to talk more about later when we talk about Iris Murdoch. This talks about, this involves transframing, which has nothing to do with the way we use this word right now for political, ideological battles. I'm using it in the older sense. Normally, when you have an insight, here's the thing, and you reframe it, you say, "Oh no, it's not like this. We should see it like that," that's a normal insight. You reframe it. But sometimes you not only are reframing the object or the problem, you're also changing your perspective in a meta-noetic fashion. So you're not just having an insight into the situation, you're having an insight into how you have been framing things and making sense of them in general. Does that make sense? So let's do it.
- 3.83** "Oh, I thought she was angry, but it turns out she's so afraid." I'm always doing that. Why am I always making that mistake? I'm doing that—and then, you see, I'm doing a meta-noetic thing, meta-cognitive thing. I'm not just having an insight about this; I'm having an insight about why I'm not having the insights I should have. Does that make sense? That's transframing, and I'm trying to do a transframing with you.
- 3.84** We're going to, we're deconstructing this, and I'm trying to move you over here and get you to look back—perspectival and participatory knowing, noesis and gnosis—and say, just like when you wake up from a dream, "Oh, I see why that was so limiting. I see why I was so biased and constricted, when I was in that." That's what we're doing right now. That's what we're doing right now. I'm trying to give you a different place to stand.
- 3.85** I want to show you something just to make this notion of pilgrimage a little bit more alive for you. So this is the hallmark of propositional knowing theory, scientific theory, propositional structures that are coherent, that correspond to the world, and explain the world. Darwin's theory of evolution. Atomic theory. By the way, most everyday-world people use the word "theory" wrong. A theory in science is the greatest accomplishment. It doesn't mean a guess; it means the best possible explanation we have, the most plausible explanation we have for something. It doesn't mean a guess.

- 3.86** But this comes from a Greek word, of course, "theoria", which means how you look at things. It goes back to noesis. This is about contemplation. That's the more original meaning, how you're contemplating things, how you're envisioning them. Because there was a recognition that this ultimately depends on this. But here's something, and Nightingale and Ward have shown this. This has an even older meaning. So it means vision here, noetic vision.
- 3.87** What's the oldest meaning of "theoria"? You can find it in Plato. The oldest meaning is pilgrimage. That's literally the oldest meaning. What you did is, you went from here, to see something here, to behold it—listen to the word, "behold," contact, participation. To behold it. I'm holding it. And then that changed me, so I could go back and tell the people that I had left. That's the original meaning. That's what we're doing here. That's what we're doing here. We're going out and coming back.
- 3.88** I'm trying to get you beyond modernism and postmodernism, so that you can actually stereoscopically see beyond both of them from a different place, from a different place. This is going to allow us to recover. Remember the recovery theory? Remember the anthropologist going, Tolkien and fantasy? I'm trying to take you on a pilgrimage so that you can recover the ability to see and participate in ontonormativity.
- 3.89** So what I want to do is begin deconstruction without falling into nihilism. So I'm going to use some of the tools, but I'm not going to come to the same place as the postmodernist. I'm also not falling back into nostalgia. I'm not a fundamentalist. "We just have to get back to the good old days. But it was so good. Tell all about it. Let's be Greek again." I don't want to be Greek. I don't want to be an ancient Greek.
- 3.90** First of all, if you're an ancient Greek, you know how you're treating her? Horribly. Really, really badly. You know the worst place to be in the ancient world, if you're a woman? Athens. I don't want to go back to that. Neither nihilism nor nostalgia are live options for us. We're looking for meaning that is free from significant performative contradiction. That's what we'll start in the next lecture, so that's what we've got to today. Thank you.

Lecture 4: Recovering Goodness

At a glance — Recovering goodness by deconstructing false dichotomies.

- 4.1** So welcome back. Lecture 4. So we're taking a look at this prospect of trying to deconstruct all the dichotomies, as we try to do this meta-noetic passage, pilgrimage out of modernity without collapsing into either nihilism or nostalgia, all so that we can recover a living sense of ontornormativity, the centrality of goodness. So that's where we're at, and that's what we're trying to do.
- 4.2** So where we're going to begin is we're going to start with the work of Hilary Putnam. I guess I'll put his name down. I think I mentioned him already, from 2002. As you can see, a lot of this work is fairly recent, at least in philosophical terms, because this is something that's been slowly coming into culmination. So you get to benefit from that. We'll start talking about things that are at the cutting edge.
- 4.3** So this is Putnam from 2002, and his book was entitled *The Collapse of the Fact/Value Dichotomy*. That's pretty basic, eh? No mysteries to what the book's about. No cryptic philosophical titles. Now, Putnam does something very good to set us up. He begins by noting that we believe that we know what facts are. Yeah, we know what facts are. Let's be clear about that. We think we have examples of facts, but that's not the same thing as knowing what a fact is.
- 4.4** Socrates used to always do this with people. He'd say, he'd ask them, "What is justice?" And people would give an example of justice. And he said, "No, I don't want an example. I want you to tell me what justice is." So let's make sure we're—and so this is Putnam: we know what examples of facts are, but do we know actually what a fact is? If I were to ask you, "What is a fact?" What's it made out of? Does it have a color? Does it have a location? What is a fact? And how is it different than the things that the fact is about? What is a fact? What are we talking about when we're talking about a fact?
- 4.5** So what we do is we presume that we know what facts are, and then we worry about values. We don't know what values are. What are values? Are there such things as objective values? That's how people will often ask this question. You can hear all the dichotomy rumbling around in that question. Are there objective values somehow? But if there aren't objective values, then how can we have morality? And then we go on and on and on.
- 4.6** Let's stop that. That's to play the game, and we're trying to step out of it, remember? Let's ask the question that doesn't usually get asked, but Putnam asks: What is a fact? Not an example, but what is it to be a fact? Now pause for a moment. I know this is a weird class and I'm a weird person and I'm making you think in weird ways, but even beyond all of that, have you ever stopped to think what's a fact? See how transparent it is? How transparent the lenses are.

- 4.7 So here's what Putnam takes to be what people generally mean. He tries to provide an account. A fact is an isolatable set of conditions. So here's an isolatable set of conditions. Sometimes people call them states of affairs. An isolatable set of conditions, and by that we can mean events, conditions, causes, broadly. And we can point to that — some pointing, referring, designating—I'm trying to use that very general term. We can point to that in a way that will make some proposition—of course, propositional tyranny—make some proposition true. So there's some isolatable set of conditions. I can point to it in a way that will make a proposition, a belief about it, true. That's a fact. That's what a fact is.
- 4.8 So notice what this is, by the way. Do you see what this is? This is a snapshot of the modern picture of truth. Remember? Coherent, corresponding. Remember? Coherence and correspondence. And it's on the dichotomies. This is inside, and this is outside. It's a snapshot. It's from within. So the idea is you're in the picture that modernity gives you of coherence and correspondence, and there's the great divide between the subjective and the objective, and you're doing that, and that's a snapshot within it. Does that make sense?
- 4.9 So of course, the picture of modernity would give us this picture of what facts are. But I hope I've made you wary of such pictures. Like, wait, I get the picture, but does that mean it's actually making sense? Wittgenstein was brilliant to make us realize we often are satisfied, as I said, with pictures that ultimately don't make sense. A lot of our philosophical confusion is we stick with the picture that's salient and attractive rather than trying to get a deeper understanding. You know what that's an instance of? Bullshit. Because we're preferring an attractive appearance over understanding the underlying reality.
- 4.10 So let's look at this picture. Let's try and do it with an example now. I'm not going to point at Lawrence—notice I'm having to do all of this, by the way—I'm going to point at the entity that he's sitting on. I need to make that clear, because otherwise this could be weird. Here we go. There is a chair. That's the picture. Proposition: There is a chair. Point. There's an isolatable thing, and it made what I said true. Yes, there's a chair. That's a fact. Is that okay?
- 4.11 What could be more obvious? What could be more obvious? Well, first of all, can you isolate that belief? Can I actually ever have a single proposition? Imagine that there's—for the picture to be really the case, there's nothing else in my mind other than that proposition, right? That's what the picture shows, yes? But is that the case? Can I really believe there's a chair there without believing that my perception is working and that my eyes are good, that the medium is clear, the air is not distorting, that I'm awake, I'm not dreaming, that these people haven't decided to confuse me or fool me by putting in something that looks like a chair but actually isn't a chair?
- 4.12 And can I know what a chair is? A chair, that's a human artifact, a tool. Could any chimpanzee know that that's a chair? Think about that. Could any chimpanzee know

that that's a chair? You have to know about humans making tools and the fact that humans regularly like to sit in order to do things, so that means human intentions and human purposes, and this is a piece of technology, and we've been doing technology for like 4 million years. You have to know all that, don't you, in order to get there? Because again, what's a dog doing? Is it getting that that's a chair?

- 4.13 You have to have beliefs about gravity, don't you? The solidity of the chair. Electromagnetic resistance, if you are more educated. Inertia. Friction. He can sit on the chair because there's inertia and friction, yes? You'd be surprised if you tried to sit on the chair and it just skidded away from you, or as you tried to sit on it, it started floating up towards the ceiling as if it was made out of a helium balloon or something.
- 4.14 You have beliefs about light and the lighting in the room. It's clear. I'm sober. I have beliefs about my culture. This is a normal thing in my culture: a chair. It's not normal in the Aboriginal world. Do you see a lot of chairs in the Aboriginal world of Australia? No. They sit down, but they don't have chairs.
- 4.15 Think of all of those beliefs, each one of them. Your beliefs about gravity—can you isolate your belief about gravity, or is it bound up with a lot of things like mass and the way planets move? And what about friction? Do you see what happens here? Your beliefs are interwoven with all your other beliefs.
- 4.16 And so, here's this vast network—do you like my precise and helpful diagram?—and you go, "Pay attention to that part." How do you do that? How do you do that? Well, you're bumping into something we keep bumping into that, of course, I'm going to keep referring more and more to as we go on, which is you do, "That's the relevant". Those are the relevant beliefs to foreground, and then there's a bunch I can background, and then there's a bunch I can ignore. I'm doing relevance realization. Does that make sense?
- 4.17 Well, what about the state of affairs? Okay, okay. Yes, I get there's all that in there. But at least there—I won't kick it or anything because Lawrence is on it—chair. Can you point to an isolated state of affairs? Let's take a famous event: the sinking of the Titanic. We make a highly overrated, pretentious movie about it, and it drives the culture crazy. I think it was the 7th movie. We've made two or three more since then. We're obsessed with this event because we think it was portending the end of the belief in technological progress, and it was foreshadowing World War I and dark, dark and all this stuff.
- 4.18 Okay, that looks like that's a fact: the Titanic sank. What caused the sinking of the Titanic? What caused it? Well, the ship hit an iceberg, which means the ship had to be traveling at a certain speed. Why was the ship traveling at that speed? Because the British and the Americans are competing for dominance of the Atlantic. So you've got two world empires that are in competition. But the British steel has got impurities in it because the coal that the British are using was laid down in a particular way hundreds

of millions of years ago, leading to the impurities in the metal that made it fragile at that speed to hit that mass of iceberg. And particularly the temperature of the water, which is due to how much water is there, the salinity of the water, and the distance of the Earth from the Sun, and whether or not Sunspot activity has been happening. And the iceberg is there because there has been variation in that going back hundreds of thousands of years that caused an ice age. And the iceberg happened to break at a particular time because of weather patterns in the Northern Hemisphere. And then the currents, which are caused by the gravity—

- 4.19** What caused the sinking of the Titanic? Here's the actual answer in terms of the physics of reality: the entire previous history of the universe. That's what caused the sinking of the Titanic. In fact, that's the weird thing, and this is something that Whitehead was very good at. Every single event is caused by the entire previous history of the universe somehow coming to that event. Do you see that?
- 4.20** So what is actually out there is an incomprehensibly vast and complex causal network, and you just go, "That little bit." What are you doing, by the way, when you do "that little bit"? You're doing relevance realization. You say, "I'm only paying attention to those causally relevant features that are relevant to my attempt to generate an explanation," and an explanation is to make information relevant to you so that you can understand something, such that you can answer a question that is relevant to you. So you're doing tons and tons of relevance realization. Does that make sense? Notice, none of this can be optional. None of this can be optional.
- 4.21** But still, can't I— there's pointing going on. Well, let's do another example of pointing. Ready? Okay, here we go. Fiddlejit! Fiddlejit! What are you saying? What are you thinking right now? What the hell is he pointing at? Am I pointing at that side of the room? Am I pointing at that stand? Am I pointing at the top of the stand? Am I pointing out that actually somebody's supposed to be there and they're not? What am I pointing at? Oh geez. I'm pointing at whatever happens to be relevant to you and I in terms of shared problem-solving right now. I can't just point. That's way too multiply ambiguous. So I have to do, guess what? Relevance realization.
- 4.22** And when I say anything to you, to make sure we're coordinated, I have to use relevance realization, because I can't say everything to you. I always have to convey way more than I'm saying. I have to rely on you to make inferences and implications. What's a fact?
- 4.23** Here's another one. There— I started it with, "There's a chair." How does that work? This is called demonstrative reference. So notice, there's words like this: cat, which is the meow creature, the land shark with a brain that pretends to love you. But when I do that, it doesn't pick out anything, does it? It depends on the context. It depends on how you are oriented to what is important.

- 4.24 If I can get Jake to orient in the same way, like there, and he's trying to think, "What's important to John right now, right? Can I orient in the same way?" But if I do this there, "Uh-oh, no, what was that?" So that all depends on relevance realization and him and I communicating in a way that we can find something co-relevant together, so we can orient and attend to it together, and we can pick up on what's important.
- 4.25 But even all of that. Now, we've got the object. What am I pointing to? Am I pointing to the marker I need right now? Am I pointing to a human tool? Am I pointing to a product that's sold in the United States for profit? Am I pointing to something that I could use to stand for the letter I? Am I pointing to something that I could play with as if it was a rocket ship? Am I pointing to something that if Lawrence suddenly loses it, I could throw it at his eye? I hope that won't ever happen. What am I pointing to? How many aspects does this have? And actually, how many aspects can you see? It's combinatorially explosive. So you have to—oh, you have to do relevance realization to pick out the right aspect.
- 4.26 What's a fact? What's a fact? Is it a simple thing at all? Or is there so much going on outside the picture, not included in the picture, that actually makes the picture possible? Did you understand that? There's so much going on outside the picture that's not included in the picture that makes the picture actually possible. So it's a bad picture in that way. But all pictures actually work that way to some degree.
- 4.27 Let's still try to save this. I'm trying to, I'm really steel-personing the modernist. Okay, right, all of that. But maybe, still, what we can come up with is, we don't have a single sentence, a single proposition pointing to a single thing. What we have is a vast network that hangs together logically and coherently, that picks out a causal network in the world in a fashion, and it isn't a simple pointing. There's all kinds of checks and balances.
- 4.28 So, what you move to is you say that what's going on is that there are theories that are being confirmed by sets of facts in the world, like what science does. Facts is what science produces. I'm still not convinced that addresses any of the problems we've brought up, but let's go with that just in case. Because I'm a Canadian, I like to be polite when people are trying to steel-person.
- 4.29 So, let's take a look at it. How do we do theories? I'm going to keep doing this. Every time the modernists chunk something out, I'll go, "Okay, let's take a look at it." Because what am I trying to get you to do? Step back, step out, look back. Yes? Pilgrimage, meta-noetic passage.
- 4.30 Let's take a great theory. There was a series— I'm much older than you, so this was like in the '70s on the BBC. Your parents probably weren't even together in the '70s. I'm old, death approaches. But in the '70s, there was a great series called The Voyage of Charles Darwin. It was about Charles Darwin. I would have loved to be Charles Darwin. Imagine, you sail around the world, an amazing adventure. You get to be a scientist as

you sail around the world, and then you just happen to come up with one of the greatest theories of all time. I mean, that's a pretty good life.

- 4.31** So let's do Darwin's theory of evolution as an example, and we're going to keep coming back to this theory of evolution a lot. Well, how does it actually work? The way it works is—I'm giving you a view that a lot of historians of science and philosophers of science have converged on. It's not the absolute that everybody accepts, but historians and philosophers never have an absolute. So I'm giving you what many people take to be the most plausible.
- 4.32** The process is called the inference to the best explanation. Inference to the best explanation. It goes like this. You notice some phenomena in the world, and why I brought up the series is you can see Darwin doing what I'm going to do with you now. You watch the series. He doesn't just observe a bunch of things and then come up with the theory of evolution. That's not how it works.
- 4.33** So here's a phenomenon. There are goats, and goats are really fitted to their environment, really well-fitted to their environment. This is usually couched in language that's a little bit confusing; they're really well designed. What's an explanation for that? One explanation is wind: wind constantly mixes things together, and wind mixes things together and makes a goat. Well, maybe? Not a very good explanation. Maybe erosion. Well, that's not a very good explanation. Maybe lightning strike. Very good, so you try all that.
- 4.34** And then, before Darwin, you have that, maybe, there's a superintelligent designer. Just like if I come across a chair, how was that made? Or I come across a watch, how was that made? Oh, there was an intelligent designer. This is a guy named Paley. I want to say something to you. Before Darwin, you should believe Paley because the competing explanations are crap. They're bad. Everybody that was rational pretty much believed in intelligent design. God, for the religious version of that, made the goat. Because the alternative— do you really think wind could have done that? Or a lightning strike, or erosion, or an earthquake? None of the self-organizing processes in nature seem to do that.
- 4.35** But then Darwin comes along and says, "Wait, I have a better explanation. I have a better explanation because my explanation doesn't require a supernatural superintelligence, which is very hard to get independent evidence for. It just requires a process of natural selection, variation and natural selection and goats reproducing and that will change one organism into another over enough time. So he discovered a self-organizing process we can't currently observe because it happens so slowly. But he was able to put the pieces together and gather the evidence. This was the thing: he could explain the fossil record much better, and he could explain bad design as well as good design.

- 4.36 What do you mean bad design? Okay, how do humans reproduce? They squeeze a baby out through the birth canal in such a fashion that the baby almost dies or the mother almost dies so that before medicine there was a considerably higher chance that the mother and/or child would die. That's pretty crappy, don't you think? And the baby is born radically premature such—don't even contemplate this; this is just for the point. Because like when you're a parent, you're aware of this. If you pick up like a newborn and you shake it, you'll kill it. That's how helpless they are. And they're gonna be helpless for, gonna be dependent on you for 15 years minimum, and if you turf your kid out when they're 15, you're some kind of monster. Nowadays it's like 25.
- 4.37 Why that design? Why would God do that? You know what we figured out? We figured out doors. It's really a bad design. Why is that design? Because we have two evolutionary things. We're developing bigger brains, and bigger brains say bigger birth canal, because you have to get the big brain out. But we're also bipedal, and we're bipedal because we have bigger— because we're bipedal, we develop bigger brains, and because we have bigger brains, we exploit our bipedalism. But bipedalism means you want to keep the pelvis narrow, because if your pelvis gets wide and you're bipedal, you waddle. So you get a slightly wider pelvis for women. And then, you get the baby born as prematurely as possible. And then, you psychologically evolve the male—pretend you two were procreating— the male and the female together so that when this little blob comes out, you look at it and go, "This is the most wonderful entity in the entire universe. I will dedicate my entire life to them." It's a bad design.
- 4.38 Evolution explains bad design and good design, so it wins over all of these. This is inference to the best explanation. Notice what this is not. This is not enumerative induction. I haven't gathered a million instances and come to a conclusion. It's not deduction. To make this deductive, how many explanations do I have to rule out? All of them. How many are there? Combinatorially explosive. So you pick the one that does the best job of realization, which I taught you last, last three lectures: inference to the best. Which means every scientific theory is very liable and has to date to being replaced by a better explanation. That's what actually happens. Does that make sense?
- 4.39 So this whole process is dripping in generating explanations and then putting them into competition in terms of how good they are at zeroing in on the relevant information and helping us connect to reality better. Do you see that?
- 4.40 Maybe all of that's the case, but still, isn't that pretty direct? No, because if I'm trying to confirm this, let's say with an experiment, notice there's a problem. I'm going to do an experiment, and I'm going to test a hypothesis. Do I test any old hypothesis I could possibly generate? Like, "I wonder if the number of times I think about milk has any relationship to variation in the red spot on Jupiter. I wonder if that's related." Do you care about that? No. In fact, how many of those can you generate? How many hypotheses about possible facts can you generate? Combinatorially explosive.

- 4.41 So science doesn't pick any—we don't just sit around. You pick a plausible— for those of you who want to go more in depth into plausibility, look on the Peterson course on general introduction to intelligence, where I explain what plausibility is in depth. I'll suffice it for here to say it deeply depends on relevance realization. So, plausible hypothesis.
- 4.42 Now, once you're in the experiment, you have to control for confounds. Confounds are possible alternative explanations to your hypothesis. Do you pick all possible confounds? No, combinatorially explosive. You pick the plausible confounds. Then, I run the experiment, and I get a bunch of results. How many interpretations can I give of this finite data set? An infinite number that are logically equivalent. I pick the ones that are most plausible, most relevant. Am I done yet? No.
- 4.43 Now I have to go through peer review, where people decide whether or not my conclusions are relevant, plausible for the community. And then, I have to take that and go into theoretical debates. Do I debate with anybody? Believe me, John Vervaeke has learned, as he's gained a presence on the internet, you don't debate everybody because that would be my life. I'd have to debate with—I get hundreds of emails every day with people saying the most bizarre things to me, "I've figured out blah, blah, blah, blah." I have to judge: which one of these are worthy of my attention? Plausibility before, through, during, and after the experiment, and it's all dripping with relevance realization. Relevance realization, relevance realization. Is that okay?
- 4.44 There's still more problems. This is Quine, and making use of an earlier philosopher of science, Duhem. Let's say I have a hypothesis, and I run the experiment, and it doesn't confirm my hypothesis. Maybe that's what facts are. Facts are when we get confirmation of a hypothesis within a theoretical experiment. Yeah? Well, wait, how does that work?
- 4.45 I don't know if they still make you do this, but if you take physics in high school, when I did it, you had to try— so here's a principle of physics: the conservation of mass, conservation of matter and energy, but right now conservation of mass. You do the chemical experiment, and you measure everything carefully before the chemical experiment, and you measure everything after, everything, and they should be equal. How many students in that high school class actually get that right? No one. Everybody, "No, it's not, they're off, they're off." "Mine's heavier than I started with." "Oh, I lost." Do we call—I don't know who we'd call, the Nobel Committee or something? "Look, we've refuted the principle of the conservation of mass." Is that what we do? Of course not. We say, "No, no, no, no. This is such a good principle. It explains so much." We keep the principle, and we reject all these experiments. Why? Experimental error. All of those students made mistakes. We bring in an auxiliary hypothesis to explain the disconfirmation because we don't throw away any and all disconfirmation.
- 4.46 Disconfirmation is weird. So Lawrence says to me, "I have a hypothesis. Salt dissolves in water." And I go, "Haha! I challenge you." And he goes, "Well, watch." He gets some

water, and he's about to pour some salt into it. I spray plastic on the salt as it's going in, and it doesn't dissolve. And I go, "Haha! I refuted you." And he goes, "No, I didn't mean that. I mean salt that hasn't been sprayed with plastic dissolves in water." I go, "Okay, let's do it again." He goes, "Okay, ready?" As he's about to pour the salt, I flash freeze the water into ice, and the salt sits on the surface, and I go, "Aha!" And he says, "No, no, I didn't mean that. I mean salt that isn't covered in plastic that goes in water that hasn't been flash frozen." And I go, "Aha!" He goes to pour the salt in again, and right before he does, I douse it with so much salt that it's saturated, and the salt just goes in and precipitates out immediately. And I say, "Aha!" "No, I mean salt that's poured into water that already doesn't have salt." How many of these can I generate?

4.47 All these counterexamples, you don't count them as counterexamples because you say, "That's not a relevant counterexample." That's not relevant. That's not relevant. That's not relevant. Have I convinced you? This picture proposition, point, thing over there, that's it—no. The whole process is deeply, deeply dependent on relevance realization. Throughout, massively, and every attempt to get out of it keeps weaving back into it. Does that make sense?

4.48 Now, we're going to make a more advanced argument, but let's just intuitively play with it. Is relevance a fact or a value? Is relevance out there objectively? So, I just made that relevant to you, but if it's objectively relevant, that's a property it always has. So it's always been relevant to you, and it will always be relevant. So for the rest of your life, you'll be focused and considering this because it is relevant to you. Or is it quite possible that it will never be relevant ever again to you for the rest of your life? The second, yeah? Good, because that would be weird.

4.49 "Well, then, relevance is purely subjective, which means it's just my preference, which means I can't get it wrong. I can't be wrong about what's relevant." So, you can't say—you can't actually have a moment of insight. You can't say, "Oh, I thought she was angry, but she's actually afraid. And what I thought was relevant doesn't turn out to be relevant. What I took to be salient doesn't actually connect me with reality."

4.50 So relevance isn't subjective, because you can be wrong about it, very wrong, and you frequently are. In fact, you very frequently are. And it can't be objective because how is it there in the object? How would you—Lawrence: "I've got the relevance meter. Beep, beep, beep, beep, 17 units of relevance." Can he do that? You'd go, "Lawrence, you need to go home. You need to get some help. You need to rest." Relevance isn't subjective or objective. It's not a fact or a value. We've already had this term: it's transjective. And you think, that's weird. Well, is it?

4.51 Let's take two other areas. Let's go back to Darwin. Darwin's theory is that creatures survive because they fit their environment. They're adapted to their environment. Adaptation. Now, is the adaptation in the organism? Great white shark, drop it in the Sahara Desert. What is it in 10 minutes? Dead. The adaptivity is in the ocean. I drop you in the ocean, the middle of the ocean, what's going to happen to you? Dead. Where is

it? It's not in the subject, it's not in the objective environment, it's in the fittedness of the organism to the environment. It's the real relation of fittedness, of adaptivity. What if relevance realization isn't biological evolution, but how you are cognitively evolving, how fit your framing is to the world? What if that's what's going on?

4.52 Here's another thing that is transjective. So we've got relevance realization, we've got adaptivity, we've got another thing from perception. This is the work of J. J. Gibson. I was fortunate enough to study psychology with John Kennedy, who was J. J. Gibson's greatest protégé. It's one of the great lucky events of my life. We ended up publishing quite a few together. Gibson is one of the psychologists that helped launch, remember, 4E cognitive science? We talked about that.

4.53 Gibson talked about that, what we actually are perceiving aren't objects. We're perceiving affordances. "Hold the glass." The glass is graspable. That's what my perception actually is doing. Why? Because realizing that the glass is graspable actually orients me and shapes me, shapes my agency so that I can act to get what I want. The glass is graspable, and it will carry the water. Does that make sense?

4.54 Now, where is the graspability? That's the affordance. Is the graspability in my hand? "My hand can grasp anything. I will now grasp the Sun." No. The graspability is in the cup, the glass, because we made it—notice the word I'm going to use here—to fit the human hand. But can anything grasp that? Do you think a fly can grasp that cup? No. What about a blue whale? No. Where's the graspability? Well, we already saw it. It's in the way my hand and the cup, the glass, really fit each other. Fit is to contact, to conform. It's not to correspond. Do you see that? The word connect means to touch. Two things are touching each other. Does that make sense?

4.55 So we have to go outside the modern picture of coherence-correspondence. We're back to the ancient picture of participation, of fittedness, of conformity, of the two things participating in something together. They're participating in the affordance. They're participating in the adaptivity. They're participating in the relevance realization. Perspectival and participatory knowing, noesis and gnosis, at the core. And we have to give priority to this, the transjective, which doesn't fit into the fact-value dichotomy at all. Do you see that?

4.56 In fact, most of life, most of perception, and most of cognition don't actually fit into the picture of the fact-value dichotomy. The picture is presupposing things outside the picture that are not included in the picture. Maybe we can't find goodness because in some sense it's transjective. Maybe it doesn't land into those categories we want it to, or we demand it fit into.

4.57 Okay, the modernist is getting a little bit frightened here. But still, "Objectivity!" People start sounding very sonorous, or they start, for some reason, they like to bang on tables when they're saying this, when I'm arguing with them. As if somehow that shows something. It's like, yes, I get that you can bang on a table, but do you understand what

has to be the case for you to bang on a table and for me to find it meaningful in this act of communication and argumentation? Like, if the cat came in and started pounding on the table, would it mean the same thing? Not at all.

- 4.58 Let's try and save this. What do we mean by objectivity? This is what I mean by objectivity. I mean that it's how it looks, no matter how you're looking at it. Free from any particular subjective perspective, that's how it is objectively. That's what I mean by facts. All that other stuff you were doing, with Putnam and Vervaeke, was all about perspectives, like you said, and I'm saying objectivity is how the world is free from any perspectives. That's what I mean by facts. Everything else is subjective valuation.
- 4.59 So you give me another picture. I'm going to do what I'm going to always do. I'm going to step back and look at this picture that you find so attractive. What you're basically saying is—this is what Nagel describes this picture as, Thomas Nagel—the view from nowhere. You're not anywhere. First of all, that's problematic. That's why he chose it. But let's try and make clear why it's problematic.
- 4.60 If I were to have this picture, this view from nowhere, what it's giving me is a description. It's giving me a description that would be just the facts. That's what it's claiming. What is the view from nowhere? It's the description of Everything Everywhere All at Once because anything else means a perspective has slipped in that selected some things rather than the other. So this has to be everything everywhere all at once, which, of course, might make you think of a recent movie, which was about nihilism.
- 4.61 Let's take a look at this picture, the view from nowhere. That would mean, presumably this is a rational picture; it's not absurd, because if it was absurd then we'd have problems. So that means it would be a formal system. It would be logically consistent because if it has all kinds of inconsistencies in it, then we're back to what's going on? How is it everywhere, everything, all at once? So it has to be logically consistent. And it has to be complete. There can't be anything missing from it, because if there's anything missing from it, it's not the view of everything everywhere all at once. So what we're saying is what we have is a formal system that is logically consistent and complete.
- 4.62 Except we have a guy by the name of Gödel who logically proved that that's impossible. That's his incompleteness theorem. For every formal system, he proved necessarily the case that it's incomplete. There are truths that you can state that you cannot actually generate within that system that are nevertheless true of it. So if it's consistent, it's incomplete. And if you claim it's complete, that means it's secretly inconsistent. So guess what? The view from everywhere of everything all at once is logically impossible.
- 4.63 But there's more. Does this make any sense in physics? Everything everywhere all at once? No, you have this guy named Einstein who actually became famous by making us realize that there is no absolute space and time. There is no way of saying everything everywhere all at once. That's what the theory of relativity completely and utterly

denies. That's called absolute space and time. There is no such thing in physics. So it is physically impossible.

- 4.64 But now you have other problems. You have complementarity problems. Light is both a wave and a particle. And if you see it as a wave, you can't see it as a particle. And if you see it as a particle, you can't see it as a wave. How do you see everything everywhere at all at once then? You can't.
- 4.65 What about uncertainty? Whenever I try to view anything, I can't be certain about it because the act of viewing actually disrupts it. So this is actually, if you put in quantum mechanics, you also get that it's epistemically impossible. We can't know this because of complementarity and uncertainty. And you say, "Okay, but maybe at least this is an ideal. I get it." I mean, this is pretty impossible, right? Logically impossible, physically impossible, epistemically impossible. You know what I kind of think is a good rational principle? Don't believe in pictures that are so impossible.
- 4.66 "But, maybe it's an ideal." So last-ditch effort to defend this. "I get it. It's impossible, but maybe it's an ideal we can aspire to." An ideal is—oh, by the way, you're thinking in fact and value, something you ought to do. So first of all, you've given up the game.
- 4.67 Secondly, ought implies can. If I say you ought to do something, it implies that you can do it. I can't obligate you to do something that is impossible for you to do. So we're talking about practical impossibility here. "You shouldn't be the age you are. Stop it!" That's ridiculous. It doesn't make any sense. Can you do this?
- 4.68 Is this practically possible for you, or would you not face an incomprehensible combinatorial explosion that would overwhelm even the best relevance realization? So this is also finally in the end, even though we're already sneaking back in valuation, it's also practically impossible.
- 4.69 So here's what I say about that. If that's your notion of objectivity, I reject it. But that doesn't mean I'm advocating for subjectivity. I reject the picture. I reject the picture. So now you say to me, "But what I meant is people should try and overcome being deceived, self-deception and illusion." And I say, "That's what you mean by objectivity, that people should be as rational as possible. I agree with you. I think that's great." So what we mean by objectivity is that people are being as rational as possible.
- 4.70 But is that really objectivity, or is rational transjectivity about zeroing in on what's relevant in a way that really connects you and fits you to reality? Ah, rationality is transjective. So in the very end, we're talking about getting better at transjectivity when we try to give our last final version of what we were trying to picture with this notion of objectivity. How's that?
- 4.71 Notice I don't have to throw out rationality. I don't have to throw out reasonable. In fact, relevance realization, rationality, caring about what's real, caring about truth, become even more important in what I'm talking about. I'm not going into nihilism

here. And I'm not going back to, "Let's just believe what we used to believe." That's not what's happening either. Neither nihilism nor nostalgia. Both of those destroy goodness.

- 4.72 So the modernist reaches for another thing. All right, I get it. The "no place" of this doesn't work, but maybe there's another way of finding a place that will give me objectivity. What I mean is that there's a place that is absolutely certain, and I can derive all my beliefs logically from that place, and that's what I always meant by objectivity. I find the place of certainty—it's called the foundation. And then, I do logic, because logic maintains certainty, deductive logic, and I deduce out everything from that foundation, and then that, that's what I meant. I didn't mean any of this. You're right, John, this doesn't work; it feeds you back to transjectivity, but what I mean is foundationalism.
- 4.73 You'd be really clever to say that because this is exactly what all the founders of modernity in the European Enlightenment thought: Descartes and Locke and Kant, but especially Descartes and Locke—Descartes rationalism, Locke empiricism, the two founding fathers of modern science. Foundationalism, we finally got to it. We're back to Descartes and Locke and what they originally proposed, the original picture.
- 4.74 So we have the foundation that is certain, and then we have a process that works certainly, and then we build out from it. It might not give us everything everywhere all at once or any of that stuff, but that's what I meant. And the facts are what follow from the foundation. The facts are what follow from the foundation. So, first of all, why did the founders of modernity come to this? They had an idea that's part of propositional tyranny. They claimed to get it from Plato, but they didn't read Plato well because Plato—what Plato would do is he'd have people make a proposal, a definition of something, and then Socrates would tear it to bits. And then, Socrates would propose a definition and then tear it to bits.
- 4.75 The lesson wasn't that Plato was giving the right definition. The lesson was trying to get to this through propositional knowledge alone was wrong. I'm not the only one that thinks this. This is what many Platonic scholars are coming to. The Enlightenment misread Plato. Plato wasn't proposing definitions. He was doing something like a Zen koan to get you to give up trying to give purely propositional accounts of what it is to know. You can take a look at the work of Gonzalez and Drew Hyland, just a whole bunch of people.
- 4.76 But Locke and Descartes took that knowledge was justified true belief, so totally propositional, justified true belief. The problem with this is that it doesn't work because of this term. You can get things that are justified and true, and you believe them, but they don't count as knowledge.
- 4.77 There's a famous set of problems called the Gettier problems. So, Jake looks out onto the lawn, and he sees an orange curved surface, and he thinks there's an orange ball on

his lawn. Now, normally, seeing is good evidence for something being the case, and he sees something that reliably picks out orange balls. But what's actually there is half of an orange sphere that somebody's cut, and then directly behind it is an orange ball. Do you get it? So is it true that there's an orange ball on the lawn? Yes. Does Jake have a belief that there's an orange ball on the lawn? Yes. Does he have evidence for it? Yes. But does he actually know about the orange ball that's on the lawn? Nope. Nope.

- 4.78 That's frustrating, don't you think? Notice what's going on because he's somehow not in contact with the ball. Do you see that? The non-propositional conformity in contact is missing. And that's why these weird problems—they're called Gettier problems, name of a philosopher—get to us. Sorry for that pun.
- 4.79 So what happened is, first of all, this is suspicious right from the beginning. I just showed you why. But let's say it isn't. What happened is they looked at this. Now, I want you to notice something about this. Justification—where did that word come from? The Protestant Reformation. It's a religious word. I am justified through faith, not by works. This is the great proclamation of Luther. Justification means that you have done— something has happened to you. It's actually what Jesus and God have done that has restored you to the right state. You have been put into the right state for salvation.
- 4.80 Justification then also becomes a moral term. "Hey, you shouldn't have done that." "No, I'm justified in doing that because look, if I didn't hit him, he would have hit her." And the court goes, "Yeah, you're actually justified. I return you back to innocence." Do you understand? It's a religious and moral term, and then it gets taken over into science and epistemology.
- 4.81 Now here's the thing. Justification requires evidence and argument, or faith, if you're Luther, that it's supposed to somehow—we'll come back to faith—go beyond evidence and argument. But it's like that. So Locke and Descartes aren't going to do this because they're trying to make this secular. So they say, "I have evidence for the belief, an argument that's to be justified." But then somebody says, "But don't I have to believe this?" Well, yeah, you have to believe that evidence, an argument. And what do you believe? You believe that it's true, and you better be justified in believing that it's true. Uh-oh, what have we got going on here? We have an infinite regress. I have an infinite regress. I can never get justified, which is a good definition for hell.
- 4.82 So what I need is I need something that stops the regress. Here's the thing that I don't need to justify, that can justify everything else. That's the foundation. That's the foundation. What am I looking for? This is a religious term. What are Descartes and Locke wrestling with? They're wrestling with the anxiety that is being created by all of the things that are happening—the Reformation, the Scientific Revolution, all of it. Remember when we talked about Copernicus and the Sun? Anxiety, anxiety.

- 4.83 What people used to have is they used to have a sense of faith, a sense of participation, a sense of contact. We don't have that for Descartes and Locke because we're trapped inside the closet of our mind, getting postcards somehow, that we then assemble in a way that we think will somehow picture the world. How that works is—we've already seen it. So what they want to do to alleviate the anxiety is give us certainty. So this justifies, because it is certain. That's what stops the anxiety and stops the regress: the certainty. Certainty.
- 4.84 Certainty. We have to take this really strongly. Certainty means it's impossible for it to be false. It's impossible for it to be false. And then, I build everything from this in a way that operates with certainty, logical deduction. That is the picture. And now the modernist has their last defense. That is how we get the facts.
- 4.85 We're going to come back next time and take a look at that picture. Step back and look at it, and ask ourselves: Does that picture actually work? What do you suspect is going to happen? It actually falls into performative contradiction and undermines itself completely. All right. That's the lecture.
- 4.86 Can you help me organize my thoughts? Because how I'm relating to this is now into faith and religion. So that foundation is certain. And maybe most people would connect with certainty is God because God can see everything all at once.
- 4.87 That's a very good thing. Notice when we try to do the— I'm trying to remember who it was—Putnam. We're trying to be God when we do the view from nowhere. That's the shadow of good God. So, what we have to ask ourselves—this is excellent, and the connection you made is totally pertinent—what we have to ask ourselves is, does faith mean belief in certainty without evidence and argument?
- 4.88 Let me say that again, because your question is really central. And this is how we're not doing nostalgia. And I hope you all know I am not here to undermine anybody's religious orientation or faith. In fact, that's not what I'm trying to do at all. Is that really clear? So we have a view currently—and I'm not saying this is yours. I'm just going to put it out there, as if someone says it, because I don't want to burden you with it, but if you want to defend it, you can.
- 4.89 What I mean by faith is I believe that something is certain, but I don't have any evidence or argument. What might be an important problem with that? That's from within the picture. That's from within the picture. This is a modern—so this is really important. This is a modern notion of faith. This is a notion of faith that comes into existence during the European Enlightenment, and it's convinced us that it's what faith has always meant. What I'm going to try and show you is that's not what faith means.
- 4.90 By the way, I've talked to deeply thoughtful religious figures about this, like Bishop Maximus, and it's recorded. It's on my channel if you want to see it. I'm going to give you an alternative proposal of what faith means that is not belief in certainty without argument or evidence, but nevertheless is doing all the important work. In fact, it

deeply interweaves with noesis and gnosis and conformity and participation. So let me at least foreshadow that. Do you trust me that I'll give you a more rigorous argument? I'm just giving you a gesture right now. Thank you, Micah. I appreciate your trust.

- 4.91 I'm faithful to Sarah. Does that mean I have beliefs about Sarah without evidence and argument? No, it doesn't mean that. What does it mean? Am I certain about her? Oh boy. If I ever—sorry, I'm making her sound scary, and she's not; she's a lovely person. I am so fortunate. You know, we realized we reliably bring out the best in each other, and so we made a lifetime commitment. And that's what I'm talking about. We reliably bring out the best in each other.
- 4.92 I'm not certain about her because she's always mysterious to me. She's not certain about me because I'm always mysterious about her. I'm always, forever, and I believe forever, committed to trying to understand her better. I never get it right, sort of. Do you understand what I'm talking about? And I have a kind of— I indwell her, and from her I see into me in a way I couldn't possibly ever see into myself, and I let her do that through me, and we open. We are trothed to each other. This is an ancient word. Like in betrothal—we are troth to each other. But that is the same root for two different words, troth: trust and truth.
- 4.93 That's a different model of faithfulness, and it fits with all of this and onto-normativity and more about the centrality of goodness. That's what I'm going to propose to you, and we're going to talk about what you have to presuppose fundamentally, which is not the same thing as a foundation.
- 4.94 So, for example, can you be certain about your relevance realization? No, it can be wrong. But can I go somewhere outside of my relevance realization? Can I get someplace outside of it? Can I? No. No matter where I go, what am I doing? Relevance realization. I always have to presuppose it. No matter what place I'm in because it is the process of making a place. It's the process of taking place. Whenever I try to correct relevance realization, what am I using to correct it? Relevance realization. That's not a foundation. That's a living, evolved coupling and connection with reality. That's trothing. That's faithfulness. Is that at least a plausible, viable alternative?
- 4.95 I just want to maybe add, if this aligns, if I could use the word wander. I agree with what faithfulness is and how things are not certain, but in a relationship, you are constantly, maybe you're bringing up new ideas and new perspectives and that wandering—
- 4.96 You're wayfaring. In fact, you're on a permanent pilgrimage with that person.
- 4.97 Yes.
- 4.98 How's that?
- 4.99 Yeah.
- 4.100 Thank you, everyone.

Lecture 5: Dismantling Dichotomies

At a glance — Dismantling dichotomies as the modernist position keeps shifting.

- 5.1 Welcome back. So we keep pushing. The modernist position keeps shifting, and we keep following and following and following. A new picture is proposed, and we step back and look at the picture, and the picture collapses. And so we've come to this last defense, in some ways, which is foundationalism. That's the place. That's the place. We've got a new account of facts. What I can derive from the foundation in a logically certain manner, those are the facts.
- 5.2 And the facts give me certainty, which justifies me and alleviates me from, saves me from my anxiety, and we're smuggling in goodness, but that's OK. We'll just not worry about that. So let's take a look here at foundationalism, and we're going to make use of Plantinga's work, a great analytic philosopher. Please note the name. We're going to come back to that analytic philosopher. Why is he called that? We'll come back to that. Which means, he aspires and he generally succeeds in making very rigorous arguments, very tight, very conceptually clear, very logically coherent.
- 5.3 But his book from 2015 is called "Knowledge and Christian Belief," because he's a Christian. I'm not advocating for Christianity, but notice that we frequently are getting people who are at the margins of the modernist framework, that are making some of the most important critiques. So he says, the person we can look to, to give us a model of foundationalism, we could look to Descartes, and I'll mention Descartes throughout, but the two—he focuses on Locke, but these are the two godfathers.
- 5.4 He used rationalism, that the way we get knowledge is through reason. And Locke's empiricism is that the way we get knowledge is through experience. And this goes into experiments, and this goes into mathematical argumentation. When you put those together, you have modern science. Is that OK? So these are the founding fathers, as I put it.
- 5.5 Sorry, there are no founding mothers. I think that's a moral crime, but I can't do anything about it. I would say that we've talked in the past about the prospect of the advent of the sacred. I think a lot of women philosophers and scientists are doing the lion's share of this work right now, and I don't think that is a coincidence either.
- 5.6 So what's a foundation? A foundation are beliefs that are certain. It's what Locke talks about, but he's deeply influenced. Descartes has a huge influence on Locke, certain beliefs—sorry, you may take that to mean particular beliefs. I'll say beliefs that are certain. Now we have to be careful here. We don't want psychological certainty. Psychological certainty is not what we're talking about here. Psychological certainty is not foundational. It's very dubious. We can easily call it into question. So, are we clear about that?

- 5.7 The reason why this is important is that people readily confuse philosophical certainty, which is sometimes called logical certainty, with psychological certainty, and that's not what we're talking about here. We're talking about epistemological—having to do with knowledge, the foundations of knowledge— we're talking epistemological certainty, not psychological certainty.
- 5.8 One of the problems, when many people say "faith" in the way that I was talking to Micah about, is that they have a sort of psychological certainty, and they're confusing that with epistemological certainty. Is that all right? So let's make sure that that's not what we're talking about. We're talking about epistemological certainty. Some people call it philosophical, some people call it logical. I like epistemological actually the best, because epistemology is the study of knowledge, the kind of certainty that would ground or provide a foundation for knowledge. That's what we're talking about here. Any questions about that? It's really clear that we have that distinction in place.
- 5.9 So what are the two kinds of epistemological certainty, according to Locke? One is what he calls self-evidence. You're Americans: "We hold these truths to be self-evident." Where did he get that from? Who did he get that from? John Locke. John Locke is the hero of the Enlightenment, and those Enlightenment figures are the heroes of the Founding Fathers of your republic.
- 5.10 OK, now, I actually have a lot of problems with Jefferson, because I think the thing he says is self-evident doesn't actually satisfy self-evidence, but in fact, I think he's confusing psychological certainty and epistemological certainty. But I'm not trying to undermine your republic, so let's keep going.
- 5.11 Self-evident is something that is certain because it is logically provable. I can show you that its opposite is necessarily false. So I take it that this is self-evident to you, because I can logically prove to you that its opposite is necessarily false, logically false. Is that OK? Now, you know, there's probably some philosophers who might be—but you know, you're presupposing predicate logic, and there's multiple logics. Yes, I understand that. But let's try and give the modernists their due.
- 5.12 So that's one, and the other—and this one is really tricky. This is why I was really careful to distinguish psychological and epistemological certainty, because this next one is—it can hover in a gray zone around epistemological and psychological certainty. So you have to be really careful when you're invoking it. It's correct, but you have to be really careful, because it's very easy for this second one to slide from epistemological certainty into merely psychological certainty. What is that?
- 5.13 So, these are states that are called incorrigible. These are beliefs about your current mental states. So let's do this very carefully. And I want to show you how you can slide from one to the other. So look over there. You're seeing that, right? So, he can be certain that he's seeing what appears to be a lectern. Can he be certain that he's seeing

a lectern? No, because he could be dreaming or hallucinating. But there's a state that he's in that he can't doubt that he's in it.

- 5.14** By the way, this is—where does Locke get this from? This is Descartes. "Cogito ergo sum." I can't possibly doubt that there's doubting going on. That's what it actually means, because it has, I have to be—so notice what's going on here. By the way, this is really important. So pausing in the course of the argument to note something, that what you get is, I'm no longer in contact with the world, modernity. I'm trapped behind. But I ultimately have to rely on where the mind is still participating in something, in contact with something, in conformity.
- 5.15** So where the mind is—if you'll allow me the metaphor, and I hope it doesn't sound weird—where the mind is touching itself. That's this kind of certainty. Does that make sense? But notice how we're sneaking back in noesis and gnosis to ground it all. Do you see? I deny that I have noesis and gnosis of the world. But it's all based on the mind's having noesis and gnosis of itself. Why does the mind have that special power or privilege? Nobody says. Is that all right? So those are incorrigible mental states. They're basically, the mind can't doubt that the mind is in contact with itself, because doubting requires that the mind is in contact with itself. Does that work, Jacob, or was that confusing? Now, what you do is, you get certainty, either self-evidence or incorrigible, and then you logically—it has to be logical deduction, because only logical deduction gives you certainty—it has to be logically deduced. That means, to say it's logically deduced is to say it's derived. Derived means logically deduced, because only logical deduction is certain. All men are mortal. Socrates is a man. Therefore, it's certain that Socrates is mortal.
- 5.16** So this is the model. We get this, and then we logically derive everything from it, and that is foundationalism. That stops the regress. That justifies me; it justifies me by giving me certainty that alleviates my anxiety, and that gives me my facts because I build everything from that. Is that OK? It's a beautiful picture. The only thing that's wrong with it is that it's probably false. We are attracted to this picture. We really are attracted to this picture because if modernity can't get this picture, it collapses. This is the basement that all of modernity tries to be built on. Is that OK? That's why it's called a foundation.
- 5.17** So knowledge, therefore, means certainty. If I follow this model, and what my knowledge is about is, my knowledge is a fact, everything in this is certain. Yes or no? Yes or no? This is certain, yes? The derivation is certain, yes? So all the derivatives are also certain. Yes? Yes or no? Yes, it has to be. If it starts with certainty, and the process of derivation is certain, then the results have to be certain. So knowledge is certainty. That's what you get from this picture of knowledge and facts. Knowledge is certainty. So anything that doesn't give us certainty isn't knowledge. Do you see how that follows?

- 5.18** So let's take a look at something that doesn't give us certainty: science. Science doesn't give us certainty. It can't. Aristotle thought that science gave us certainty. But Aristotle turned out to be wrong, because Aristotle got overturned by Copernicus, who got overturned by Kepler, who got overturned by Newton, who got radically overturned by Einstein, and who, it looks like, is wrong in some way, because we can't get quantum and Einstein to go together, so something has to give.
- 5.19** This is Larry Laudan's work. The past history of science has shown us that none of our theories were certainly true. They all are not just probably true. No, they tend to be rejected as significantly false. Do you understand? Well, science is about certainty. It's about probability. No, that's not enough. It's not that we say, "Oh, Newton was only probably true, and Einstein's more probably true." It's like, no, no, we reject Newton as being in some sense false, because Einstein showed that Newton was false. It was false to claim that there's absolute space and time. Do you understand?
- 5.20** Science doesn't and can't give us certainty, precisely because it is a process of self-correction. It is about being faithful to reality, not being certain about reality. I'll say that again. Science is about being faithful to reality. It's not about being certain about reality. So if we adopt this model, we have to say, science doesn't give us knowledge. But what is driving modernity? The scientific revolution? That's really problematic, don't you think? Now, what some people did, and do, is that they adopt this argument, and they adopt the result of modernity self-destructs like this.
- 5.21** That is how you get skepticism, modern skepticism. Skepticism is the claim that there is no knowledge. There is no knowledge. That's a very hard place to try and live without engaging in performative contradiction. How would you state that there's no knowledge? "I'm absolutely certain that there's no knowledge." No, how would you act? You know, skepticism is very problematic.
- 5.22** When I went, in ancient times, when John went to undergraduate school and was taking philosophy in the before times, it was a dark time. There were no cell phones. There wasn't even microwave ovens. No, sorry, they were just coming online when I was in university. It was a very barbaric time. But we'd spend hours and hours, in course after course, wrestling with skepticism.
- 5.23** And the problem is, if you accept the modern framework, all of this, you're driven into skepticism, but nobody can accept skepticism—well, there are some people that try to—because you can't live it. It turns everything you do into a performative contradiction. And performative contradictions matter as much as propositional contradictions. So something's going wrong here. And so, a lot of people have thought something's going wrong.
- 5.24** Now you can either take that argument that I just gave you as modus tollens. So, knowledge is certainty. Science is not certain. Therefore, science is not knowledge. Or you can say, science is knowledge, gives us knowledge, and therefore modus tollens.

There's something wrong with that premise. You're at a choice. You can either say, conclude skepticism—that's modus tollens. Or you can make another valid argument—you always have the choice, by the way, when you get to these kinds of arguments—and you can say, "No, no, science does give us knowledge," because maybe knowledge is about understanding and faithfulness, rather than about certainty. Maybe it's about explanatory power, rather than certainty. So science does give us knowledge, so this is wrong. Knowledge isn't certainty.

- 5.25** Now that's hard to hear, isn't it? We still want, like in our guts. "But I want to be certain. I want to be certain." Sorry, I'm making you sound like you've got a chipmunk in your head. I don't mean that. "I want to be certain. I want to be certain." A talking chipmunk, which is even worse.
- 5.26** So basically, skepticism, which is really, I think, nothing but to step into ongoing performative contradiction, or as many people have concluded, this is wrong, which is meaning, there's something wrong with this picture. When you start out on a theory of knowledge that is trying to explain the scientific revolution, and you end up claiming that there is no scientific revolution because there's no scientific knowledge, something's gone wrong. Maybe the picture is wrong. Let's keep going, though. Let's keep going.
- 5.27** This is the particular argument that Plantinga makes in the book that I refer to. So here's foundationalism, which means there's a belief about it. I believe that—there's the propositional knowing—foundationalism is true. Is that all right? Now, let's apply foundationalism to the belief in foundationalism. Step outside the picture, and see what the picture is presupposing that's not included in the picture.
- 5.28** So let's take a look at this belief. Is this belief self-evident? Can I logically prove that it must be the case? Do you think? No. Is that like $2 + 2 = 4$? No. Foundationalism might be false. Nothing logically impossible about that, so it's not self-evident. Is it an incorrigible state of your mind? No, not at all. It's not like this is how your mind is in contact with itself. You're making some claim about knowledge out there and reality. So it's neither one of those.
- 5.29** Can you logically derive it from self-evident truths, like $2 + 2 = 4$, or the state of your mind, the current state of your mind? People have been trying for 400 years. The answer so far has been no. Can't do it. Can't get to a—I can't give you an argument that this is absolutely certain. I can't derive it from self-evident truths. I can't derive it from incorrigible truths. You say, "Maybe you can." Maybe you can. Well, let's try.
- 5.30** So, "I think, therefore I am." Those three dots mean "therefore". First of all, we've got to be really careful about this because we're sliding between psychological and epistemological certainty. First of all, can Descartes be—is he aware, with certainty, incorrigible certainty, of his self? So when you look in, can you describe to me what yourself looks like? Please, go ahead. Come on.

- 5.31** You don't know. What you might try is your memory, right? I have memories. Are your memories indubitable, or are they sometimes just wrong? The fact that you're remembering, you can't doubt that. But can you doubt your memories? Yes. Of course. So Descartes can't know anything about Descartes himself or his past, because those are not in his current state of mind. So there's no "I" here, which means there's no "I" here.
- 5.32** Think. Well, in his current state of mind, is he aware of all the ways he can think? Is he hoping at that moment, when he's doing that moment of doubt? No, he's not hoping. Is he wondering? No. He's doing one thing and only one: doubting. What he's actually saying is, doubting can't doubt that doubting exists because it has to exist in order to doubt. Now, try to derive anything from that. So all I have is doubting "is". So what does logic do? Logic is, logic explicates what's implicit. That's why we talk about logic. What's implied? Implication.
- 5.33** So, for example, all men are mortal. Socrates is a man. Therefore, Socrates is mortal. I haven't added any information. Everything that's in the conclusion is already implied in the premises. Do you see that? It's already there implicitly. The notion of mortal and man are bound together. I'm just making explicit what was implicit. That's why it's called implication; what is implied. Is that OK? That's why I can do analysis. Analysis is to break apart what was implicit in the structure and making it explicit to you.
- 5.34** So when I'm analyzing a chemical, am I making a new chemical? No. Am I adding anything to the chemical? No. What am I doing? I am showing you all the parts that were inside the chemical. So logic is, in this sense, analytic. It's just analyzing what was implicit. It can't add anything. So what can you, in a completely logical fashion, derive by doubting "is"? What can you derive from that? Well, there's doubting, and there's existence, and doubting and existence are in relation. And um, um, um, that's it.
- 5.35** Descartes tries famously to derive that God exists, and he ends up presupposing the very thing he's trying to prove. This is called the famous Cartesian circle. I won't go into it. The problem is, you can't get anything from here, so this isn't self-evident. It's not an incorrigible state of mind. We've tried to derive other things. We've tried to derive a way of showing that this is certain, but we can't, and that's because logical derivation can't do it. This picture can't get going.
- 5.36** And so, almost all philosophers now—it's very rare to get consensus in philosophers. You get three philosophers in a room, you have 17 opinions. I have a PhD in philosophy, so I'm allowed to make fun of philosophers. But for most philosophers, foundationalism isn't true. I have to reject it. We're actually having a really hard time sustaining the fact-value dichotomy. And as we try to sustain it, we find that this dichotomy is bound up with a bunch of other dichotomies, and they're all collapsing together like a house of cards, like a house of cards.

- 5.37 So what people do, at least it's been my observation that this is what people do, if they get pressed this way, they will give ground on the fact-value dichotomy, which means, by the way, they're also giving ground on the meaning-measurement dichotomy, because that fell; we'll come back to that. They're giving ground on the subjective-objective, but they try one major shift, because they don't want goodness to be ontornormativity. We've got to keep goodness stranded.
- 5.38 Now they can't strand it with subjective-objective. And I can't strand it with measurement and meaning, and I can't strand it with fact-value. I can strand it with is-ought. You can't go from an is to an ought. There. And to do so is often called the naturalistic fallacy. You may have heard this. You can't get any ought from an is. That's like the naturalistic fallacy. People are very confident, and there's a lot of people that think they are representing modernity and rationality and logicity who will frequently invoke this.
- 5.39 OK, so let's look at the picture. Where did the picture come from? Is there anything presupposed by the picture that's not in the picture, in a way that undermines the picture? It came from David Hume, one of the other figures of the Enlightenment. In fact, he's one of the central figures of the Scottish Enlightenment, and he's a deep follower of John Locke. Oh, no. Already, things don't sound good. And he's a famous skeptic, by the way, which is already uh-oh.
- 5.40 So Locke takes a look at this, and now I'm making use of the work of Casebeer. It's exactly like the name sounds. His name is like a case of beer, Casebeer, a book called Natural Ethical Facts, from 2003. Natural Ethical Facts. So let's do a typical thing. Eating is healthy— give me some ground here. Let's say responsible eating or something like that. But eating is healthy. You ought to do what is healthy. And if that sounds a little old-fashioned, you should do what is healthy if you like that better. Ought and should, in this context, are synonymous. Therefore, you ought to eat.
- 5.41 Why does Hume not like this? He says it's technically not valid. Because, remember, you can only get something from here that was implicit in the premises. So you introduced this. You introduced this. You're saying that what you've got is a hidden premise: health is good. You didn't put that premise in, so your argument is technically invalid. And so, at that level, if that's all Hume did, we'd go, "Big deal." By the way, we should do this because a lot of people stop there and think that's Hume's argument. Hume is smarter than that.
- 5.42 That's a bad argument because all I have to do, oh, well, OK, I'll put the premise in here. Eating is healthy. Health is good. You ought to do what is good. Why? Because good and ought imply each other. Therefore, you ought to eat. Now, it's a technically valid argument. Well, that was easy. We got rid of David Hume. Hume's not that. That's not Hume's argument. And so, many people— you'll see this on the internet—they think that's Hume's argument. That's not Hume's argument. Hume is not that stupid.

- 5.43 By the way, if that's all they do, they're being stupid. It's not fair to Hume. Hume is smarter than that. Hume objects to this. He says this premise is illegitimate. And if you take that premise out, the argument becomes invalid, and that's why you can't ever get to an ought from an is. Why does he think we should take the premise out? You won't ever hear this in any of these online versions of the naturalistic fallacy and Hume. Why does Hume say, that's an illegitimate premise?
- 5.44 Because Hume has this idea, an epistemological idea derived from Locke, that meaning and knowledge can only be of what is perceivable. Something's meaningless and can't possibly be known, unless you can perceive it. It has to be perceivable. And I mean, like, perceptible, because he's an empiricist like Locke. Remember, everything comes through experience. So you have to have a perceptual experience of it, or it's meaningless, and you can't possibly have knowledge of it.
- 5.45 And so he says, because of that, what color is goodness? What size is goodness? What shape is goodness? What texture is goodness? What sound does goodness make when you hit it? And you go, "This is all ridiculous. Goodness isn't like that." And he goes, "Aha! You see, that is why I reject it." That's his argument. The problem with that is, look at all the other things that Hume rejects because we can't perceive them—famously, by the way.
- 5.46 I'm not introducing something that people are in controversy about—Hume explicitly and repeatedly says you can't see causation. You can't see that one thing causes another, because you can't see, you can't see necessity. When you say A causes B, you say that, if A exists, then necessarily B will follow. What color is necessity? What shape does necessity have? What sound does it make? How much does it weigh?
- 5.47 By the way, this is part of what Kant said. Kant said Hume is right, so necessity can't be out there. This must be something the mind projects onto the world. Remember the math being projected onto the world? That's what Kant did. Kant took this seriously.
- 5.48 I don't. I think that's ridiculous. Saying that causation isn't real—what does that do to science? You know what you can't also see? The past. If I get rid of causation in the past, I can't have things like the theory of evolution. I can't have cosmology. I can't have the Big Bang. I can't have any of that. In fact, you know where you end up? Skepticism again, which is where Hume went. See, if you are going to apply Hume's argument and you're going to be some sort of logic pro on the internet, you should be a Humean skeptic. You should doubt that there's science. You should doubt that the past exists. You should doubt that there's causation.
- 5.49 You should doubt many—like, most things are actually not perceivable. You can't perceive yourself. You can't perceive your past. You can't perceive the future. How are you making predictions in science if the future is imperceivable? Most people interpret Hume as a radical skeptic, which I think is fair to Hume, and Hume goes that way. So Hume has integrity. Most people who use Hume don't. But now we're doing the same

thing again. We're trying to do is-ought, and we're ending up, here's a picture. And as we try to give the picture, it undermines all knowledge claims.

- 5.50** By the way, David Hume, can I see, can I see that? Hume believes this. He believes this fact. Can I see this fact? Can I see that only perceivable things are real? Where would I be, such that I could see that only perceivable things are real? Nowhere. So the people who are not stupid—sorry, I'm being insulting because there's a lot of bad stuff on the internet about this, really bad, philosophically incompetent. I respect Hume. He should be treated with respect.. Follow his arguments, and if you deviate from them, give me a principled reason why you're doing it.
- 5.51** Now, what Casebeer argues, and I agree with him, is that most people jump from Hume to a guy you've probably not heard of: Moore, G. E. Moore, a British philosopher, the beginning of the 20th century. It was actually Moore who invented the term naturalistic fallacy. Hume did not. What they do is, they jump to a naturalistic fallacy that came from Moore, and they conflate it with Hume. Moore is a different person at a different time, giving different arguments.
- 5.52** So when people, they do this—is-ought, which they got from Hume and they say, to violate that is to fall prey to the naturalistic fallacy, to make a fallacious mistake, which they get from Moore. They're just linked together. I'm separating them out because I'm looking at the picture carefully. Sorry, am I sounding angry? I don't mean, I don't want to be angry. Passionate. Passionate's OK?
- 5.53** So, Moore actually came up with this, and he's not relying on Hume's argument. Good for him, because I don't think the arguments are going to get what people want. So what does Moore do? Moore has a different argument. He's doing what's called meta-ethics. Here, we need to make a bit of a distinction. We're going to need a bit when we talk about Murdoch. Morality is like your states of mind and how you act. By the way, people don't use these terms carefully. Ethics is the study of morality, the attempt to justify and explain morality. And then meta-ethics is the attempt to explain what's going on in ethics. Philosophers do this kind of thing. You see, there it is, meta.
- 5.54** So people try to be moral. We try to understand how we're moral, and we try to then understand what kind of theories we're generating when we're trying to explain how we're moral. Did that work? So moral, not mortal. Sorry. We try to behave morally. We try to generate theories explaining how we do or should behave morally. And then, we come up with theories of how we should come up with theories of how we should be moral. Could there be a meta-meta-ethics? Yes. But does anybody do that? No, because nobody will get paid to do that.
- 5.55** But Moore's doing this. Moore's doing this. And here's where we suddenly circle back out of nowhere to our quarry. He says the central problem is goodness. All of a sudden, after all of this, following and following and following and following, Moore goes, "It's

all about goodness," because that's what Hume was bothered about. But let's do this. Are you all with me? All right.

- 5.56** His argument is known by various names. One of the ones I like is the open-ended question argument. The open-ended question argument. It goes like this. For any proposed definition of goodness, or for any proposed, X is goodness, and we'll come back to what we mean by definition here, because he means it in a very strict sense. He means it the way analytic philosophy has to mean it. We can always ask this question: Is X always good? So this is, goodness equals X , but is X always good?
- 5.57** As soon as we answer no, that means X is not always good, which means X is not equivalent to goodness. Do you see how that works? As soon as we answer no, then—and notice how I made this equivalent, because that's the sense of definition here. We're not talking about a dictionary definition. We're talking about a mathematical-like certainty, an equivalence, an analytic claim, as he would call it.
- 5.58** We're talking about the necessary and sufficient conditions, like the definition of a triangle. All triangles necessarily have three straight sides that are in complete contact with each other. There is no triangle that doesn't have that, and every triangle has that, and that's all a triangle has to have in order to be a triangle. Do triangles have to be red to be triangles? Do they have to be a certain size to be triangles? No, so necessary and sufficient, captured by an equivalent sign, not a dictionary definition, because that's not what a dictionary definition is. We mean an analytic definition. Are we clear about that? Because the argument only works if it's that.
- 5.59** Let's do an example. Let's do one that's—the order doesn't matter here. So I can say, pleasure is goodness. Or I could say, goodness is pleasure. A lot of people behave this way. The good that I seek is pleasure. So then we can now ask, is pleasure always good? No, no, no, pleasure is not always good. I've done pleasures that I really wish I hadn't done, and I'm a lot older than you. That's one of the reasons why I don't want to live forever, because all you do is pile up these mistakes. So is pleasure goodness? Well, not always, which means pleasure doesn't equal goodness, which means I can't identify goodness with pleasure.
- 5.60** What Moore says is, no matter what natural thing you put in here— fame, success, power—no matter what you put in here, you can get a no. So there is no natural thing that is goodness. There's nothing that is natural— remember, he's a naturalist because he's in modernity—there's nothing natural that can be made equivalent to goodness. So goodness is non-natural. That's his term. He won't say supernatural. Goodness is non-natural.
- 5.61** And another thing is, it's absolutely simple. I can't give a definition of goodness, so I can't possibly analyze it. I cannot give a definition of goodness, so I cannot possibly analyze it, because I can only analyze things that have definitions. Is that clear? So it's absolutely simple, and it's non-natural. That means any attempt to go from an is to a

good, to saying something is and something is good, and therefore it ought to be done, doesn't work. That's the naturalistic fallacy, because good is non-natural and simple. That's the naturalistic fallacy.

5.62 Now, it's bound up with analytic philosophy and the idea that meaning is analytic, or sorry, that there is a class of meaning that is analytic, that—a way of putting this is that concepts, the things that bear meaning, such that we can know, meanings that we judge to be true, concepts are definitions. This is an ancient theory of what a concept is. You have concepts. Do you have a concept of what a chair is? Do you have a concept of bird? Do you have a concept? Yeah. You can conceive of birds. When I say "conceive of a chair," can you do that? Is that all right? So you know what concept means. Interestingly, we choose a word from pregnancy: conception. We give birth somehow.

5.63 Concepts are definitions, and notice, are these dictionary definitions we're talking about here? No, we're talking about analytic definitions. We're talking about necessary and sufficient. We're talking about equivalency relationships, like a triangle is equivalent to. So Moore's argument depends on the idea that concepts are definitions, which is a very famous and long-standing theory, such that it is frequently called the classical theory of concepts. Aristotle seems to have this view. Plato doesn't.

5.64 By the way, if you have to choose between Plato and Aristotle, choose Plato. That's been a really good heuristic for me. It doesn't mean that you shouldn't listen to Aristotle. Aristotle is brilliant, but Plato. Because remember what I said about Socrates? Socrates would ask people for definitions, and it looks like he's an analytic philosopher. But what happens in every dialogue—well, not every dialogue, but many dialogues, is that people can't come up with a definition. Socrates will even propose a definition and then he will destroy it. Plato actually seems to be saying that maybe a lot of our concepts aren't definitions. Maybe our knowing isn't fundamentally or ultimately propositional. Maybe it's noesis and gnosis.

5.65 OK, but let's take a look at this because there's a philosopher we keep banging into who has been so helpful, because he's one of the two great philosophers of the 20th century, and they're doing very similar things, Wittgenstein and Heidegger. Wittgenstein says, "I don't think concepts are definitions. At least, most concepts are not definition." His famous one is game. How many of you—raise your hands, please—how many of you have played a game? How many of you, if I think, "I want you to go into that house and find me a game," do you think you could do it, supposing there was one in there?

5.66 You wouldn't bring out a toaster or a chair, right? You would? Mayhem. So we've got to think about therapy for Jake. So the problem is, as Wittgenstein famously pointed out, is, any definition I give will exclude some things that are games and include things that aren't, something you do for pleasure. I do lots of things for pleasure. I eat for pleasure, certain kinds of eating. Is that a game? No, that's not really a game. It necessarily involves competition. I play a game of catch with my son. What's the competition? Oh,

you do it with other people. Solitaire. You're pretending. I go and watch a play. Am I playing a game? Well, metaphorically. No, no, no. Sorry, no metaphor here. These are analytic definitions. No metaphor, so let's get back to it. Give me the definition that will include all and only games. It's like, oh—

- 5.67** By the way, nobody's, ever since Wittgenstein has done this, nobody's been able to come up with it. In fact, Jerry Fodor famously argued that, for almost every concept we have, other than strictly mathematical ones, we can't come up with a definition. Oh, well, surely bird, bird. Birds are natural. I mean, if there's anything that's natural, it's a bird. Have to be able to give a definition of a bird. Well, it has feathers and wings, and it flies. So I'm going to put some feathers here. A couple of wings, maybe even a beak and some talons. Gather it all together. Throw it in the air. I've got a bird? No, I've got a really bad horror movie.
- 5.68** What's missing? Well, it has to be put together in the right way. What right way? Well, so they can fly. So penguins aren't birds? No, penguins are birds, because their ancestors used to fly. That's all I need? Their ancestors used to fly? So wasps are birds? Well, no, wasps aren't birds. They fly, but they're not birds. Well, they belong to the species. And then my son, the biologist, comes out and says, "There is no definition of what a species is in biology because," well, oh yes, there is. Species are beings who can mate together. Actually, no, because you have what's called rings.
- 5.69** So let's say there's a mountain range here, and these birds can mate with these, can mate with these, mate with these, mate with these, mate with these, mate with these, mate with these. But these can't mate with each other. Are they all in the same species, yes or no? This happens all the time, by the way. The answer is [mumbled]. That's the answer in modern biology, by the way [mumbled].
- 5.70** So let's apply Moore's argument. He said goodness is non-natural, and we can't analyze it. We can't unpack it and see what's inside of it. So birds are non-natural, and we can't possibly analyze, see what parts are inside of them, or— do you think that's right? Do you think birds are non-natural, that they don't belong in nature, they're not natural things? That's ridiculous. That's ridiculous.
- 5.71** Chairs are not natural. The thing that we used as a fact. Give me a definition that includes all and only chairs. Well, you sit on it. So I'm sitting on a rock. Is it a chair? No. It has to have four legs. No, it doesn't. I've sat on chairs that have one leg. It has to have legs. No, I've sat in a beanbag chair. Um. Um. The problem is, concepts aren't definitions. They're not. Some concepts are: math, logic. But we know that we can't get knowledge from things that are purely mathematical and logical, because remember what I showed you about derivation?
- 5.72** If we applied Moore's standard to things other than goodness, we would make almost everything disappear from the natural world. I don't know what would be left. All that would be left in the natural world is math and logic, and that seems exactly opposite of

what we mean by the natural world. That's really problematic, don't you think? Pick anything. So I can do an open-ended question that trumps Moore's open-ended question.

- 5.73** Give me a natural thing that I can put in here that works, that I can come up with a definition. Good luck. Can you give me the necessary and sufficient conditions for being an atom in atomic theory? No, because we're not sure yet. We're not, we're still analyzing. We're still working. So that's the first problem.
- 5.74** Second, the Stoics. What? These are Hellenistic philosophers of ancient Greece and ancient Rome, because they actually had an answer. They worried about Moore's question. They worried about this. They thought, I need to guide my life. Wisdom is to find the good. I need to find that which is always good, if I'm going to live well. What is always good? They actually asked that question. They had an answer. Moore doesn't consider the Stoics. He doesn't consider—what's their answer? They agree with Moore. Pleasure doesn't work. Fame doesn't work. Power doesn't work. But they had an answer. This was their answer: wisdom is always good. It was like, hey, maybe that's right. In fact, a lot of people think that's right.
- 5.75** You know what's a funny thing? There's more Stoics now alive than ever were during the Roman Empire. Stoicism is going through a huge revival. I mean, maybe we should argue about it, but at least it's not clear to me that they're wrong. Maybe wisdom is always good. It's hard to think of an instance where I would say, "I acted wisely, but that wasn't a good thing to do." Maybe the problem is that it's not about, I'm trying to find an object that's good. And maybe wisdom is about how I—oh, here we go—how I fit to things. And this fitting, if done right, can always be good. That's what wisdom is.
- 5.76** And it's like, that's a really important idea. But see, Moore can't go there, because he can't think of the transjective, because he's caught in the subject-object dichotomy. He's not going to talk about something like wisdom. That's ancient philosophy. That's religion. We don't do that. So that's the second problem. Maybe there is an answer. You just have to step outside of the subject-object relation.
- 5.77** We're going to do the final problem with this. What am I trying to do? I'm trying to devastate the is-ought dichotomy. Remember all the ways in which good was stranded? Value-fact, ought-is, meaning-measurement. Remember that? What Moore is ultimately relying on, and this is Casebeer's point, is he's ultimately relying on the analytic-synthetic dichotomy to ground his whole approach. I've already shown you. I've already given you two independent reasons for rejecting his argument. But let's look at the one that Casebeer comes up with.
- 5.78** First of all, analytic-synthetic. Who did he get that from? Immanuel Kant. But you've seen it before; we've talked about it a lot. This is true in virtue of meaning, and this is things that are true in virtue of measurement. So I have to go out and explore the

world and measure things in order to determine if it's true. This, I can just look at the meaning of something. And what that means is, this is definitional meaning.

- 5.79** Now you've already seen that's very problematic. Most meanings are not definitional. So, first of all, remember that. You already saw, remember the high school physics experiment? The relationship between theory and data is meaning. This is measurement. Sometimes you change the theory because of the data. But what happened in the high school example? You reject the data because of the theory. You say, none of us disconfirmed the conservation of mass, experimental error. So it actually looks like this. This is called the theory-ladenness of all data.
- 5.80** So these are actually not in a dichotomous relationship to each other. They interpenetrate. I've shown you that, and I've shown you that most meaning is not analytic in nature. I'm going to show you an additional problem, though. So, do you see how the meaning-measurement thing— well, this doesn't actually exist. I have to actually go out and play with a lot of games before I figure out what a game is. And these aren't really, because I measure in terms of what I theorize, I change my theory in terms of the data. They're actually interpenetrating each other.
- 5.81** So Quine, who you heard before, came along and looked at the analytic-synthetic distinction and said, "Yeah, but how do I know that these are true? How do I know it?" And he says, "Let's put aside logical equivalence." So put aside logic in math because, like everybody, he says they're weird. And that's what Kant was really worried about. So, how do I determine the definitions I give to most of my meanings?
- 5.82** Do I just have an intuition? I just know, I just know. Of course not. That doesn't make any sense. Maybe again, for some logical principles, like, you can't learn that, if P, then Q, P, then Q, because how could I teach it to you? Maybe. But let's—a bachelor is an adult, unmarried male. Is that true? So Tarzan's a bachelor? No. It has to be an adult male that has access to women. So, the Pope. The Pope's a bachelor? No, it has to be an adult male who has access to women, but is not denying his access for religious reasons.
- 5.83** And then what do I need? I need—what do you mean by religion? Oh, good grief. You can't give definitions. How do you actually learn about bachelors? This is what Quine asks. How do you actually learn? Well, we learn it from dictionaries. OK, great. How did the dictionary learn? How did the dictionary writers come up with it? They go out and measure how people are using words, and they measure when the word, how they're using the word, changes. It's not always the same.
- 5.84** The word "nice" used to be a way of calling somebody stupid. Things change. That's why we have weird—take, to come into possession. I took a shower. Who did I take it from? Where did I take it from? Then I took a nap. What? Where? And a little bit gross: I took a crap. What? Seems like I'm trying to get rid of something, not bring it into my—like, what's going on?

5.85 So they're actually going out and measuring the world and measuring how it's changing and how we are all constantly talking to each other about how we are making use and by making meaning. The analytic and synthetic completely collapse. The dichotomy doesn't work. I gave you three arguments. So Moore's argument doesn't work. It doesn't work.

5.86 So the is-ought dichotomy also collapses. The fact-value dichotomy has collapsed. The meaning-measurement dichotomy has collapsed. Analytic-synthetic has collapsed. We keep relying on relevance realization, which totally collapses the subjective-objective. And we're starting to bump into goodness more and more as we're going into that place. That's the fifth lecture, everyone.

Lecture 6: Relevance in Meaning

At a glance — Relevance in meaning, after laying waste to the fact-value dichotomy.

- 6.1 Welcome back. We've pretty much laid waste to the fact-value dichotomy, and to all the things that tried to support it, like the notion that objectivity is the view from nowhere or foundationalism. Then we went to the is-ought and that collapse. Along the way, we again saw multiple reasons why the meaning-measurement, or analytic-synthetic dichotomy, collapses. All the ways in which we tried to strand goodness in modernity are actually collapsing.
- 6.2 Let's note two things. We keep bumping into contact, participation, relevance realization, transjectivity, again and again and again and again. The other thing is that as the manifold is collapsing, it's showing something. Now, I'm going to give you the first picture, and this picture is going to be radically changed. Then I'm going to try and make sure that the picture isn't presupposing something that should be included in the picture to the degree to which we can meet that. Because as I've shown you, we can never do that. We can never get to the nowhere, but we have to be as rational as we possibly can.
- 6.3 What we've noticed is that true and good in the ontonormative sense and beautiful are really bound up together, and that this has a lot to do with intelligibility, realness. So let's make sure—I've mentioned this a couple of times. I want to spend a couple of moments on this. But first, I want to get back to this. This has something to do with realization, as we talked about, and that has something to do with relevance realization. All of that's going on.
- 6.4 Then we can say, why this? Because as the manifold collapses, we see that these things are all actually interpenetrating. The manifold actually blinds us to the fact that they're all interpenetrating. We've got to follow this out, which I'll do in a moment. But let's step back, and I'm going to do this. Now, this maybe has something to do with us, so maybe that shouldn't be in the picture, but realization, at least, has to do with the picture. So, there's at least a tight connection that way.
- 6.5 So maybe just concentrate on the triangle. Something we don't normally do when we look at the triangle, let's also name the relations because we're now really concerned about relations that bind things together and make them touch, connect. So all four of those—the true, the good, the beautiful, the intelligible—we're getting back to the convertibility of the transcendentals. These seem to keep coming up on everything. We have to presuppose this again and again and again and again. And we seem to be called to this again and again and again. So it's both what we're presupposing and it's also what we seem to be aspiring to, again and again and again. Is that fair?
- 6.6 What is this? What's this space? What's the source field for this dynamical system? Where's it taking place? Obviously, I don't mean a literal place. Where's it taking place?

We seem to need to raise that question now because the argument has led us to here. This is what Neoplatonism called the One. Remember, we talked about that? How oneing was both how things are coming together and how they're coming to be known. This is what holds meaning. It holds both senses of realization together. It makes relevance realization possible. And remember that the One is equal to the good, where the good means ontonormativity, not logically identical.

- 6.7** And now we're back at something, and this is very difficult for me to try and bring in here, but we see many, for example, in the West, we see Islam and Judaism and Christianity all adopting this framework as the correct way to talk about ultimate reality — that's what I was trying to write, the really real. Another name we have for this is God. Contrary to a popular fable, there is no etymological relationship between good and God. God does not come from the word good. Let's put that aside.
- 6.8** But that question now emerges. I don't want to presume on what your religious orientation is, but no matter what it is, we're uncomfortable about this because we've lived through the Scientific Revolution, the Protestant Reformation, the bloodiest of religious wars in all of maybe world history, at least European history. We've seen religious institutions do heinous and horrible things and be bound up with horrible governments. So we're suspicious, the hermeneutics of suspicion.
- 6.9** That's why I've done all this work to try and get you to a place where we can at least consider the Neoplatonic perspective again, but not nostalgically. We can't go back to being in it the way they were in it. That's why we have to do this whole pilgrimage. We have to see it again for the first time, as T. S. Elliott would say. We have to recover it. This isn't nostalgia. That's really a difficult thing to talk about.
- 6.10** So what I want to do is to try and get another pathway into it by finally starting to talk more about these two things: realization, especially relevance realization, and goodness, ontonormativity. Because I hope now I've cleared the space and cleared your eyes so we can look at it, and we can consider how important noesis and gnosis, perspectival and participatory knowing, contact is. Does that seem plausible to you?
- 6.11** I mean, there's got to start being a payoff at some point. I'm dragging you. There's this. Oh, crush it. There's this. Oh, crush it. There's this. "Can you build something, John? Can you build something?" Yes. We're going to start building now. We've done enough deconstruction. Let's do some construction. Because this is not nihilism. We're going to talk about that at some point when we turn back to at least a little bit more depth, the work of my beautiful and new friend, William Desmond. I highly recommend his work to all of you.
- 6.12** So we're bumping into Neoplatonism. We're bumping into relevance realization, contact. We're bumping into the centrality of noesis and gnosis. We've done something interesting. We've argued, like the postmodernist, that the modernist model is collapsing, the modernist model of truth is collapsing. But unlike the postmodernist, we

don't then say, "But that's the only model that there could be." We don't say, "You have to live in the ruins because there's nowhere else to live." We've done a pilgrimage, so we already have a good sense that there's somewhere else other than the ruins that we can live in. We're going to try and build that now, have that take place for us in some viable and plausible way.

- 6.13** Let's talk first about realness. I'm going to keep coming back to this again and again and again because of the centrality of realization and its deep relationship with relevance realization, intelligibility and realness. What keeps coming up here is contact, touching, conformity, co-participation, all that. I keep showing you again and again, and again, it's actually being presupposed again and again. It's not a foundation. It's a process we always have to presuppose because we can use nothing else.
- 6.14** What is contact? Luckily, we have somebody who wrote a book on it. It's literally called Contact with Reality. Esther Lightcap Meek—meek, like "the meek shall inherit the Earth." I kid you not. I got to talk to her, not in person, but via video. She's making use of the work of a really important scientist philosopher, Polanyi, Michael Polanyi.
- 6.15** We know that realness has something to do with comparative and corrective intelligibility, realization. So let's do a Plato thing here. Here's the stick. Here's the wooden stick, and here's the shadow of the stick. Which one is a real stick? The shadow or the wooden stick? Which one's a real stick? The wooden one. Yes. You're all worried now because I've always set you up so many times. "Aha!" No, the wooden stick. Why?
- 6.16** Because I can use the wooden stick to explain the shadow, but I can't really use the shadow to explain the wooden stick. Do you see that asymmetry? I can get more and more information about what sticks are from the wood, and I can't get more and more information about what sticks are from the shadow. Do you see that? So, there's an asymmetry.
- 6.17** There's an inexhaustible information, explanatory information— so inexhaustible intelligibility, explanatory information, information that helps us realize, understand in comparison. There's inexhaustible intelligibility in comparison to this that has exhaustible intelligibility. You can see it, and maybe you can measure its length, and that's about it. Does that make sense? We judge realness by a comparative corrective, because real is a comparative term, and we use the comparison to correct in terms of what is the source of intelligibility. We look for that which seems to be pointing to inexhaustible intelligibility.
- 6.18** What did Michael Polanyi propose? We sense we're in contact with reality when we come into a state in which we are experiencing exactly this: inexhaustible—we get a sense of there's inexhaustible future. Now, what does [he] call it? [Indeterminate] future manifestations, IFM. [Indeterminate] future manifestations of intelligibility. We go, "Atoms are real," because every time we go to the atom model, it keeps doing this.

It keeps opening up and explaining more and more things and helping us understand more and more. Does that make sense?

6.19 So contact is—basically, contact is enhanced realization. Why do we use the metaphor of contact? Sometimes we use vision, but all of our senses actually require contact. Light has to contact my retina. Sound has to contact my eardrum. This is Kearney's work on touch. All of our senses are really touchers. What do they have in common? He calls it tact. When we say somebody's being tactful, what do you mean when somebody's being tactful? They're really zeroing in on what's really going on and what's relevant. They're really adjusting themselves to fit it well—relevance realization. So tact, but why contact?

6.20 Is it okay if I touch you? I will touch you in an appropriate fashion. When I'm touching him, I'm always being touched. Even when I touch myself, I'm touching and being touched. I can't touch without being touched. Do you see that? That's at the center. We don't get that as directly with sight because we think there's a chair over there. But actually, I'm touching the light and being touched by the light, which is touching the chair and being touched by the chair—Lawrence is nodding, so that's a good sign. So part of this is, this is inexhaustible, but part of this—and now we're going to use a bit more Polanyi. This also has to do with how attention works. I'm going to do something a little bit weird, and we'll come back a little bit about this when we talk about Murdoch in attention, but pretend this is Merleau-Ponty, this is Michael Polanyi. There are so many examples of this.

6.21 Pretend I'm blind—thank God I'm not. I'm closing my eyes and I'm tapping this. Do you see that? Now, notice how attention is working. I'm not really aware of the marker. I'm aware through the marker. It's not that I have no awareness. I have a tacit awareness of the marker, and I have a focal awareness of the glass. You have a tacit awareness of the light, and you have a focal awareness of her shoes. Understand? Yes or no? And notice I'm doing contact to make that very clear. So, I'm realizing and being realized, realizing and being realized, realizing and being realized. What's happening is, in that moment, I'm doing what Polanyi calls indwelling. I'm indwelling the marker.

6.22 Let's say here's a knower and here's some entity. Part of what makes something real is when we can indwell it such that we can do this through it. Before that seems odd, let me show you I've been showing you this all along. The modernist indwells a picture and gets some of this from it, and therefore judges that picture to be very real. Because they indwell it, and through the picture, the picture is transparent to them, like the marker, they open up reality. That doesn't mean they're not mistaken, but do you understand what's going on? We're talking about what the sense of contact is. They indwell, and you indwell when it gives you a promise of this. Okay, so far? But that's not all. Because those pictures, they're not just indwelling the picture, they've also internalized the picture.

- 6.23** What's internalization? This comes from a guy by the name of Vygotsky, a very famous child psychologist. You have metacognition. It's the hallmark of your rationality. Metacognition is knowing about your cognition. It's knowing about what's going on in your mind. So you can monitor, manage, and manipulate your mind to try and make it better. That's metacognition. But I can ask you: What are you thinking about right now? Are you following this lecture? And you can answer yes or no. "Yes." A very clever answer.
- 6.24** So here's your perspective on the world, and then what you can do amazingly is you can take a perspective on that previous perspective-taking. Isn't that cool? That's metacognition. It's perspectival knowing about perspectival knowing.
- 6.25** I was part of a—we called ourselves the Wisdom Task Force. That sounds amazing. We should have had badges and stuff, a really cool uniform. What we were actually doing is we got all the researchers, most of the important psychologists, cognitive scientists, neuroscientists, and philosophers, basically together about wisdom, what wisdom is. One of the consensus ideas was that wisdom is a perspectival metacognition, the ability to take a perspective on perspectives and to take perspectives other than your own. This is crucial to your rationality. It's crucial to being wise. So it's really important.
- 6.26** Vygotsky, as a great developmental psychologist, asked: How do we get that ability? Because we don't come born with it. If you ask a three-year-old—and I've done this. You don't want your dad to be a cognitive scientist. You ask a three-and-a-half-year-old because they can talk really well by then. You ask them, "What's going on in your head right now?" They'll tell you, "Blood." They can't do introspection. They can't do metacognition. That's why they don't get jokes. That's why you ask a three-year-old to tell you about their day, you get a bizarre acid trip.
- 6.27** So how do we acquire it? Here's Vygotsky's answer. Let's say I was teaching my younger son, Spencer. Spencer, here's Spencer—he's a lot more sophisticated than that. Here's Spencer, and he's looking at a problem, and he wants my help with it. Here's John. And John's perspective—do you see how this is already similar? John's perspective includes Spencer's perspective. And Spencer does something really important, really intelligent: he trusts me. He trusts that my perspective can see things that he can't see from within his perspective. He trusts that I have goals and interests that he doesn't find currently interesting as goals, but he should plausibly consider them.
- 6.28** Part of maturation is that trust deepening. So what does he do?—and you can catch your kids doing this, and it's a little bit creepy. He starts to, when he's by himself, imitate as if I was there. He practices. He imitates. He takes the two positions. Here's Spencer, "This is what Daddy might say." He does this, and he does this, and he does this, both with me and without me, until he can do it inside, the imaginal space. That's how you get metacognition. That's how you can be rational. Does that make sense? That's not all you need for rational, but that's how you get your metacognition. That is internalization.

- 6.29** Now, notice two things were actually going on here. Spencer was indwelling me to see in a way he couldn't see. And then, he was internalizing me, and he was attracted by the promise of this. Did you see that? He indwelt me, because he tries to take my position and see through me, like the cane—Lawrence, is that landing for you? And then he internalized me. And he does that because he has a sense of this: the real, sensed presence that Daddy's opening up more and more of reality—he's not going to say that—but he's opening up more and more of reality to me. Do you see that?
- 6.30** So he's getting into deep contact. He's touching and being touched. You need metacognition to have that. I'm touching and being touched. Is that all landing? This is contact. You can indwell something and internalize it. You can realize it and then, through realizing it, have it realize you. You go through this.
- 6.31** You can do really weird things. You can take the perspective of inanimate objects. What would it be like to be a baseball hit during the World Series? You can imagine it. It's really weird. But you can do it, can't you? That's really strange. You'd be really freaked out if any other animal did that. Contact is when we indwell and internalize, and it loops because we're getting a promise, a sensed presence— not just an abstract promise—of inexhaustible intelligibility that we can use as a touchstone, a comparative that we can use to correct.
- 6.32** Isn't that what Spencer's doing? He's getting a new touchstone, a new sense of a greater source of intelligibility that he can use to correct himself. That's conformity. It doesn't mean being slavishly like everybody. That's just a current modern meaning. This is indwelling and internalization, touching and being touched, contact. It's opening up realization because what's driving it is the fact that it keeps fulfilling the promise that I'm getting increased and enhanced intelligibility that is allowing me to comparatively correct. I'm reducing my illusion and my bias.
- 6.33** Am I getting a God's eye perfect view? No, but I'm getting a mature view. What does mature mean? What do we mean when we say to somebody that they are mature or they're immature? John Russon has done some excellent work on this. We have a phrase that we use when somebody is being immature. We say, "Come on! Face up to reality." Maturity is to face up to what is real. When you're facing something— when I face you, when we're interfacing, a word we've technologized, I'm allowing that loop to take place. I'm touching you and being touched by you. I'm allowing you. Like, "Face me!" When you ask, "Face me. Come on, let's get real!" Notice the language we use. We face up to what's real. Face up. "Spencer, face up to what's real." It's maturation. We're maturing our relationship to reality.
- 6.34** Are we perfecting it? No, we can't be perfect. I've shown you that. But we can mature it. We become wiser. Do we ever become wise- enlightened? I don't know. Maybe. Maybe there have been some individuals like that. But did they get perfect knowledge? I doubt it. We can at least become wiser. Is that okay? That's contact. That's why you love it. That's why you seek it. Because you have a hunger for reality.

- 6.35 Why do you have a hunger for reality? Because you are trying to satisfy the most primary developmental need. Not a survival need. You have those, and you have to satisfy them. I'm not denying it. But what is your primary developmental need? What's your primary developmental imperative? Grow up. Mature. Get wiser. That's what's going on here. That's contact.
- 6.36 Now, the problem is—well, one problem at least—it's easy to say that to somebody, but since most of growing up is not propositional, it's noesis and gnosis, and it's this dynamic refitting and evolving your fittedness—we're already doing relevance realization; do you see that? Saying to somebody, grow up, it's like, "You know what you should do in the stock market? Buy low, sell high. You'll be rich any minute now." But then you want to say, "But how?" Saying "grow up" isn't enough.
- 6.37 We have to practice it. We have to develop skills, know-how, not just beliefs. We have to develop perspectives, states of consciousness that orient us and connect us, not just beliefs. We have to develop character traits, participatory knowing that fits us into participating with reality. We have to cultivate virtue. Beliefs are not enough. That's one of the great devastations of propositional tyranny. All we care about now are what people believe. I don't care what you believe. Tell me what you practice. Let's turn to the other part of this, the relevance realization that is participating in realization. Is that okay, that phrase?? Relevance realization obviously participates in realization. What is it? There are two other courses on this platform that take that question and go [sweeping hand gesture] with it. I'm going to give you [tiny pinch gesture] because we don't have as much time. I'm going to take it that I can gist it a lot and gesture and point you towards those courses and point you towards resources. I'm going to ask for a little bit of trust on this because it's not like I'm not being responsible. I have been responsible. I just don't have the time. Is that okay?
- 6.38 Here's the idea. Intelligibility has to do with what intelligence feeds on, grows on, develops from, like a living thing. It feeds on intelligibility. It grows from intelligibility. That's intelligence, that which you can feed on and grow from intelligibility, which we've been talking a lot about. What is it? When we're talking about this in psychology and cognitive science, and what is it that everybody's talking about, although they're not talking about it well? They're talking about AGI, Artificial General Intelligence.
- 6.39 What is general intelligence? Bad, bad discourse online about this. I've talked a lot about how poorly educated in what intelligence is a lot of people are who talk about intelligence. That's part of the problem we're in. What we can say is a core of all the work that's been done scientifically on intelligence within psychology and to some degree as neuroscience and cognitive science, is the idea that intelligence is your capacity to solve problems. That's how we measure it. That's how we judge it. That's how we evaluate it: can you solve these problems?
- 6.40 We test how good your intelligence is by trying to give you a wider variety of problems that you should try and be able to solve in a wider variety of ways. So lots of variety,

like a wide variety of problems, a wide variety of ways for a wide variety of goals. And yet—here's what the machines don't have, the LLMs—the way you do any of these is strongly predictive of how you do all the others. Intelligence is actually a manifold. If I find out that he's really good—this was discovered by Spearman. If it turns out he's really good in history, he's probably really good in math. And contrary to a lot of, sorry, bullshit in common culture, he's also probably really good in art if he wants to be. That's the actual, usually the motive, the explanation, not the intelligence.

- 6.41** I'm a martial artist. You know who I don't want to fight? Somebody who's really intelligent, because if they're high in general intelligence, measured by g, they're fast, and they're adaptive, and they're flexible, and they learn quickly. That's what intelligence means. It's this positive manifold such that you can solve a wide variety of problems in a wide variety of ways for a wide variety of goals. So, what is that general ability that you have? That's why it's called Artificial General Intelligence. People should read more about the history of the term.
- 6.42** Here's a proposal that I and a lot of people who have worked with me or made use of my work are arguing as to what that is. Your general intelligence—I'm going to have to invoke the meta—is the ability to solve two meta problems that are interlocked. A meta problem is a problem you have to solve whenever you're trying to solve any specific problem. Whenever I'm trying to solve any specific problem, I have to solve this meta-problem. That's why how I solve any of them mutually predicts. Does that make sense?
- 6.43** So, I solve this meta-problem in order to solve any specific problem. That's why these all predict each other because they all have a common origin. Is that okay? I'm going to tell you what they are in a sec. You get the abstract idea. Your general intelligence is to solve two interlocking problems.
- 6.44** What are those? Anticipation and relevance realization. I've already hinted a lot at this. Why this? Just think about it basically. Do you want to fight the tiger or avoid the tiger? Which do you want?
- 6.45** Avoid the tiger.
- 6.46** Yeah, that's good. That's pretty smart, don't you think? Do you want to just happen upon where the salmon are? Or do you want to be able to predict where the salmon are when you're hungry for fish?
- 6.47** Predict.
- 6.48** That's pretty smart, isn't it? Yeah. Ceteris paribus, all else being equal, if I can anticipate the world better than you, I'm more intelligent than you. In fact, we develop these frontal lobes to get better and better at that in comparison to other creatures on the planet. Michael Levin has great work on this. He calls it your cognitive lightcone. Notice the Neoplatonic use of light. Do you know what a lightcone is in astronomy? A

lightcone is—this is all the light that could possibly have traveled to the Earth from now. That's all we can see. We can only see within it. So, the lightcone of an organism is how much into the future can it see? Notice we're doing noesis here.

- 6.49** A dog is more intelligent than a frog because you know a dog can see into the future better than a frog. That's why I can say to Sadie, "Hey, your ball's in the kitchen," and she'll go get it, and she'll come back, and I'll go, "You're such a smart dog." Now, if I did that with Lawrence, I wouldn't be so impressed. "Can you go get me the ball from the kitchen?" He goes and gets it. "Good, Lawrence." Notice right away, just to start, as soon as I start to expand my lightcone, what problem starts to get really big, really fast? I want to push this up, but I can only push this up if I push that up as well. Does that make sense? Do you see that?
- 6.50** How do we do this? There's an entire theory of this that's called predictive processing, the work of Karl Friston and others. Again, I'm just giving you the simple version of this, the Coles Notes. You folks don't even know what Coles Notes are, probably, right? No, of course not. In the before times, in the dark times, we didn't have the internet. If we wanted to get the overview of something, we had to go to a place called a store, and we had to buy an object, a physical book. The book would contain a summary of other books. It would be called Coles Notes. Dark times. We used to have to gather all the books together in one place, a building, and hold them and make them safe and secure. And people would have to travel to that place. It was called the library. And they couldn't bring their phones with them when they went to the library. The phones actually had to be where they lived. Very dark times.
- 6.51** So, what is predictive processing? What's going on there? It's pouring out of a really important—first of all, the real name of this should be predictive preparation processing, because the organism is not just predicting the world, it's trying to prepare for the world. That's what anticipation is: predicting such that you can prepare. It has two amazing insights that drive the whole thing. One is that everything your brain is doing can ultimately be understood as trying to anticipate the world.
- 6.52** Everything your brain is doing is trying to improve its ability to anticipate the world. Is that okay? It's trying to reduce being surprised. But I like surprises. You like little tiny surprises that actually improve other predictions. Like, I like birthday surprises. Not if people jump out of the cake with knives. I don't want that. So that's the first big insight. Anticipate the world.
- 6.53** But here's the one that's really, really clever. Karl Friston, a brilliant mind. He and I keep almost meeting and talking. We both want to talk to each other. It's going to happen someday soon. Here's your brain. If the brain tries to directly predict the world, it can't do it. The world is too ambiguous, too chaotic, too complex. The brain can't create—hear me, hear me, please—the brain cannot create a correspondence model. It can't do it. You should believe that now, by the way, anyways.

- 6.54** What does the brain do? This is interesting. I'll get better at this in a minute. But parts of your brain are directly looping with the world. Remember, contact? Everything is—there's part of it—did you go to retinal school to learn how to convert light into sensory visual information? How long were you in retinal school? No, all you had to do was open your eyes. The same thing with your ears, taste, touch. You learn about, and you get better at it, but you can just automatically start doing it. Is that okay?
- 6.55** That's called the sensory motor loop. Because whenever I'm sensing, I'm moving, even my eyes, even hearing. Whenever I'm sensing, I'm moving, and whenever I'm moving, I'm changing what I'm sensing. Whenever I sense, I move, and whenever I move, I sense. So I'm realizing and being realized all the time. So you're looping. Do you see why the loop? Why I keep talking about, there's the loop, there's the loop right there. Do you see it? This is extended. This is 4E, cog sci. It's not in you. It's between you and the world. See that?
- 6.56** So what the brain does is, here's a part of the brain that gets automatically activated by that. Is that okay? Let's call this your first layer. Then you have another layer. This layer is interacting with the world. There's the sensory motor loop, and it's coming up with patterns. This part of the brain is looking at this and trying to predict and complete the pattern ahead of time. It's trying to figure out the pattern and complete it ahead of time. It gets it mostly wrong because it's hard. But what it has here, it doesn't have here because these two are both participants in the brain. They participate together.
- 6.57** This part can correct that part and say, "No, you got it wrong here." Obviously, they don't talk to each other, but I have to use language. "No, no, you expected this, but I actually did this." Expectation and then error feedback. Do you see that? Expectation then error feedback. Now, normally, they draw the diagram this way for a reason. Here's the loop part. What's going up is error, and what's coming down is expectation. This is correcting, and this is expecting. Error feedback, expectation. Is that okay?
- 6.58** Here's an instance. Your name starts with a G.
- 6.59** Gian.
- 6.60** Gian, what color is that? Do you see that the whole wall is white? She can't. She's not lying, by the way. Your eye can't take in that whole wall. You know what she's actually doing? Her eyes are going over there, taking a sample, going over there, taking a sample, going over there, taking a sample, and then imagining the rest. It's expecting, and it's looking for correction. No correction is coming back, so the whole wall is white.
- 6.61** Actually, there's no clean line between imagining and perceiving. You're equally perceiving and equally imagining. When I run across this room, the sensory motor loop in my body is too slow. My cerebellum is picking up all that's happening in my eyes and in my legs, and it's predicting what's coming, and it's enabling me to anticipate the floor, imagine it as much as I am detecting it. Do you see? This is the imaginal. This is why the imaginal is central to your cognition. This isn't imaginary. It's imaginal because

predictions can be true. They're not necessarily false. This is what you're doing. Do you get it?

- 6.62** Believe it or not, I'm almost done with predictive processing. By the way, notice this up and down. Remember? Remember the cat? Bottom-up, top-down, totally interpenetrating. That's that right there. You're expecting and there. That explains how you read the cat. This is very concrete. This is very abstract. Multiple levels, corresponding to multiple levels of reality, by the way.
- 6.63** Here's the thing: she's actually wrong. If I go closer to the wall, I'll notice that there's differences. This is one shade of white, this is another shade of white. It's not all the same shade. And what she should say to me is, "I don't care. What difference does that make?" Well, it makes a difference if you're painting the wall, right? And it makes a difference if the camera is picking up, "No, there's some weird glare in that one spot. We need to do something." So, sometimes it matters and sometimes it doesn't. What is that? You're selecting for, sometimes it matters and sometimes it doesn't. That's relevance realization. That's relevance realization.
- 6.64** What they propose is there's another monitor over here monitoring up and down, deciding what error signals should go all the way up, what expectation signals should go all the way down. They call this precision weighting. They like to use these very physics-sounding terms because everybody has physics envy. This is actually their model of attention, selective attention. In a 2022 paper with Brett Anderson, Mark Miller, and John Vervaeke, we basically argued that predictive processing comes into a model of selective attention, and relevance realization comes into a model of selective attention, and they actually fit to each other because predictive processing needs to be doing relevance realization.
- 6.65** So now, do you see, first of all, how relevance realization and predictive processing are interlocked? We already saw this when we did the lightcone. You already got an intuition. That's why your intuition, as you open this up, you have to get better and better at being selective to what you attend to, because you're going to face a combinatorial explosion in what you can pay attention to. Does that make sense?
- 6.66** Notice that along the way, we got a lot of converging argument and evidence for that cognition is between us and the world rather than within our head. We've got an explanation of why the imaginal matters so much. And we've got contact and participation. The brain touches itself in order to touch the world, and whenever it's touching the world, it's touching itself. You, your knowledge of yourself and your knowledge of the world can't be extracted and dichotomized to each other. They functionally interweave with each other. So relevance realization.
- 6.67** You could look there and then there while hearing there and then there. You could look there and there or hear there and there while remembering this or that or remembering that or that. You know what you do? You go, "Bing!" There. Do you get it

right all the time? No. When I make something obvious, I always am making other things oblivious, making myself oblivious to them. So attention, memory.

- 6.68** What about when I form the beloved thing of modernity? I have representations. Oh, really? Does a representation capture all the facts about this? What is this? Michael, what is this? Tell me. A marker. By calling it a marker, did you capture that when it was made and that it's in North America? Did you capture the fact that I've used this one and not those ones over there? No. In fact, there's a lot of facts about this that you didn't capture. Why didn't you capture those? Well, because they're not relevant. Whenever I form a representation, I'm picking one of all of the many aspects that I consider relevant to either think about or communicate with you about. Every representation presupposes relevance realization.
- 6.69** I'm going to follow a rule, at least. Following rules, right? Here's a rule. I'll pick a moral one because moral rules are easy to enact. "Be kind." Do you try to follow that rule? Yeah, you do seem that way, by the way. You're welcome. Kindness goes a lot way. So what's the rule for being kind? The problem with rules is they don't specify their own conditions of application. So how I'm being kind to you—I hope I'm being kind to you. Do you think at times I'm being kind to you?
- 6.70** Yes.
- 6.71** Yeah. So how I'm kind to my students. Should I be kind to Sarah the same way I'm kind to Lawrence? Should I be kind to—this is weird, so just pretend. Should I be kind to Lawrence the way I'm kind to Sarah? That's creepy. Should I be kind to Sarah the way I'm kind to my son? No, that's not right. Should I be kind to any of you the way I'm kind to a stranger? No, because we're trying to work something out together, right? So what I need is rules for how I should apply my rule. But then I'll need rules for—oh, I need relevance realization, which tells me, how do I make the rule fit this situation appropriately? Rules, representation, memory, attention.
- 6.72** Everything I try to do, whenever I make an inference, what does this logically imply? It can imply so many things, potential connection to so many propositions. Can I check all of those? No, this is Cherniak again. No, I can't possibly check all of those. So What do I do? Well, it depends on the context. This will be relevant in one way if tomorrow I'm going skydiving, different if tomorrow I'm going on a picnic, or if I'm going sailing, or if I'm staying inside to watch movies.
- 6.73** In fact, the relevance of the proposition is not contained in the proposition. Jerry Fodor made that very clear. Whenever I'm doing an inference, I'm not checking all the logical implications. I'm selecting the ones that are relevant. Inference, following the rule, representing things, remembering things, paying attention, again and again and again and again. This is what's going on.
- 6.74** Here's the thing: I can't give you a definition of relevance. Because this is how we sometimes—we gather all the things that we label, and we're trying to see what they

have in common. What do all the things that I find relevant have in common other than I find them relevant? Nothing. This can be relevant to you. An armadillo can be relevant to you. The Battle of Borodino in which Napoleon defeated the Russians, but at great cost, could be relevant. What do those share in common? Nothing. The things that are relevant aren't stably relevant. This is relevant right now. It won't be relevant a minute from now. I can't give you a definition of relevance.

- 6.75** You know what this is exactly like? Darwin. You can't give a definition of fittedness other than you survive long enough to reproduce. But what I mean is I can't give you a definition of adaptivity. Why? Because what happens is, adaptivity is continually redesigning itself from previous instances of adaptivity. Because if it doesn't continually redesign itself, if it doesn't evolve, what happens to the organism? Gone, extinct. Remember when I said, relevance realization is exactly like evolutionary adaptivity? It is an evolving fittedness between you and your world.
- 6.76** This is how you are coupled to the world. You and the world co-determine, co-create your fittedness to the world, and you're constantly looping and evolving that fittedness. This is why you have insight. There's no final form of that. There's no finished state. If I were to ask you, "What's the final form of life that evolution is working towards?" You'll say to me, "You don't understand evolution." There's no final form. Evolution is about constantly redesigning itself. That's what relevance realization is.
- 6.77** What I'm trying to show you is that it is primordial. What does primordial mean? Profoundly presupposed— profound, meaning deep. Profoundly, but it's not a foundation. Profoundly presupposed. No matter what I'm doing, I'm doing relevance realization. I'm doing anticipatory relevance realization. No matter what I'm doing, I'm doing anticipatory relevance realization. Is it perfect? No, it can't possibly be perfect. Can it check all the information? No, it's exactly about ignoring most of the information all the time.
- 6.78** What that means is there's an inevitable downside. Are you caring about how the curtains are hung right now? You don't care at all, do you? But what if they're moving because there's a gun pointing from them? Now I care about them. Sometimes when you're ignoring the information, that's exactly the information you need. Relevance realization, the very capacity that makes you so adaptive also is what makes you prone inevitably to self-deception. That's why it is primordial. You presuppose it, but it can't give you certainty because it always puts you at risk of self-deception. Do you see that?
- 6.79** This can't be a foundation. This is a presupposition, a process that we have to presuppose. It's primordial. It is not foundational. Does that make sense? It's pervasively and profoundly—yeah, I should have put pervasive in there. It's pervasively and profoundly presupposed. Pervasively and profoundly presupposed.
- 6.80** This is our fundamental standing. This is how we stand so that we can understand. This is how we are in place so things can take place. This is why relevance realization is

flowing through your perspectival knowing, your sizing up and your salience landscaping. It's flowing through your participatory knowing because relevance realization is the ultimate form of participation because it's how you and the world are both participating in the process of evolving the fittedness of relevance. That's your intelligibility—sorry, that's your intelligence, plugging into the intelligibility. It's transjective through and through and through. How do you do it?

- 6.81** When I came to this realization, it was also in the before times. I had been working on my thesis. I started to realize that, wow, relevance realization is primordial. How do we do it? Actually, I couldn't come up with an answer for my PhD. I got a round of applause, literally. I went in, and even before they started examining me, they gave me a round of applause for my dissertation. Sorry, I'm bragging, but I was really impressed by that. I was like, wow, because I didn't solve—and so my whole career has been trying to answer that amongst other things. How do we do it?
- 6.82** Well, the connections between relevance realization and biological evolution are actually really, really tight. And I figured out how to, I believe, and a lot of people have come to agree with me, how to exploit them.
- 6.83** So let's take a look at how evolution works. Evolution is a dynamical system. In a dynamical system, you have something that feeds back on itself. Where do goats come from? Michael, where do goats come from? How do you get a goat? Right, where there are other goats. So goats come from goats. Goats reproduce as goats. Reproduction is a feedback cycle. And then, this is Darwin's theory: you have a feedback cycle, and then you have a source of variation. A variation is a constraint that makes more things possible. So, this opens up to options. You get mutations. You get variation. Look around. There's a variation between all of you. You get variation. This increases your options.
- 6.84** But you have—notice what's going on here, by the way. You're getting another bottom-up, top-down thing happening. You have top-down, you have natural selection, competition. It kills off most of the options. So this decreases options. What they do is they're in opponent processing. They're pushing and pulling on each other. Is that making sense to you?
- 6.85** It's like this. Say I'm opening up the option. It's like an accordion. Here's all the goats that are born. All these options. Oh, man, a lot of them get killed off. But now, see what I did? I moved. And now I opened it up from here. Now, and here. You see what I'm doing? As I open and close the accordion, the goats are becoming different than they used to be. They're evolving. The circle is revolving within organized change. That's evolution. Does that make sense? That's what you do. That's what you do.
- 6.86** Let me give you an example. Selective attention. Remember precision weighting, selective attention? You have two networks. One network is called task-focused. It's trying to keep you on task. You've got this weird Canadian professor, and he talks in

these multisyllabic, complex sentences, and I'm trying to stay focused on it. But there's a part of your brain, every part—it's called the default mode network—is going, "I want to go over here. I want to think about this. I want to think about this. Oh, what's he saying?" Right? We all do it, by the way. I'm not picking on you.

- 6.87** Notice what you're doing. The default mode network is creating all kinds of mutations, options for things you can think about, pay attention to, and the task focus network is killing most of them off. But it doesn't kill them all off. Sometimes, Sky is following John Vervaeke, or trying to, and he does a little bit of [mind drifting], but he goes, "Oh, wait." And he comes back, and maybe he has a good question. So he evolves. He doesn't just simply repeat what he's getting from me. He evolves his grasp of it. You do opponent processing. You're doing it. In fact, you're doing it all through your biology, all the way up and all the way down. You're doing opponent processing in order to constantly evolve.
- 6.88** This links to something else I taught you. Remember optimal grip? I have all these trade-off relations. Opponent processing is how you do trade-off relations and how you zero in on, "Oh, I have these options." Do you understand? Optimal gripping is what is produced by opponent processing. It gets the best overall balance between the opposing places.
- 6.89** And now look what we're back to. We're back to being in touch with things and conforming to them, gripping them, optimal gripping. You have a connectedness in your optimal grip, and you're constantly evolving it. Every minute at multiple levels, you're doing this opponent processing that's giving you optimal gripping. You're constantly trading between. So when I look, am I going to explore? Or am I going to try and exploit what has been given to me? Do you see that?
- 6.90** So now let's put these two together. I'm going to pretend predictive processing is like Mendelian genetics because that tells you how things reproduce. Then, relevance realization is like the theory of evolution, natural selection. So first of all, what you're doing is your brain is looping with the world and it's doing stuff to increase. It's doing all of this. Do you see that? The exact opposite—sorry, the exact same thing as biological adaptation, evolution.
- 6.91** Genetics is the machinery of how we reproduce. Just like your brain is a machine for reproducing, your behavior is constantly giving birth. Remember, conceiving? Your behavior is constantly giving birth to new behavior. Like the goats. And yet it's going through this, but doing it really, really fast. Your brain is basically evolution on speed—well, your embodied, embedded brain.
- 6.92** Now, when the predictive processing is trying to reduce you being surprised. But the problem is, it keeps bumping into trade-offs. "I'm going to reduce surprise, so I'm going to explore." But if I reduce a surprise that way, you know what? I don't reduce the surprise reduction by exploiting a particular place and getting to know it in-depth. "Oh,

well, I'll stay and get to know something really in-depth. That'll reduce my surprise." But then I'm going to be surprised by what's over there. Do you see? They're in a trade-off. There's all kinds of trade-offs. So the predictive processing, going up and down, self-organizing, trying to do this, hits those trade-offs that are unavoidable in reality. Are you with me?

- 6.93** And then, it evolves, it self-organizes—opponent processing— that gives us optimal grip on the trade-offs. And that's how the relevance realization and the predictive processing—genetics coming up, and then natural selection going down— they're constantly fitting us to the world, giving us that connectedness, giving us intelligence and making the world intelligible to us, giving us realization. It's participating in exactly the same grammar as the realization of life, evolution, which is ultimately participating in the realization of the physical, chemical world. That's it for Lecture 6. Questions?
- 6.94** I just want to go back to the topic on maturity and what we talked about there, and how maybe parts of us can't face what's real.
- 6.95** Do you think that's a good thing or a bad thing?
- 6.96** Both.
- 6.97** Yeah, good answer.
- 6.98** Let's say maybe those are our flaws. As we grow older, we need to face what's real.
- 6.99** Can I just intervene before you get to your question? Because when I asked you that question, what you're basically doing, you probably didn't hear it, but I'm going to say it. You're saying, "When I don't grow up, there's some relevance realization. I'm trying to ignore reality, and that's what relevance realization does. I'm actually being hijacked by my relevance realization because, for some reason, doing that was adaptive in that environment. But the world has moved on, but I haven't."
- 6.100** That's what I was getting at. How do we face that problem? How do we mature in those aspects of our flaws? Because as we adapt to the world, so should our parts of ourselves. I'm not a mother right now, but let's say if I become a mother and I have to face the reality of maybe—
- 6.101** You know what you have to do? Because I've raised multiple children, my own and step kids. You have to be a relevance realization interface enhancer for them because you can't do, "Okay, world" with your kid. You'll destroy them. You have to do this thing where, with Spencer, you're constantly doing this with them [gestures looping motion].
- 6.102** So your question is exactly perfect. And then here's the answer. I'll use being a parent because it's your example. Can I succeed in helping Spencer mature if I just try to give him beliefs? Does he also need skills? Does he also need to cultivate perspectives and states of mind and consciousness? Does he also need to cultivate traits of character? I have to give him a lot more than beliefs. So your culture is not actually giving you a good model because your culture keeps saying, all that matters— propositional tyranny

—are your beliefs, your set of beliefs, your ideology, and being certain, psychologically certain, that your beliefs are the right ones, and everybody else is wrong.

- 6.103** Put all that aside. I have to practice. You have to play with your kids. You have to play with your kids a lot. It doesn't always mean play they want to play with. You have to practice. I hope you take this the right way. I'm playing with you now. Are we doing anything practical here? No, we're playing. We're playing, and I'm playing with your relevance realization machinery, and I'm trying to obviously change your beliefs, but I'm trying to change your beliefs so that you are more open to cultivating skills, which is what you're asking for, states of consciousness and character traits.
- 6.104** Then the question is: what are the kinds of playing that we do? Where do we go to play well so that we can become wise as we mature—because I showed you those two are interwoven—such that we get a good integration of beliefs, skills, perspectives, and character that keeps us evolving individually and collectively so that we get an ongoing participation in reality realization. So, our relevance realization continually evolves in reality realization.
- 6.105** We used to have places where we did that. It was called religion. That's what a religion does. A religion is about a comprehensive orientation that gives you beliefs, yes, but those beliefs are supposed to be, especially before modernity, in the service of giving you skills, giving you perspectives, and giving you character traits, by giving you role models that you can indwell and internalize, giving you a tradition of role models that you can trust and troth yourself to, and giving you a community that you can practice participating with.
- 6.106** But we don't trust any of those institutions because of the rise of modernity, and also because of their own failings. This is the meaning crisis. This is the meaning crisis. So the issue is, we can't go back to the way it used to be. We can't forget. Are we going to forget? Look, could any of us be here doing this without the science and the technology? No, we can't pretend. We can't go back to nostalgia. Can we pretend that the organized religions haven't done the heinous things they've done? No, we can't pretend.
- 6.107** But all the other institutions have done heinous things, by the way. That's why we distrust all of them. We can't go back. So somehow we have to recover the baby that we lost with all the bathwater. That's what a lot of my work's about. That's one of the things this course is trying to do.
- 6.108** In that model you had with the g at the top and then the two meta-branches of anticipation and relevance realization and the cognitive lightcone idea, I wanted to understand how, for me, it felt a little bit incomplete because I was trying to see how humility fit into the aperture of that. I wanted to ask what you thought about that.
- 6.109** I think humility is really important. I got to give a little bit of background, and then I can answer your question in-depth. You're always framing the world. Relevance realization

—remember the nine dots, and you make the square? That framing, sometimes, is the very thing that's thwarting you. You fail. You fail because your framing doesn't fit. Is that okay so far, Lawrence? So here's a failed framing, here's a failed framing, and here's a failed framing.

6.110 Then, what we do is we come to a new problem. Now, what your friends tell you is they say, "Try to think—" you're stuck; you can't solve the problem. What they say to you is, "Try to think of previous instances of similar problems that you solved." Because they're in the middle of propositional tyranny. They think the description of the solution is what's important. But that's not what your brain cares about. Now, there's a lot of empirical evidence to back what I'm going to say. Your brain cares much more about how similar the framing was than to the content. That's what it's trying to remember because it's so deeply part of you, how you connect to the world. Is that okay?

6.111 What that research shows is that the best way of solving this problem is not to remember previous instances that are similar that you solved, but actually to remember previous instances that you didn't solve. Why? Because what can I do when I look across all these failures? I can see what I'm not changing that's causing me to fail, and by seeing what I'm not changing that's causing me to fail, I increase my chances of actually getting the insight. Does that make sense? Self-correction.

6.112 Yeah.

6.113 Yeah, but you see, I self-correct best by really paying attention, remembering and caring about, admitting up to, owning and being responsible to my failures. What virtue is that?

6.114 Humility.

6.115 Yeah. That's why humility is deeply associated with wisdom. Is that okay?

6.116 Yeah, I like that. It's good.

6.117 Good.

6.118 I'm trying to understand the relationship between relevance realization and meaning in life. Because in a way, I think you made a really strong case around how our organisms very naturally do relevance realization. But also on an individual and, I think, collective level, we're struggling with a meaning crisis. So, yeah, just your thoughts about that and whether there are certain practices.

6.119 So thank you, thank, thank you, thank you for that question because this is the question that I live for. Agent, affordance—remember what an affordance is? It's that fittedness that makes things possible. Here's the arena. This is the world disclosing itself to you in an intelligible manner that makes sense to the agency, so you don't run onto the football field wearing a tennis outfit and carrying a racket. Everything has to be this.

- 6.120** Do you see that that's—remember what's at the core of meaning in life? It was mattering. Remember mattering? Things are important to you; you take them in. They're all food analogies, by the way. Because what you are, and we'll get to this next time, is relevance realization depends on you being the being that moment by moment is making itself. You're a living being. So you are constantly taking care of yourself. Does that make sense to you?
- 6.121** Because you're constantly taking care of yourself, you constantly have to care about what information you should pay attention to, what information you should remember. And what do you need it to best be? Able of fitting you to the world. So you're caring about being connected to something that is really real. That's meaning in life. But you are not just an agent. You have a meta-cognitive ability to reflect on yourself and tell yourself stories so that you are a self in a story that connects you to the world. You're also a self. Most organisms aren't, but there are non-human selves: chimps, elephants, probably dolphins, because they passed the mirror test. But you're even more than that. So you refine this with maturing your relevance realization.
- 6.122** But you're also a person, and what do persons do that even all those other organisms, even the ones like ourselves, don't do? You make promises. You're never going to see any other organism making a promise. They don't do it. You make promises. You bind your present self to your future self, and you end up doing things in the future you don't want to do then, because you made a promise. And you also extend, you allow people to give promises. You give permission. So promises and permissions.
- 6.123** You're a person, and now you're involved with the true, the good, and the beautiful that puts you into communing with reality, both other people in the community and the world that supports their community. Persons in community write selves in stories in the world. And you're doing all of this, and this is all about relevance realization and connecting to that which makes you more of an agent, more of a self, more of a person, so that you deeply care more and more about being connected to what is more and more real. That's meaning in life.

Lecture 7: Voluntary Necessity

At a glance — Voluntary necessity — drawing the threads together.

- 7.1 Welcome back. Today, we're on lectures seven and eight. Very exciting. We're going to try and draw it all together. Last time, we started making the turn from the deconstruction into the construction. We did a lot about predictive processing, relevance realization, connectedness, all of that. That's where we're at, optimal gripping, and all of that. We're going to do a little bit more about this. What I want to do is start by talking about the relationship between relevance realization and truth.
- 7.2 I'll give you a proposal for it, that I think is plausible. I won't be able to give the entire argument. I'll just make the proposal and hope it'll be intuitively plausible to you. Relevance realization or relevance, if you just want to short-form it, truth. I mean now the process of truth, trothing and trusting. Relevance realization constrains what truths we consider, what we orient to and pay attention to. Truth corrects what we're deeming relevant instead. Oh, no, no, that's not how it really is, so readjust. There's a fundamental interconnection between relevance realization and truthing, if you'll allow me to turn it into a verb. This is a fundamental opponent processing; they're pushing and pulling on each other all the time. Does that make sense?
- 7.3 What that gives us is, it gives us a really primordial optimal gripping on the world. We get a beautiful amount and structure of evidence, a goodness of fit to reality for life, cognition, and meaning. Does that make sense so far? We're just trying to draw it all together.
- 7.4 Remember, we talked about this at the level of your agency, your selfhood, and your personhood are all being gathered together and deeply connected in this looping fashion to reality. I want to remind you now, because I'm going to extend it—sorry for the pun—relevance realization is always relative to a living being, a self-making, autopoietic— that's the word for self-making—being.
- 7.5 It's because Skye is the kind of being that is continually making himself, his agency, his selfhood, his personhood. He has to continually take care of himself at the level of his agency, his selfhood, and his personhood, which means things have to matter to him and be imported into him, because he's constantly making himself out of, from, and within the environment. Does that make sense?
- 7.6 So cognition is inherently embodied—autopoietic—embedded, enacted, extended—it's between, transjective, metaxu. That's all familiar. Now, those are the standard 4 E's in what's called 4E cogsci. Remember I promised I'd come back and I was going to add to it. You've seen the ones I'm going to add. We've got the four E's of embodied, embedded, enacted, and extended. I'm going to add three more.

- 7.7** Cognition is inherently exaptive. You're constantly taking the sensorimotor and exapting it up. You have an urge of exaptation. You have an urge to build yourself up. Why is this natural to you? Well, very quickly, relevance realization is simultaneously integrating information, drawing things together, saying, "These, treat these as the same." So if it's relevant, these two beings are the same. They're both humans. No, no, no. Here's the opponent processing: treat them as different, differentiation. One is presumably male and one is presumably female. There's a difference now.
- 7.8** When a system is simultaneously integrating and differentiating, a system becomes complex. What am I doing here? I'm explaining why it's exaptive, why you have this urge upwards. It's intrinsic to you. It's not accidental. OK, look at my hand. My hand is simultaneously highly differentiated but highly integrated. When it does all this, does my hand fall apart when I do this? Does it fragment and break down? No, it stays together, but it isn't together like this. I can't do anything with this, but it's together like this.
- 7.9** It's complex. I'm pretty sure he started out as a zygote. That's a fertilized egg. Now, I've never had a student in my class that's a zygote. Because what actually happened is, the cells initially just reproduce, and then they start to differentiate. They self-organ—listen to the word—self-organize into lungs and heart. So they differentiate and integrate, so that he becomes more and more complex.
- 7.10** It means he can do more and more things that he couldn't do before. He can do more and more things while not losing his agency, his selfhood, and his personhood. Does that make sense? That's called complexification. Complexification produces emergent ways of connecting to the world and extending your light cone. You are intrinsically an urge upward. You reach down. You're like a tree. You're rooted in your primordality. Everything you have to presuppose.
- 7.11** Did you make your relevance realization? No, it made you. You participate in it. Everything you have to presuppose, you're rooted in your primordality, but you're reaching up like the branches of a tree. You have an urge towards ultimacy because you are intrinsically autopoietic. You're intrinsically complexified. Why are you complexified? Lawrence, quick guess. What's your best guess? Is reality simple or complex?
- 7.12** Both.
- 7.13** That's a better answer than I expected. Well, yes. Tell me what you mean by that. Sorry, that was intended to be a compliment.
- 7.14** It maybe depends on the scenario, whether you need to address it.
- 7.15** Let me see if this tracks. Do you think, I mean, at some level, it's complex because it's combinatorially explosive, and massively integrated, but it's not absurd. So you can draw into intelligibility, and that's how it can be simple. Have I got what you're saying?

- 7.16 Yeah, that's good.
- 7.17 Yeah. Good. We're on—copacetic. Great. You are complexifying so you can be intelligibly coupled to a complex world. You complexify so you can participate intelligibly, simply in the complexity of reality. The nature of reality in the nature of you means this is intrinsic to you. Your primordality is intrinsic to you, and your urge towards ultimacy is intrinsic to you. Does that make sense, Micah?
- 7.18 Maybe this has something to do with the fact that we have often wanted God to be both the most immanent and the most transcendent. See, I promised you we'd have some happier stuff this time. So I'm not always going to say PP, RR, 7E. I'll just say RR, relevance realization, but I mean all of it. Now, because it is 7E, because RR is 7E, there's another really important feature that comes out of this that we bumped into, especially when we bumped into the notion of faithfulness, not belief without evidence or argument, but faithfulness, trothing, trusting, truthing, being true to.
- 7.19 Our binding—I'm going to use a word now that I've used for that binding we have to reality, that contact, that participation, that connection. I use it because it has allusions that I want you to feel. The Latin word for connectedness is religio. You might hear another word close to that. So religio, you're bound in this way from your primordality towards your ultimacy. You're inherently self-transcending. Now, what's the nature of that binding? I'm going to use a technical term here, and then I'll explain what it means.
- 7.20 It's a binding, but it's defeasible, defeasible. We have a defeasible binding. Something is defeasible when it can be overridden by context. You have a rule, "Be kind." Somebody's about to hit you in the face with a stick. Are you going to be kind to them? Not at that moment. So the context, although it's a rule you follow, and it's a rule that you should try to follow everywhere, context, because of relevance, can override it. Does that make sense? It's a defeasible binding.
- 7.21 So notice, this is what you do. You participate. I'm not going to say project because that's the modern idea. You participate in— things are calling to you and binding you with relevance and salience, but you can defease it if something suddenly comes up. So it's defeasible binding. Is that making sense? It's a defeasible binding in which—I'll use horizontal to the world. It's defeasible binding in which you're also bound this way from primordality to ultimacy. Is that OK so far?
- 7.22 So human beings from about 40,000 BCE want to celebrate this. They have some intuitive understanding of this, so they do weird stuff. I have—it's one of my most prized possessions—I have a certified replica of the lion man from Germany. It's about 40,000 BC. It's made out of a mammoth tusk. It has the figure of a human being, but the head of a lion with a Mona Lisa smile on it. And it's been worn smooth because it's been passed around the campfire for generations.
- 7.23 What was going on there? We don't know, but there's something going on there. They're trying to represent, so they're drawing humans and animals, but putting them

together. We've been doing this. We don't have anything like that from any of the other hominids, but we did this. We're celebrating, we're expressing, and trying to behold, not do anything practical. We're not reproducing, we're not making fire, we're not hunting, we're not seeking shelter. We are just celebrating, expressing, wondering at, beholding our religio. That's us. Is that OK?

- 7.24** And now all of that's at risk in the meaning crisis because we've lost the centrality of goodness. So it's defeasibly binding. Now, that has to do with another technical way of thinking about relevance realization. Let's say here's the space of all the information I need that's available to me. Now, that's combinatorially explosive. Do we agree with that? Now, if I want to be certain, if I'm trying to do the modern thing and I want to be certain, I have to use a process called an algorithm.
- 7.25** This word is misused a lot. The technical sense of algorithm is a process that, if used correctly, is guaranteed—certain—it's guaranteed to give you the correct answer or prove that an answer is impossible. There's an algorithm for determining the number of persons in this room. Counting: one, two, three, four, five. If I do it correctly, I am certain to get the true answer. Does that make sense? That's an algorithm. So I can use algorithms.
- 7.26** Now, if I were to try and use an algorithm on a combinatorially explosive situation, how much of the information do I have to check to be certain I have the right answer or to prove that no answer is available? How much of it should I have to check? All of it, or you can do some a priori things to—but let's say most of it, which means, can you do it? No. You know what you can't be? You can't be algorithmic. You can't be totally logical or totally mathematical, because if you try to be Mr. Spock—do you know who Mr. Spock is? OK, he's a Vulcan. It's Star Trek, tries to be logical all the time. He tried to be exactly like a computer, like Data. Sorry, I'm a Star Trek fan.
- 7.27** If you tried to be comprehensively algorithmic, and you decided you were going to get up off the chair, that would be the last thing you did, because you would be calculating for the rest of your life and beyond the history of the universe to try and figure out. So let me give you just a quick number. I'm playing chess. There's all these different alternative pathways, different combinations of move, of myself and the opponent. The number of pathways that are logically available in a standard game of chess is greater than the number of atomic particles in the universe. That's just to play chess.
- 7.28** Relevance realization is actually doing this. It's binding you, but it can't lock you in because it could be wrong. It's defeasible binding. It's neither algorithmic, which would be the search for a thing. Do you just arbitrarily, "Just look here. That's good enough"? Can you just arbitrarily? No, you can't be arbitrary, because the chances of getting it right are minuscule, and you can't be algorithmic because you're dead way before you could get anywhere near a solution. So you're neither algorithmic: necessary, nor arbitrary: purely voluntary. Does that make sense? Is that making sense? So neither algorithmic nor arbitrary.

- 7.29** This leads us to the work of Harry Frankfurt again. Remember the guy on bullshit? He has a book, *Reasons for Love*. Is it *Reasons for Love* or *Reasons of Love*? What did I write down here? *Reasons for Love*. His main argument there is that reason needs to be bound by defeasible caring. Relevance realization is caring about information because you're taking care of yourself. If I tried to just logic, I'm doomed. I have to bind myself, but defeasibly, neither algorithmic nor arbitrary, so that I can start to actually do reasoning. Does that make sense? That's his argument. He's bang on, I think, about this.
- 7.30** But then he does something really interesting. He makes it concrete and experiential. He comes up with what he calls the unthinkable. What I'm doing here is, I'm unpacking faithfulness for you. I'm getting to what it is. You're seeing that faithfulness is bound up with celebrating religio, enacting it, wondering at it, be-holding it, being held by it. Is that OK? Let me give you an example.
- 7.31** Sara and I actually started living together only about a year ago, because she had her daughter living with her in her house, and my son was finishing up university and then grad school, teacher's college. He was living with his dad because that's what he could afford. So we're staying in an apartment together, and I'm paying for everything. Of course, I want to do that. Now, what does Frankfurt mean?—
- 7.32** I take it you understand I deeply love my son, and he loves me, which is one of the joys of my life. It's so great when your kids—you can remember these moments. There's the moments when you've had your kid, and you're two months in, and you're not sleeping and you're not eating, and the person you thought loved you more than anybody else in the world hates you, and you're sick all the time. There's an alarm, the worst alarm nature has ever created. You go, "What did I do?" And then the child smiles at you, and you go, "Oh." It's one of those moments.
- 7.33** Another moment you have is when your child's about 18, 19, and they come to you, you've gone through adolescence with them, and you say something to them, and for the first time in a long time, they look at you like, "Hey, maybe Dad's not an idiot. Maybe Dad is saying something." So we were at that stage. We were like adults. We were in deep friendship. I'm still his dad, of course. Really like that. Now, what does he mean by the unthinkable, Frankfurt?
- 7.34** I could form pictures in my head and run inferences, like this. "I can kick Jason out. If I kick Jason out of the apartment, I will have so much more money. The place will finally be clean again. There'll be food in the refrigerator, and I can do whatever I want." I could think all of that. I could imagine it. I could draw all the inferences. Now, note, listen to the phrase we use. But I, of course, could never bring myself to do it. Bring myself. Do you see that voluntary necessity, that defeasible binding? I could never orient myself, such that I would start to participate in being the kind of person who would kick my son out of an apartment. Does that make sense?

- 7.35 It's not logically impossible to me. It's not unthinkable in the sense that I can't picture it or make inferences. I can't do it with noesis and gnosis. Does that make sense? So there's a voluntary necessity to what I'm doing. What does Frankfurt mean by that? I can't do otherwise than I'm doing, but it's not like I'm a drug addict, and I'm compulsive. I want to be doing what I have to be doing. Does that make sense?
- 7.36 It's a voluntary necessity because it's defeasible binding. This is a necessity, but it's voluntary. It's neither algorithmic, which is necessary, nor arbitrary, which is purely voluntary. It's voluntary necessity. Now, that sounds like a contradiction, but it's because it's pointing to this fundamental opponent processing— voluntary necessity. Love is voluntary necessity. I can picture being with other women. I can draw all kinds of inferences. All of this will be the case if I'm not with Sara anymore. I could sleep with a lot of other women. I could run all of that. But it doesn't call to me at all. Do you understand? I feel compelled, but there's no compulsion. That's love.
- 7.37 You turn a corner, and you see a beautiful sunrise. It's beautiful. You just stand there to behold it: voluntary necessity. You feel compelled, but you don't feel like, "I'm entrapped. I'm enslaved." You feel like, "I'm fully alive." Love. Beauty. Now, John Searle, reason, reason. I'm reading a good argument. I get to the conclusion, I find the argument compelling. But do I find it compulsive, or do I go, "Yeah, that's right"?
- 7.38 He calls this the gap. It's compelling, but it's not compulsive. You can still go, "Nah, nah, sorry." But very often you go, "Oh." You realize something. Reason has, at its heart, voluntary necessity. That's why he wrote the book, *Reasons for Love*, because reason is bound by love. By the way, who's the philosopher who said there's a deep interconnection between reason, beauty, and love? Plato. Plato.
- 7.39 Hartmut Rosa talks about what he calls resonance. Resonance is, you turn a corner, and there's an unexpected snowfall, and it strikes you as beautiful. So there's a beauty there. And what do you do? You just come into and you feel—it's almost like music. It's inside of you and outside of you, and you just want to participate. You just want to be there. You just want to behold it, these moments of resonance. He's got this huge book. I mean, we're at resonance, and he's got the uncontrollability of the world. His point is, as resonance goes down in life, people's sense that their life is good goes down. This correlates with research. The more you get into a flow state, the better you feel your life is.
- 7.40 His point is—and this is really important for our sense of realness, so make a little note on this because I'm going to come back to it—resonance requires that I'm on this balance, think about optimal grip, between uncontrollability and controllability. That's why he calls it the uncontrollability of the world. If I can completely control it, if there's nothing surprising—hear that word: surprising—about it, no resonance; if it's completely surprising, then that's horror. You turn the corner, and there's a bunch of people with Uzis, and they're about to shoot you. You don't go, "Let me behold."

- 7.41 You're on this state of this optimal grip between controllability and uncontrollability. Why? Because these are the two senses of realness, and we're going to keep coming back. There's two things we do that give us a sense of realness. One is when we make our inferences and things confirm. Listen to the language: confirm. "Oh, that all fits together. That makes sense. That's real." That's one sense. You notice the integration aspect.
- 7.42 But there's another sense, which is, "Oh, I didn't realize that. Whoa." You get that moment of profound insight. You're surprised, and you go, "That's real." That's the differentiation. Does that make sense? Resonance is when I'm optimally gripping. I'm getting the two senses of realness, and they're co-creating my connectedness, my religio. So the chances that my religio is bound to reality? Very high, very high. So your brain is going [eating sounds].
- 7.43 When this happens a lot, intensely, you get what's called the flow state, Csikszentmihalyi. You know that when you're doing something and you get so focused at it, you feel at one with it, and the world is shining. When I'm a martial artist, it just comes from me. The block is there and the opening for the punch is just there. You know what I mean? You're an athlete or a poet, or you're a jazz musician, or you're a rock climber.
- 7.44 My stepson, Cameron, he's a rock climber. So is Lily, my stepdaughter. Rock-climbing makes no sense. Rock-climbing is something from a Greek myth of torture. "You! Go there, climb that. You will hurt yourself. You will get very tired and hungry. You will get scared. You might die. And once you are at the top, come back down." What is that for? People rock climb because they get into the flow state. The flow state is deep resonance Hartmut acknowledges this.
- 7.45 If I had to ask one thing from you, it's a two-part question, so it's a little bit sneaky. It's like, to determine how meaningful your life is, how often do you get into the flow state? How real are the circumstances? Are they artificial, fabricated, or do they transfer to real life? You're probably quite happy, quite meaningful. There you go. Now, you can get flow-hijacked, because we can hijack anything, into artificial, unreal situations, and you can get addicted to video games, for example. How often do you flow, and how real is your flow?
- 7.46 Flow is a state where people are not having great pleasure. They're basically experiencing ontonormativity. It just feels—they call it optimal experience and optimal performance. This is the best I can be; this is the best things can be. They're together, and they're at one. If you want to see what's going on cognitively in the flow state and why it's so yummy, take a look at The Primacy of Beauty. Talk more about it there.
- 7.47 We have voluntary necessity at the heart of love, beauty, reason, flow state, resonance. This is the noetic quality, the really real that is so sought after. It actually powers our self-transcendence; and self-transcendence requires voluntary necessity. So whenever

you self-correct, you're doing self-transcendence. And whenever you mature and you go from one stage to another, you're doing self-transcendence.

7.48 Why does self-transcendence require a voluntary necessity? This goes to the paradox of self-transcendence by Galen Strawson. If I just extend myself, if it's purely in my power, then there's no transcendence. I'm just extending myself. Myself is not other than what it started to be. If something just crashes into me from outside and necessitates the change, that might be transcendence, but it's not self-transcendence, because it came from—I need something that is neither autonomous—Kant, autonomous—nor heteronomous.

7.49 I need something—the term that Tillich uses is "theonomous", bound by God, bound by ontognormativity. I need voluntary necessity. That's why all of these things, love and beauty and resonance and flow and reason and how they all share a common nexus, this is why you think of them as fundamentally connecting to reality because they power, they afford your self-transcendence, your maturation. You're coupling your complexification to the complexity of the world in a way that makes religio.

7.50 So Plato has a proposal for you. This is the work of Drew Hyland on Plato. Plato says, "You have a job. Your job is to be as human as you possibly can be." And in one sense, you say, "Well, I am human." He means in your agency, your selfhood, and your personhood. He doesn't mean your biology, although your biology is continuous with your cognition. So you go, "OK, great, Plato. Buy low, sell high. Great advice." He says that no, what you need is, you need this thing that's at the heart of love and beauty and reason and resonance and flow.

7.51 You need that voluntary necessity because you have to hold together. There's a Greek word for this, "tonos". I don't like the English word tension because it has a negative sense for us. This is like the tension of the bow or the lyre. It's a good tension opponent processing held in an optimal grip, tonos. Does that make sense?

7.52 When the Buddha is sitting in front of the—he's not yet the Buddha—he's sitting in front of the river. He's just fallen in, and the little girl has saved him and given him the rice pudding. He's like, "What should I do?" Because he's been starving himself to death and everything. There's a barge going down the river. The master is telling the student about how to play the lyre. He says, "No, the strings can't be too tight or too loose." Then that's how the Buddha gets, "Oh, I need to find the middle way." Opponent processing, optimal grip. Tonos. OK, does that make sense? It's related to tone.

7.53 You have to hold together your finitude and your transcendence. You're bound to your primordality. There's so much that you're not in control of and you're limited and constrained. Do you ever fail? Do you ever do things you regret doing, you feel guilty for doing? Do you ever get really frustrated because you just can't make things happen the way you want them to? Oh, you don't? You're blessed. I do. Well, no, no, that's not fair. That's the virtue of dealing with frustrating circumstances. Great. Yes.

- 7.54** We're finite. We're doomed. The very things that make you adaptive, make you prey to inevitable self-deception and self-destruction. We're doomed to fail, to be frustrated, to be at fault, which means a crack that's faulted. Now, if we just identify with that, that's despair. That's despair. And that means other people can exploit us and become tyrants over us. You want to be a tyrant, don't terrify people, at least initially. I'm giving you advice on how to be a tyrant. Cause them to despair. Because when they're in despair, they will capitulate. So you don't want that.
- 7.55** But you have to remember, you have a capacity. You have the urge towards ultimacy. You are inherently self-transcending. Remember? Voluntary necessity. But what if I just identify with my transcendence? "Look at me. Look at, I am so godlike. Look at my beautiful insights and look, look, look, look." Then I get inflated, and I have what the Greeks called hubris. Hubris is the pride in which you're trying to be more than a human, more than a mortal. You're abandoning your finitude.
- 7.56** Now you become a tyrant. If we want to avoid despair and inflation and tyranny on both sides, both ways, we hold these two together. We have to be true to—listen to the words I'm using—we have to be true to our voluntary necessity, because it keeps us true to the tonos of our finitude and our transcendence. It makes us realize our humanity, agency, selfhood, personhood, and realize reality in a binding way. But it's a defeasible binding. It's an evolving binding. Is that OK?
- 7.57** What did I say? True to. True to your voluntary necessity that holds you in the tonos of your finitude and transcendence. That's my proposal to you for what faithfulness is. That's being faithful. Perhaps goodness has to do with our faithful fittedness to the world that is fundamental, not foundational, fundamental to generating and maturing our humanity. How's that? Does that hang together? Maybe it's a real relation of how we are for ourselves, while for one another.
- 7.58** Participating conformity. When you participate, you don't dissolve into the other. There's a part of you that is for yourself. But you don't just absorb everything into you, into your subjectivity, because then you're a tyrant. You hold these two together by being for yourself and for others. To participate is neither to capitulate nor to manipulate.
- 7.59** Maybe this, that we're talking about with our humanity, this goodness, this real fittedness that makes us participate in our humanity in a faithful fashion, so that we're true to ourselves and true to reality, maybe that fittedness is just a species. Maybe it's in continuity with our biological fittedness. That's what I've been arguing. Maybe that biological fittedness or adaptivity, maybe it's in deep continuity with how reality is that way.
- 7.60** What if we're not projecting and our two senses of real—and what else do we have to judge reality with, other than our sense of realness? We have these two senses that

come out of predictive processing and relevance realizing. Confirmation, surprise. Science is built out of getting the right tonos between confirmation and surprise.

- 7.61** That's what an experiment is. Confirmation is trying to get it just right. We might get it wrong, but what do we use to correct it? Our sense of realness as confirmation and surprise. The two senses of realness. Everything is in some sense for itself, so it can surprise us, but it's also for us, so we can confirm our relationship to it. This is William Desmond's idea, which we'll come back to.
- 7.62** Being is communal. It's communal. Everything is for itself while being for others, and for others while it's for itself. Community, common unity, is actually the best icon that we can participate in, not just a picture we look at, but an icon we can participate in, for what reality is fundamentally like. Because in community, you're neither giving yourself, dissolving into the collective, nor are you trying to be an autonomous individual. This is Tillich, this is Jung. You're always trying to balance individuation and participation off against each other.
- 7.63** You know this because your life will swing between them. "I'm lonely. I should go out and get involved." "I'm so involved. I'm losing myself. Where am I? I better go back." "Hey, I'm lonely. I better get involved. Where am I? Who am I?" I saw you sigh there for a second. Tonos is when you're getting the optimal grip on that. Is that making sense?
- 7.64** In order to explain the possibility of a deep continuum between our cognitive biological religio and ontological goodness, ontognormativity, let's move more deeply into the transjective nature of relevance realization and non-propositional knowing. First of all, a lesson—some of this we've already talked about, so I'm just reinforcing it. This is from neural networks, Geoffrey Hinton. I knew Geoffrey Hinton before he became a god because he's also at U of T, like Jordan Peterson was, John Vervaeke is, Geoff MacDonald. Yes, that is where all knowledge eventually comes from.
- 7.65** So, anyways, Hinton proposed what was known as the wake-sleep algorithm— my kind of admittedly loose use of the word. It's at the core of deep learning, which is at the core of the LLMs, so central stuff. That's why he's called the Godfather. Now, I'm going to simplify. I'm not going to do any math, but what the LLMs basically do, and there's evidence that you do this, too, that's why there's a plausibility, is what the LLMs do is, they do a loop called generate to recognize. Well, I call it that. Other people do, too, but not everybody calls it that. Geoffrey doesn't call it, Geoff doesn't call it that—and recognize to generate.
- 7.66** You move your arm, and he tries to figure out what you're doing. You're really good at it. You're really good at thinking, what did that arm gesture do? What is she trying to do with it? You're good at reading the action from the movement. It comes naturally to you. But have you ever tried to point with another animal, even a dog? They go over there and they look at your hand, and you've got to train them forever and all this. This is what you do.

- 7.67** Your brain actually practices using the very processes it uses to generate. Remember the brain models itself to model the world, and in modeling itself, it's modeling the world? Remember that? It's predicting itself to predict the world? Predictive processing? The brain basically says, "Well, what do I do when I'm moving like that?" It generates it, and it uses the very same processes that generate it to mirror. I don't think there are mirror neurons, but I think there's mirroring. It uses those very same processes to recognize somebody else doing it.
- 7.68** Even other primates do that. If you're showing a monkey a human being reaching out to grab something, the area of the monkey's brain that fires when it's grabbing something lights up. It's generating to recognize. When it recognizes, it then can fine-tune its own generation. Remember, Spencer and me? This is what's behind the indwelling, internalization thing. I like to put those together and call that inspiration. When I can indwell and internalize, and it's a loop going like that.
- 7.69** It's at the core of learning. This is how we learn. This is why you dream at night. Your brain generates all kinds of weird crap. Remember, relevance realization and evolution? All kinds of mutation. Then you get up with them and your brain is, "Do I recognize any of them in the world?" No, almost none of them. They all die off. But you recognize a couple and you get better. That's why you dream. Does that make sense? Of course, we've been dreaming for a long time and fascinated by our dreams, because they have to do with religio in a really powerful way.
- 7.70** So, we've got this inspiration happening. Now we're going to turn to the work of Iris Murdoch, one of the women who have been making a big difference. We're going to talk about quite a few women today. She wrote an amazing book: *The Sovereignty of the Good Over Other Concepts*. It's this big. It's thin. It's only about this thin. You can read it in a day. It's so beautifully written. It's very famous. She was also a gifted novelist. She wrote tons of novels, won all kinds of prizes.
- 7.71** She is an explicit disciple of Plato. She makes that clear. She's trying to bring Platonism back, especially in the sovereignty of the good. Now in that, she gives a very famous example. This is the example of the mother-in-law who has a daughter-in-law she doesn't like, because she thinks the daughter-in-law is unworthy of her beloved son. Not an unusual circumstance. So she thinks the daughter-in-law is vulgar and undignified, noisy, and juvenile. And they're not getting along.
- 7.72** Then one day she has a moment when she breaks from her self-absorption, a kind of insight. It occurs to her—notice the language I use—it occurs to her, the way an insight occurs to you. You don't make an insight. You don't go, "Hey, I need an insight now. Go." It doesn't work that way. You participate in it taking place, in it occurring. She realizes, "Hey, maybe my daughter isn't vulgar, my daughter-in-law. Maybe she's not vulgar. Maybe she's refreshingly simple. Maybe she's not undignified. Maybe she's spontaneous. Maybe she's not noisy. Maybe she's cheerful. Maybe she's not juvenile. Maybe she's youthful."

- 7.73** Have you ever seen the Necker cube? If you look at this long enough, it flips, right? Did it flip for anybody? This could be the front, and it's going this way into the board, or this can be the front, and it's going that way into the board. Do you see that? You can do—I don't know what you do, but you just sort of [flipping sounds]—it's called an aspect shift. Often when people go into therapy, they realize, they're caught in, they're aspect-shifting and they don't realize it.
- 7.74** What do I mean by that? Somebody comes into therapy, and they say, "I'm too stubborn. I'm too stubborn. It's really destroying my relationships." They have a propositional knowing. Then you talk to them for a while. I did some psychotherapeutic training, so I did some practicum. You talk to them for a while, and they come around, and they're totally off. Then you say, "Hey, quickly, tell me something you really like about yourself." They'll say, "Well, I really persevere no matter what." You go, "Stubborn, persevere."
- 7.75** You're aspect-shifting, but you need to hold those two together. You can't love the fact that you're perseverant and hate the fact that you're stubborn. You've got to figure out how to have a stereoscopic vision of both together. You have to have gnosis that comes from good noesis. OK, so that's aspect-shifting.
- 7.76** The mother-in-law is aspect-shifting. This is noesis, this kind of insight. She's reorienting. Do you see that? What's foreground and background, what's relevant; it's all shifting around. But then it doesn't just go out to the daughter-in-law. It reverberates back: resonance, resonance. Because this was uncontrollable to some degree. She gets into resonance, and it reverberates back, and she realizes, "Hey, maybe I'm misframing the world incorrectly." So that the insight isn't only outward into the object, it's backwards into the subject. Does that make sense? It's a resonant, reciprocal insight.
- 7.77** This is the transframing we talked about, way back when. Remember, we need transframing to get out of being locked? She was locked, and she participates in transframing out. John Wright, who did work on that very famous example, calls this sensibility transcendence. You're not going to that impossible view from nowhere. He's not saying that. He's saying, "I'm breaking out of an inappropriate framing, and I'm not only reframing the person, I'm reframing my framing, so I'm doing transframing."
- 7.78** That's sensibility transcendence. Your sensibility, your ability to sense and make sense, is being—you're transcending. There's a self—does that make sense? You're basically complexifying it, actually. Is that all right? Sensibility transcendence.
- 7.79** One of the things that Wright is pointing to, in Murdoch, and that Murdoch is pointing us to, is that this has something to do with being good. Just think about this. She hasn't done anything. She hasn't done anything. She has not done any action.
- 7.80** But she's now attending and connecting in a way that makes a new possibility of a better life for her and her daughter-in-law really possible. Does that make sense?

Murdoch's point in *The Sovereignty of Good* is, this is us—she's using Plato—this is us looking at the good. And of course, it's not moral good. It's meta-moral. It's about ontonormativity.

- 7.81** Now, let's do this. You're coupled. She becomes coupled. There's now a continuity of contact. Her daughter is now a sensed presence to her. Really present. So this gets us into reciprocal opening. It can. The moment of sensibility transcendence can flow, I can open up what I'm beholding, and then it can open up me, which actually might enable me to open up more and open up more. Reciprocal opening.
- 7.82** When you do that, when you have mutually accelerating disclosure between two things, what is that? This is the work of Aron, that's his last name. If we're in a situation—I don't mean anything inappropriate by this—and you disclose something to me, and then I reciprocate by disclosing something about, and we do mutually accelerating disclosure, what will start to occur between us? Love. It doesn't have to be romantic love. It can be friendship love. It can be even a renewal of familial love. But that's what reciprocal opening is. It's love. It's love.
- 7.83** Love is when we really get that voluntary necessity is connecting us to reality. Here's Iris Murdoch. "Love is the painful recognition that something other than yourself is real." Her point is, we often don't—we're not actually in love. We're actually confusing obsession or desire with love. "Love is the painful recognition that something other than yourself is real."
- 7.84** You really get that quote when you have a kid. You want to challenge your egocentrism? Have a child and do your very best, with the help of the very best people in your life, to be the best parent you can. You will challenge your egocentrism. You will have to recognize painfully that something other than yourself is real. It's no longer, "How are things relevant to me?" It's, "How am I relevant to reality?" You turn the arrow around. Murdoch calls that unselfing. She gets it from Simone Weil. Love and—so real love is unselfing. It's not selfless. It's not like, I become a doormat. It's unselfing.
- 7.85** We can do this. If you go into *The Primacy of Beauty*, I do this whole thing of, we can have a moment of insight, and then it can cascade in ongoing resonance, and we can get into a flow state. Then that flow state can become more and more driving sensibility transcendence. It's transframing us in a way that has to with our fundamental orientation and contact with reality. We call that a mystical experience. We call that a mystical experience.
- 7.86** What's happening is, you're getting sensibility transcendence at the level of your worldview. This is from Clifford Geertz. This is actually a model for what religion is. He calls it—sorry, another one—meta-meaning. What you need is, you need a way that mutually models. It models in both directions. That's why it's connected to this and to transframing. It models agency and the world as an arena. We talked about this. It models you to fit the world, and it models the world to fit you.

- 7.87** That's meta-meaning because it makes all meaning, all specific concrete meaning, possible. You're doing this. Of course, this is also self and world and person and community and all those things. That's meta-meaning. When you're getting this flow that is at the level of sensibility transcendence, at the level of your worldview, you're getting a mystical experience. When these suddenly, when you get that [noise], and it shifts, an aspect shift, and it's much, much better, onto normativity, remember onto normativity, Yaden? When that's happening, you have worldview attunement. Worldview attunement.
- 7.88** That's why you feel radically like—in flow state, you're at one, but here I'm at one with my opponent. When I'm in the mystical experience, I'm flowing at the level of worldview attunement, so I'm at one with everything. Does that make sense? What I'm actually picking up on is, I'm doing the deepest maturation, complexification, and celebration of my religio, in contact and conformity, a sensed presence of reality. Deep realization. Deep, deep realization.
- 7.89** What you're doing, when you're doing this, when you're doing the worldview reattunement and you're doing radical reorientation, this is like giving you a new grammar of ways you and the world can be. Here's the possible states of all of the person-world relationships you could have. You've been living here, that's like the mother-in-law, and suddenly your light cone opens and you realize, "Oh, all of these are possible to me." And I also have a sense that is telling me how to move through that.
- 7.90** Wynn, in his amazing book—I consider it a philosophical masterpiece. I read it when I was on the European leg of the philosophical Silk Road. It's called *Renewing the Senses*. And he's doing this thing where he is looking at William James. William James wrote a very famous book called *The Varieties of Religious Experience*. In one part of it, James is looking at people going through religious conversion.
- 7.91** The word for conversion is metanoia, by the way, metanoia, which we've seen before. Remember what metanoia means? That radical self-transcending within your noesis that makes new gnosis possible. So he's looking at religious metanoia, and what you get is something really interesting. People, when they'll say, "I experienced God," and you say, "Well, what did he look like?" "No, no, it's not like that." I mean, sometimes people have visions, but that's not what we're talking about here.
- 7.92** What they'll say is, "No, no, no. The whole world changed." It's not an adjective, it's an adverb. The way of me being in the world and the world being in me suddenly changed. It did a radical aspect shift, and I was reoriented with that. This is the metaphor they frequently use. "I felt like God was facing me." I had the sensed presence. Now, remember what a face is. When I'm looking at Lawrence's face—you can do this by the way. It's called thin slicing—I can give you just his eyes, and you can tell me what he's thinking.

- 7.93 Because somehow the whole of the person comes into every part of their face. And in fact, even the mystery. There's more to Lawrence, there's so much more; I can feel it just by doing that. That's face. You get a sense of the inexhaustible, combinatorially explosive nature of reality. But it's coming into a gestalt. It's aspected into a gestalt that is now a sensed presence of connection. You're facing. You're facing.
- 7.94 It's the opposite of the universe. The universe is the container in which we put things until we build stuff up from them. The parts get built into the whole. When you're in the face, the whole shines through the parts in a way that is both confirming and surprising to you, like a person. Does that make sense?
- 7.95 So what I'm saying is, you can take Murdoch's example of the mother-in-law and the daughter-in-law, and there's a way in which people can do it with reality, from the primordial to the ultimate, and they experience that as God. Not necessarily a being. It's more the way they're in the world, and the way the world is in them, is now facing them. You must change your life.
- 7.96 So notice what we have here. We have what he's talking about, with the renewing of the senses; we have a tactful sense of touch. We've exapted touch into that continuity of contact that is sensed presence. We've exapted sight into the noetic vision of the mystical experience. And we've exapted hearing. How have we exapted hearing? Voluntary necessity. This is the work of Steven Smith.
- 7.97 Things are appealing to us. Have you ever used that word and not stopped to think what it means? What is an appeal? When you call for something to come to you. I'm making an appeal to the Supreme Court. I'm asking if I can come to the Supreme Court, and the Supreme Court come and hear my case. Appealing is when things call to you. What does it mean when things call? If you're telling me things are literally calling to you, we've got to get you some help.
- 7.98 Just like the universe isn't literally facing you, but things are calling to you because you are intrinsically voluntary necessity. A sense of being called is to find yourself participating in voluntary necessity in a highly resonant manner. That's Smith's point. That's why his book is *Appeal and Attitude*. Attitude means orientation and the prospect for ultimate meaning.
- 7.99 What we have here is, we have the radical renewal of the senses in faithfulness. Now we have this radical renewal of the senses, sensibility transcendence, radical renewal of the senses, sensibility transcendence, that is making us more and more faithful to the ontornormativity of reality, so that we are now sensing, not just thinking, not just propositions, we're sensing—it's a sensed presence to us—the true, the good, the beautiful, the intelligibility that runs between all of them, and the way there is the really real in which they live and move and have their being and can potentially configure in a way that faces us and calls to us.

- 7.100** Because we are growing from our primordiality, because of an urge towards ultimacy. So what do I mean again by primordiality? I mean that we participate. We participate, and we have to presuppose, in a pervasive and profound way, processes in which we have to participate. We cannot stand outside of them. They are always our deepest standing, our deepest point of contact, our point of orientation to the horizon, from the primordial to the ultimate.
- 7.101** So, Iris Murdoch is not using all this language because she doesn't have 4E cogsci. She wrote *The Sovereignty of the Good* in 1970. 1970. I was only nine years old. Did your parents even know each other in 1970? No, this is a long time ago. 1970s is even before microwaves. We had—get this. If I wanted to watch TV, I had to be in my house or somebody else's house, and we had to go to the TV. 1970. We had to actually turn the dial to get to channels. It was a very dark time.
- 7.102** So I want to turn back to, actually, a really good book about Iris Murdoch, *The Ethics of Attention*. I don't like that title. I'll tell you why in a minute. *Engaging the Real With Iris Murdoch and Simone Weil*, by Silvia Caprioglio, I think is how she pronounces it, sorry if I got it wrong, Panizza. This is from 2022, so a recent book. I want to read you the two quotes from the beginning of the book, just to show you how resonant we are with this whole take on Murdoch.
- 7.103** First is a quote from T. S. Elliot. "Humankind cannot bear very much reality." Reality is really combinatorially explosive, and you've got to grow up a lot to bear more of reality, to face—now you know what facing means— to face up, primordial to ultimate, face up to reality. Then Simone Weil, who is a Christian Neoplatonic mystic who has a huge influence on Iris Murdoch. "The poet produces the beautiful by fixing his attention on something real. It is the same with the act of love. To know that this man who is hungry and thirsty really exists as much as I do, that is enough. The rest follows of itself."
- 7.104** That's how attention is meta-moral in nature. She calls it ethical. I'm not happy with that. Ethics should be the study of morality. Attention is meta-moral. Like Simone Weil says here, Simone Weil says, "To know," that's paying attention in the right way, it's to know by attending, "to know by noticing," this is noesis, "to know that this man who is hungry and thirsty really exists as much as I do, that is enough. The rest follows of itself," fixing his attention.
- 7.105** For Murdoch, we have to train attention so that we can go through that sensibility transcendence, because that is the origin of all moral behavior. It's not itself a moral act. It is to realize and be realized by the ontognormativity, such that you are now oriented to doing what is right. And you're not doing it out of an abstract principle or argument. You're doing because you are called to do it. There's a voluntary necessity in the face of that sensed presence. This is love that's unselfing.
- 7.106** I'm reading one of her novels, *The Nice and the Good*, by Iris Murdoch. She was writing it at exactly the same time she was writing *The Sovereignty of the Good*. It's a great

novel. You're reading this book, and everybody in this book is nice. Everybody's nice. They're British. They're very nice. They're very polite. They're very concerned about, "Am I treating you the right way?" Everybody's nice. It's all nice.

- 7.107** But you come to the painful realization that nobody's good in this book, because everybody is so bloody self-absorbed and self-obsessed. They're actually not really wanting to be virtuous. I'm going to use a modern term—I mean, a current term. She doesn't use it. But they're more obsessed with virtue-signaling. They want everybody to think they're virtuous. They're not as concerned about whether or not they're actually virtuous. In fact, they confuse the two together on a regular basis.
- 7.108** There's this one character, her name's Jessica, and she's really in love with the central character, John, and she thinks she's in love. But it's an overwhelming obsession. She is trying to consume and control him. This is how Iris Murdoch describes that state. It's not actually love. "Jessica paused, facing the windowpane, but she did not look out. The window pane might have been entirely opaque." Notice how she's using a framing, a literal framing. Isn't that brilliant? "The window pane might have been entirely opaque. She herself might have been wearing a black veil, for all she could see of the cars and the people and the dogs and the cats passing by in the streets. Her thoughts and images enclosed her head in a field of forces which literally rendered the world invisible."
- 7.109** This is Murdoch's point. We live self-enclosed. This is her model of sin. We are so self-deceived and self-obsessed and self-enclosed. It's actually a model of sin proposed by Martin Luther, who got it from St. Augustine, who got it from Plato. Next page. While she's obsessing about John, but she had met this other guy, Willy. Notice what Murdoch said. Murdoch writes here.
- 7.110** "But she had noticed"—see how noticed is italicized? Noesis. "She had noticed Willy, and although she was scarcely aware of this, simply being forced to see something in the world other than John Ducane had done her good. That moment," she woke up for a moment to reality, "her curiosity about him," I would actually call it her wonder, "which she did not, which did she but know it, was a little spark of virtue in her." Now ask yourself, and I'm asking me too, how many moments like that do I have in my life? How good am I, really? And what can I do to make more of those moments where I realize, and I am realized by ontornormativity?
- 7.111** This is a notion of attention that orients and liberates us, matures us, and affords us participating in realization. Attention and noesis and gnosis are all bound together in what Murdoch is talking about. Attention is meta-moral and it's meta-rational, because if you can't orient, you can't make sense of things. You've got the sensibility transcendence, and then you have a flow of sensibility transcendence and reciprocal opening, that reciprocal opening that satisfies two meta-desires in us.

- 7.112** We've talked about this, one of these, before. This is Plato. One is, it satisfies our desire for contact with reality. Remember we did that? Our meta-desire. Whatever satisfies our desire, we meta-desire that it's real. But we have another meta-desire. We want to be at peace. Jessica has a moment of peace. We don't want to be at war with ourselves. If I said, "I'll give you a lot of things you desire, but the price you have to pay is, you're going to be riven by guilt and internal conflict and anxiety," you want that? No.
- 7.113** You want inner peace, but you don't want a fake inner peace. You want an inner peace that allows you to be in contact with reality and in contact with reality that internalizes as inner peace. So you're indwelling from peace to the world and internalizing the world in peace into you, and you're being inspired. This is Plato's myth of the cave. People are trapped in a cave and they're trapped in chairs, and they're seeing, there's a fire behind them projecting shadows on the wall.
- 7.114** And one of them gets free and he turns and he looks and he sees the fire and it's blinding. But then he gets his eyes—he keeps practicing until he can see the fire and see by the light of the fire, and that allows him to turn. And then he sees the real objects that were casting the shadow. And behind, he sees an opening, and there's daylight. And he makes his way into the dim daylight coming from that shaft because he's underground in a cave. And as he tries to walk into the light, he's blinded. And then his eyes adjust. So now he can see how to go further. He goes further, and that blinds him.
- 7.115** Do you see what happens? He's doing this, until he goes out and he sees the real world and it's blinding. And at first, he can only look at the reflection of things. And then he eventually can look, but he can never stare at, he can never hold in view the sun, the source of light and life. That's the good. That's also the Matrix, by the way. The reason why people flocked to that movie and were so angry when it was twisted in the horrible sequels, including the fourth one, which I refuse to see, is because they actually love Plato's vision.
- 7.116** That's called anagoge. It means the ascent. This is where you go from your primordiality to the ultimacy. Does he stay up there, by the way? No, he comes back down because he's not going to identify with his transcendence. He re-identifies with his finitude where he was trapped, and he's going to try and bring the light back here. And he now sees the world of shadow with—Wynn—renewed senses. OK, that's where we're going to end Lecture 7.
- 7.117** OK, so we have destructed certain dichotomies, and at the basis lies a contradiction needing a paradox to fill the noesis. At the core of Christ's teaching lies self-sacrifice. So would a viable floor be something like self-sacrifice to the logos?
- 7.118** Yeah. I'm reading a book by Capobianco, and he's talking about Martin Heidegger, who's a German philosopher. But he's actually talking about—and I ordered a version of this—he's talking about a version of the crucifix. He says, look at this cross. And you

look at this cross, and it's like an Eastern Orthodox icon. And there's Jesus on the cross, but all around the cross, there's the communion of the saints, and there's light from above.

- 7.119** And what you're getting is, he's saying, notice how this is an absolutely captivating—it's calling to you, it's beautiful—icon of finite transcendence in action in a way that is calling you to unself yourself. Yeah. And the logos, by the way, I just gave a talk at Cambridge at the logos conference in which I argued, this is what—logos is somehow something you do and something that the world is doing. This is why it's the basis. Remember, we talked about all these things.
- 7.120** I made the proposal that logos is what makes possible relevance realization and reality realization, and the fact that they participate in each other. It was very well received. Now, you can see that, if you want, as—there's ultimacy, here's primordiality. Jesus is the incarnation of the logos, and he's also the Ascension back, too. But that's Plato's cave, too, by the way. This is why Platonism and early Christianity are together from almost the very beginning, with just a martyr in John's gospel. In the beginning was the logos.
- 7.121** So do I think that Christianity was and can be deeply about this, a way of living it as a sensed presence, with a role model that you can indwell and internalize so that it is not I who live, it is Christ who lives in me? Yes, I do. If Christians can return to that, if they would return to that, that would be a big help for the advent of the sacred. Do I think a lot of Christians are actually living this way? I don't know.
- 7.122** There's a lot of distortions around Christianity because of how it was infected by modernity: faith as believing in things without reason and evidence, for example. There's a lot of things that I question in current Christianity. I'm giving you a challenging answer. I think you're on the right track, but I don't think it's an easy path. But Jesus told you it wouldn't be. If it was a wide and easy path, it's not the narrow way. The narrow way is the way you get to God. Is that OK?
- 7.123** I'm Diane. I'm a mental health therapist, and I'm really interested in a connection between noetic experiences and depression. My question is twofold. One is, how do you think beauty can act as a catalyst for noetic experiences, and how insight from that can transform one's experience of depression?
- 7.124** Several theorists have proposed with, I think, good reason and evidence, that depression is anti-flow. Remember, we talked about video game addiction? In the video game, the person is having the flow state, but it doesn't transfer. So video games are not good rituals. Rituals are when you're in a context, and you flow in a way that helps you transfer it to your life and helps you actually bring your life into the ritual context. That's a good ritual. Video games are often bad rituals because you flow in them in a way that doesn't transfer.

- 7.125** Sometimes they're good, but very often when the person is addicted, they're flowing here, and they can't flow here. So they experience the world as anti-flow. They get depressed, which is why they want to return back to the game. But you see, this is a vicious cycle. This is the opposite of reciprocal opening. This is reciprocal narrowing. This is what addiction is. When you're an addict, the world is losing options, and you're losing agency, and you're reciprocally narrowing until you've lost voluntary necessity, and now you're in compulsion. That's what depression is.
- 7.126** What you actually want isn't just beauty. The problem with beauty is, it can be— beauty can, but what you want is, you want them to get into the flow state and to find beauty in a flow state and in a flow state that is transferable out. Now, that's challenging. This is why working with depressed people is hard, because what they actually need to do— because they're actually entrapped, you have to get them to do something enough so they can get into the flow state and start to find—
- 7.127** Beauty might call them into that, but our culture isn't very good about beauty. We've rendered it the smooth. People will often take that attitude towards it. The point of this is to give me pleasure, and I don't really want any pleasure right now because I'm depressed. The trick—I'm working with something analogous to dealing with people with post-traumatic stress disorder and stuff like that—how do you get people into the flow state? How do you draw them in?
- 7.128** What we do is, we have a practice we call dialectic in the dialogos. We get a bunch of people together, and you teach them a way of asking not interesting questions, but asking interested questions of each other. It'll be like this. It'll be like Socrates and one of the people in the Dialogue. Propose what a virtue is. Well, what's honesty? You propose to me what honesty is, and you start giving me a—I don't try to challenge you. I try to ask interested questions. "Well, you said that. What is going on? You did this," and you draw the person out, and then you switch roles.
- 7.129** People can get into a shared flow state. They can get into a conversation that takes on a life of its own that starts to be beautiful. Not that they're having any focal object that's beautiful, and they're starting to participate and get connected. That transfers outside of that moment because they can start to bring it into other conversations, and that can help get people out. How's that?
- 7.130** We're running tests on it. Sorry, we're not doing tests on people that are depressed. We're doing it on people who are highly polarized against each other, like political disputes, and to see if we can get them to get into a flow state. There's already preliminary evidence that, if you do that, when people stop talking about the position and their values, and they stop talking about what it is to be a good person, they start to—because everybody realizes, "I'm not that great of a person," and people start to move and give ground to each other. I hope that was a bit helpful.
- 7.131** I was just thinking of beauty as a gateway—

- 7.132** Yeah, that's good. Good to press back. Because if you can get them doing something that's moving with others, that's beautiful, like tai chi, a movement practice, then you can exapt that into a dialogical practice. You can sometimes get them to shift. None of this—I can't give you a "crank this thing, and it'll churn out" because you know that. That never works. It's so much dependent on the relevance realization of people. But these are things that have a good plausibility of working.
- 7.133** My name is Skye, again. Would the same thing apply to people with, say, we looked on the spectrum of psychopathy to—
- 7.134** Simply getting people into the flow state isn't necessarily the right way. You have to do a lot more when you're trying—let's say, people are at the poles, you have to do a lot more rehabilitation in order to get them to move to the place where their flow state would be appropriately connected to reality.
- 7.135** Dialect into dialogos can help for people who are towards the more autistic, not that good with people or schizotypal psychotic, because they'll just find connections everywhere and they spin off. You've got to do a lot of stuff with them. You've got to do a lot of mindful practice with them to get them to learn to ignore irrelevant information and start to do the looping with something. That's what you practice in meditation.

Lecture 8: Communal Being

At a glance — Communal being and anagoge, the reciprocal opening, at the close.

- 8.1** So, here we are at the end. So, we've got this notion of anagoge. We're doing this reciprocal opening and sensibility transcendence and falling more in love with the world, internalizing it and indwelling it more and more. And we're getting a sense of the inexhaustible intelligibility that's available to us, and it's correcting us, and we're constantly doing this pilgrimage as we make our way out of the cave. We can look back and see how we were limited, and we're doing this. Right, we're getting inexhaustible comparative correction to our intelligibility. It's realization. And we find that ontologically, inherently good.
- 8.2** In that anagoge, we're getting a recovery of the senses, profound sensibility transcendence. We're getting noetic vision and tactful touch, and we're getting spiritual hearing, the sense of being called. We're exalting all of our senses. We get the sensed presence, and now let's put it all together. We get our meta-desires being satisfied in anagoge. Our desire, our meta-desires for inner peace and contact with reality.
- 8.3** That's in connection with meta-meaning. We're moving to the level of worldview attunement, reaching from primordiality to ultimacy in our worldview. We're attending in the way Murdoch talks about, and it's meta-moral and meta-rational, because if we don't orient, we can't reason. And all of this is doing our meta-problem solving of relevance realization. This is what we are realizing. This is that through which we are realizing.
- 8.4** My proposal that I keep coming back and refining is that, whatever affords this and our loving this, that's ontologicality. That's ontologicality. That's what we're realizing in all of this. We're realizing ontologicality. And it somehow connects. Oh! Ah, maybe this is what David Schindler means, D. C. Schindler. The centrality of goodness is this, in a way that connects our primordiality and our ultimacy, while connecting us deeply with reality. Oh, maybe that's the centrality of goodness as ontologicality. We'll come back to that.
- 8.5** But now we have hope. But in order to make sure our hope is real, we're going to confront the depths of nihilism. If this is going to work, I think I've convinced you, no nostalgia, and I keep coming back and showing you why it's not postmodern, but let's do it. Let's give the nihilists their due. I always believe we should steel-person as much as possible. And we've already foreshadowed this. Remember, we talked about William Desmond at the beginning—is it OK if I erase this?
- 8.6** We talked about this idea that the fact-value dichotomy—remember when that seemed natural and normal, and now it's like, "whoa"? The fact-value dichotomy implied, perhaps entailed, nihilism. But if we can show that nihilism is false because of performative contradiction, then we get a modus tollens and show that the fact-value

dichotomy is false. Remember that? Well, we already have a lot of reason to doubt that this is the case, and now that makes us turn the other way and say, "Oh, maybe nihilism is somehow fundamentally wrong."

- 8.7** If this picture of the centrality of goodness is going to really be what we need it to be, it has to withstand the challenge of the most honest nihilism. So William Desmond does this throughout his work. He does it especially in his book *God and the Between*. That's the between again, the transjective, the metaxu, the word for the between that he gets from Plato. Everybody's turning to Plato.
- 8.8** So what I'm going to do now is, I'm going to do a phenomenological argument by William Desmond. Phenomenology is when you go in, and you carefully and rigorously reflect on the structures of your experience in order to see how you are making sense of your experience. That's a phenomenological argument. And then we're going to bring it together with Murdoch's cognitive argument that I just gave. And we're going to bring that together with the ontological argument of David Schindler, which I just foreshadowed a few minutes ago. So that's what we're doing.
- 8.9** Desmond's phenomenological argument about nihilism, we've done. Murdoch's cognitive argument about attention, as meta-moral. And then we're going to do David, D. C. Schindler's argument—I keep wanting to call him David—about the centrality of goodness. That's what we're doing. All right, so what does Desmond do? He talks about a practice, not a belief, not an argument. He's talking about a pilgrimage, a phenomenological pilgrimage, a practice he calls "return to zero." Return to zero.
- 8.10** Now, it's very similar to a practice in Zen called "the great doubt." The great doubt. So you doubt as deeply as you can, and koans are designed to get you into the great doubt, like, "What was your face like before your mother was born?" "What is the sound of one hand clapping?" And the idea is to get you not to try and—if you give an answer, they hit you with a stick. The point is to get into the state of doubt, and as one of the texts says, it's like you're swallowing a ball of red-hot iron that will burn all the way down.
- 8.11** You're supposed to take the doubt into the depths of what we, in the West, would call nihilism. And Nishitani and Nishida from the Kyoto School—Nishida wrote a book called *The Experience of the Good*, by the way, that's very convergent with everything we're talking about, *The Experience of the Good*. And Nishitani wrote a book called *The Self-Overcoming of Nihilism and Religion and Nothingness*. So, Zen was here before, and the Kyoto School is taking Zen and mixing it with Heideggerian phenomenology, which is completely relevant to William Desmond.
- 8.12** And I've actually mentioned this to William, and he said yes, although he said, "You know, the Kyoto school, I really like the Kyoto school, but Nishitani and Nishida, they're great, but I like Tanabe." The guy knows a lot. I was like, "Whoa!" I said, "Do you like

Tanabe because he's much more like Kierkegaard?" He goes, "Yeah, that's kind of why." Really cool. Really amazing guy. So what do you do?

- 8.13** So, I've been doing practices since 1991. I'm a tai chi player for all that time and I do a version of Vipassana meditation. I do Neoplatonic contemplation practices, I do imaginal practices, I do some dialogical practices. You've heard me mention it, dialectic into dialogos. So I do a lot of practices. I have a rich ecology of practices. And I took this practice on when I was reading William Desmond's work, and also a book on William Desmond by Duns, where he talks about how you take Desmond's philosophy and turn it into a bunch of practices, an ecology of practices.
- 8.14** So what you do is, you basically sit—this is imaginal, not imaginary, it's imaginal—and you try to put yourself into an imaginal contemplative state of, "I'm going to really try and be in the noesis and the gnosis of a nihilist." It's wonderful that he had that alliteration, too: the noesis and the gnosis of the nihilist. What would it be like to see the world, to really see the world the way the nihilist does, and what would it be like to be in the world the way the nihilist is? I'm going to practice that. I'm going to try to, as honestly get to that return to zero, as I possibly can. And you practice it.
- 8.15** By the way, don't start practicing this as your only practice. Do a couple of decades of other practices first before you take this on, because this practice is very, very—it's extremely disruptive. It's like a pilgrimage, but the thing you're pilgrimaging with, you're not walking from one place to another, you're in the Starship Enterprise, and you're just going really fast.
- 8.16** So what happens, though, is you basically take the nihilists seriously. Everything is a projection. I'm going to really try and be— the word "believe" originally didn't mean to assert something. "Beleben." It means "give your heart to." I'm really going to try and be and see the nihilist, because I'm going to try and—what's it like if I was really true to "everything is a projection"? So I'm withdrawing everything. No, wait, that's a projection. What's real? What's real? What's really real?
- 8.17** Notice the question I'm asking. What's really real? And you do this and you do this and you get to this place. And yet, it doesn't wink out. You don't black out. You don't fall into—because you can't, that's the point—into an absolute nothingness. You come to no-thingness. You're not considering anything, but you're not in nothingness. You're in this difference between no-thingness and nothingness. Now, that sounds like, "Ugh." Remember that Being isn't a thing? It's a no-thing, because it's what makes all the things possible. Does that make sense?
- 8.18** You can come to a place where relevance realization, which deals with all the beings and all their possible combination, actually has a sensibility transcendence in which it realizes that it itself is irrelevant, because I'm trying to face Being, not any set of Beings. Does that make sense? And you're in this state like this. You're right on the horizon.

And they haven't done it, so this is hard, but I've done it, and so I'm trying to use that to give you an understanding of what the heck Desmond is talking about.

- 8.19** What gets here is, you get this weird thing. So stick with me. I hope I've earned your trust by now. There's nothing, there's no thing. You have an absolutely equally distributed awareness, and it's just a being, and it's like this pressure. It's like the potential for contact everywhere and nowhere all at once. Does that at least give a little bit of a sense of what it is? Yeah, a little bit? And you realize that what you're on is, you're on the horizon between the inexhaustibility of everything and the particular things that there are.
- 8.20** You're right on that place between being and all the beings. Now it's not a place. It's a no-place. It's not a real place. It's a no-place, because you're looking at the no-thingness of being. I'm trying. Is that landing even a little bit, Lawrence, for you? Are you getting a sense of what this could be like, perhaps? So you're in this place that's no place.
- 8.21** Now, let me just give you a little bit more of—so Nishida, who wrote *The Experience of the Good*, he has a term for this called the "basho". Let me give you an example. Here's the color system. Here's all the colors, and they form a system of integration and differentiation. There's a system of colors. That's OK, that's not weird for you, right? Does the system of colors itself have a color? So, in terms of all the colors, it's no color. But it's not nothing. It's no color. It's the no-place where all the colors take place. Does that make sense? And so, I'm trying to get you into the basho of Being, which is very different from your everyday experience of beings.
- 8.22** When that happens, you realize that all the relevance realization, all the sense-making that you do at this moment, makes no sense. The way that can be spoken of is not the way. It is the mother of myriad things. Naming makes us realize all the unique things, but behind it is the basho, the Being, the no-place where everything is taking place. And that's where you come to when you do the nihilistic thing. You come to that horizon, which is a boundary that's not any real boundary. Is that OK?
- 8.23** Now I'm pushing you towards something here, because we're talking about when people have experiences of ontonormativity. But notice how, when I'm going into nihilism—and this is Zen's point, this is the glory of Zen—I go into the deepest nihilism, and what I hit is, I'm not like a wave without a shore that just dissipates. I go into it, and poof, and I reverberate with ontonormativity itself.
- 8.24** That's part of the phenomenological description. Let's go in and try and give you some more concepts, so that you can at least point to it in some way. Notice this isn't about having fanciful—remember, facing? This is purely adverbial. There's no adjectival in this. This is just the way of seeing and being. There is nothing that you, there is no thing that you are seeing. There is no thing that you are being. This is purely adverbial. This is purely the way. That's Daoism, the way. It's also why Jesus says, "I am the way." And it's

why the first followers of Jesus are not called Christians. They're called followers of the way.

- 8.25** So, let's take this state. Gnosis, the Gnostics, remember the Gnostics talked about we're trapped inside this prison? They came up with this really scary and horrifying, because Nazism is basically a Gnostic nightmare. I'm serious. There's a grand conspiracy, there's an evil overlord, and it's binding us all inside of a prison, like the Matrix, and that evil overlord is like the God of the Old Testament. And who are the people that worship the God of the Old Testament, by the way? The Jews. Oh, the Jews are in part of the conspiracy. This is part of Nazism.
- 8.26** So Gnosticism has real dangers to it. So let's, again, let's put Gnosticism aside and try to recover Gnosticism. What were the Gnostics on about? Their descriptions are— I reject them. But there must have been a phenomenological experience that they're trying to talk about. They felt entrapped. They felt existentially entrapped. They felt that their very mode of seeing and being in the world—that's what existential means—their very mode, their very way of being and seeing in the world, they were entrapped. And so they created this weird, nightmarish vision to try and explain that sense of entrapment. Is that OK?
- 8.27** That's what the Matrix is, again. Try and watch that movie again. Why is he called Neo, by the way? Neoplatonism. What is he? He is the One. Neoplatonism. The Matrix. All right, so this is made up of two things. One is existential inertia, inertia. This is when people, when they come to therapy, often can state in propositions what the problem is. "You know, blah, blah, blah, blah." That's not the issue. It's not a propositional issue.
- 8.28** They don't know how, they don't know what it would be like, they don't know how to transform and self-transcend to be the person that will no longer be suffering like this. And that's what the therapist has to help them do, by doing what Iris Murdoch's mother-in-law did with the daughter-in-law. That's therapy. Do you find that an acceptable description?
- 8.29** So they lack noesis and gnosis. In a very important way, they have a negative version of what I had when I couldn't kick Jason out. They have an unthinkable. They can entertain propositions, but they can't bring themselves to get there. Do you see? The existential inertia is the shadow that is cast by the fact we all are voluntary necessity. The shadow. We only experience that sense of existential inertia because we are normally flowing with voluntary necessity. But we get a dark version of that when we feel the unthinkable in a way that is trapping us. Is that making sense? So this is the shadow cast. Think about the cave and the shadows cast in the cave. This is the shadow cast by our voluntary necessity, the fact that we are called to being faithful, true to reality.
- 8.30** There's another part to entrapment: existential ignorance. This is the way in which we're blind. We have perspectival and participatory blindness. We lack the gnosis and

the noesis. So this gets us into the work of L. A. Paul, who wrote a book, actually, she wrote the book on transformative experience, called Transformative Experience. It's a masterpiece. She introduces it to you, and you'll see all the themes we're talking about here. Notice Iris Murdoch, and now it's L. A. Paul. I met Laurie. She's really wonderful. She invited me down to Yale. I gave a lecture at Yale to her class. It was fun.

- 8.31** So your friends come to you, and they give you undeniable evidence, absolutely convincing evidence, that they can do the following. This is a thought experiment, so play with me, a serious play: I can turn you into a vampire. Now, should you do it? Well, you face a really weird problem. Because you don't know what it's going to be like to be a vampire. You don't know what the noesis of a vampire is. You have propositions about vampires, and maybe you have a few skills. Maybe you lurk really well or something. But you don't know what it's like to be a vampire. You don't have that. You are perspectively ignorant.
- 8.32** And you don't know who you're going to be when you're a vampire, because you're going to have a different set of values, different, right, because your salience landscaping, the way you size things up, and the things you identify within yourself, are all going to shift. You're going to be a different person. So you have participatory ignorance. And you can't reason your way through this.
- 8.33** She makes a very important point about that. We're told how we should make decisions is, we should rack up, we should list all the probabilities and assign all the negative or positive. Here's all the facts, the probabilities. Here's all the values that we assign to them, and then we multiply—so here's the probability of this occurrence, and then I times it by the utility, how much I value it. And then whatever choice has the greatest answer, that's what I pick. That's called the decision calculus. And the point is, it's—see how it uses the fact-value dichotomy?—it's absolutely useless. Because you're ignorant about the perspectival and participatory realities.
- 8.34** You have to go through becoming a vampire. "Oh, well, I shouldn't do it because I don't know what I'm going to lose." But if you don't do it, you don't know what you're missing either. You can't possibly know. And then you go, "Who cares? Have a kid." When I have a kid, I have to become a parent. Until I have a child, I've never been a parent. Being a child is no education for how to be a parent. I'm going to see the world differently, and I'm going to become a different person.
- 8.35** I don't know what I'm going to lose when I become a parent, and I don't know who I'm going to become. I don't know what I'm going to lose, I don't know what I might miss if I don't become a parent. I don't know. What about, "I should enter into a long-term romantic relationship with this person"? Do your relationships change you? You bet. "Well, maybe I shouldn't. I don't want to be changed. But what might I be missing?" You can't calculate it. You have to do serious imaginal play. You have to go into situations.

- 8.36** You know what people do, when they're thinking about getting a kid? They get a dog. So it's kind of, I get a taste of what it's like. I can sort of see, and this is what it's kind of like, "Oh, nope, ah, it's not going to work," I can pull out, because it's a dog. Because this is what you can do with the dog. You've had a dog for a couple of months, you go, "I don't think this is going to work. I'm going to find the dog another home." You're not really encouraged to do that with your kids.
- 8.37** We don't look, "Yeah, nah, don't want to do this." What? That's a person. "I'm going to get into a long-term romantic relationship." Travel with the person for 3 weeks. It's good advice, by the way. Another one is, paint a house with them. This is what rituals are. Rituals are, I'm here, and I don't have the gnosis and the noesis. I'm going to do serious imaginal play that allows me to get a foretaste of this without having completely gone through the transformation, so I can actually make an informed decision. That's what ritual does.
- 8.38** And then, Agnes Callard comes along, and she talks about that. We don't just do this one-off. We try to link a series of these. When I'm committing to a parent, I'm not just committing to doing one of these transformative experiences, I'm committing to a long-term program of transformative experiences. So I'm going to be doing this constant indwelling my child and then internalizing them. I'm going to do an extended form of inspiration that we call aspiration. Another woman, by the way, Agnes Callard, wrote a great book on aspiration called *Aspiration*.
- 8.39** You should now realize that, when we experience existential ignorance, this is the shadow cast by our capacity, our wonderful capacity for sensibility transcendence, for self-transcendence. And of course these go together—voluntary necessity, sensibility transcendence. These are the shadows cast. These are the negative twistings. But remember, the hermeneutics of suspicion is dependent on the real beautiful example. This can only exist because voluntary necessity exists. This can only exist because sensibility transcendence exists.
- 8.40** This is Desmond's point. You go into this, and you feel the pressure, you see the shadows, and then you ask, "But what is casting the light that is creating the shadows?" And in Zen, you realize the luminous void, the pure light of the pure intelligibility of pure realization. You realize ontognormativity. So what we realize is, we realize two parts of it, two movements within us. One is, William Desmond calls it your "conatus essendi". He gets conatus from Spinoza. Conatus is the energy of your autopoietic self-making.
- 8.41** Everything, for Spinoza, everything has a conatus. Everything is holding itself together. A Christian, like Maximus the Confessor, would say everything has a logos. That's conatus. He calls it the conatus essendi, your essential conatus. You know what this is. He calls it your urge to ultimacy. We've already talked about this. This is your urge. You're only nihilistic because there's a part of you that wants there to be

ontonormativity, and you're somehow disappointed. You can't appoint, you can't come to your appointment with ontonormativity, but you're appointed to do so.

- 8.42** Now, conatus means actually "to be born with." It's really interesting. Co-natus, nativity, natus, native, born. What is that essential urge born with? What's it born from? It's born from what he calls your "passio essendi". This is your essential, this is the essential possibility. The passio essendi, this is the womb of your conatus.
- 8.43** By the way, womb is the word for compassion in the Bible. When Jesus says, "Be compassionate," mercy is a bad translation. Mercy is a power term. Mercy is when I can exercise power on you, and I have the right to do so, and I do not do it. That's mercy. Mercy is a bad translation. The other translation is compassion. Look at passion, by the way. Passion means to undergo. The Passion of the Christ, to undergo. So, compassion, when he says, "Be compassionate, the way God is compassionate," he's saying, "Be womb-like, the way God is womb-like." God makes everything possible. God is not only that to which you're ultimately urged, God is the womb that makes all of your being possible for you. It's your primordality.
- 8.44** Of course, that opens us up. It opens us up to the primordial, profoundly, pervasively presupposed, and it is the ground of our participation. But that is bound up with, gives birth to, conceives our conatus essendi, our urge towards ultimacy. Nihilism is about losing both of those, because we are somehow—we have twisted them into shadows of themselves. This is what Desmond means when he said, "You couldn't experience nihilism. If nihilism were true, you couldn't experience it. Because if nihilism were true, there'd be no truth in which you could participate. There'd be no light of intelligibility by which you could make this statement."
- 8.45** Nihilism, as Nishitani argues, completely undermines itself. It's the self-overcoming of nihilism. But you can't do this in argument. If you stay in the framework, especially the fact-value dichotomy, you're doomed. You have to pilgrimage it out and do this meta-noetic thing that we are doing right now. There's a phenomenological process that we're engaging in here. This is from Desmond. "The self-transcending power of thinking"—that's the urge—"is derived from a primal porosity." Porosity is participation, metaxu, touch, realizing and being realized. If there's no realizing and being realized, how could I possibly be aware of nihilism?
- 8.46** We are thus given the communal nature of being again. There's something about being that affords participation, voluntary necessity, and sensibility transcendence. So what we need is—and now I'm doing both William Desmond's Christian Neoplatonism, although he's not a Christian, but he loves Christianity, a very interesting fellow. And Zen and Daoism are all pointing at this.
- 8.47** I'm not saying they're saying the same thing. I'm saying, I've done all of these ecologies of practices to a significant and deep degree, and you can see that they have convergent realizations. I am not saying they're saying the same thing. Is that clear? It's

very important that you hear me on this. You and I can have a really flowing, life-giving conversation. It doesn't mean that you and I come to agree on the same propositions, but we both feel that we have moved in mutual transformation to places we couldn't get to on our own. That's what I'm talking about.

8.48 So, perhaps we have a higher state of consciousness, a really superlative form of gnosis. Because we've renewed our senses and we've gone into—we've done the return to zero and pushed them and stress-tested them. What if we had a gnosis then that could alleviate the despair that comes from existential entrapment? Well, what are the features of that despair? One is: the world is absurd. That's what a nihilist will say. The world is absurd.

8.49 Now the problem is, absurdity doesn't work the way the nihilist thinks it does. Thomas Nagel, the guy who wrote *The View from Nowhere*, and also really launched perspectival knowing when he wrote his very famous essay, "What's It Like to Be a Bat?" We have lots of propositions about bats, but we can't get into their perspectival knowing, because we can't do their participatory gnosis, because you need to be a bat. You need to have the autopoiesis of a bat.

8.50 So Thomas Nagel wrote a great essay on the absurd, entitled "The Absurd." He also talks about it in his book, *The View from Nowhere*, and he says the arguments that people give for absurdity aren't good arguments. "Well, what I do won't matter a million years from now." That means also what happens a million years from now shouldn't matter to you now. "Well, I'm so insignificant." OK, I blow you up to the size of the Andromeda galaxy. Are things better for you? You're confusing causal power with meaning.

8.51 So he goes through all the arguments. You can read it at length, and he basically shows that nihilism is not the result of argumentation. The arguments are after-the-fact attempts to express nihilism, because nihilism is ultimately a perspectival and participatory thing. It is not a propositional thing. And he is especially concerned to explain how it's perspectival. So he gives an example.

8.52 I'm going to tell you another thing. Now his story—he's older than me—his story is from the dark times, the before time. People had to have their phone where they lived. And when they were away from their phone, you couldn't phone them. Imagine that. Such dark times. But people often didn't want to miss an important phone call, so they would have things that would record a phone call. Maybe you've seen this primitive device on a movie: an answering machine. You have voicemail on your phone, but your generation don't use voicemail. I learned this very quickly. In fact, you don't call somebody on your phone because they panic when you call them. "Why are you calling?" No, just text.

8.53 So here's this guy, Tom, and all day, he's been wrestling with, "I've got to tell Susan that I love her." So he calls the phone, he hears the phone picked up, like a click, because

you used to hear that. And before anything happens, he shouts out, "Susan, I love you, I love you, I love you." And then he hears, in her voice, "Susan is not here right now. Please leave a message."

- 8.54** Now you're smiling, because humor is a little bit of absurdity. Humor is when there's two perspectives and they clash with each other, and you can use an insight to resolve that. So here's not a very good joke, but don't leave alphabet soup boiling on your stove. It could spell disaster. Not a very good joke, but what's happening is, I'm playing with two different meanings of "spell disaster." You see? Two different perspectives.
- 8.55** Now what he says is, we feel a little bit—what's going on here? Well, because from his first-person perspective, this is incredibly meaningful, but from the impersonal perspective of a machine, it's absolutely meaningless. Do you see that? The two perspectives: first-person and third-person perspective. Now blow that up to the cosmos. Here's your first-person perspective. Here's the entire universe perspective. Now, do you feel cosmic absurdity? It's not funny anymore, is it?
- 8.56** But could you have an insight that alleviates that perspectival clash? Could you have a noesis? Yes. William Blake: "To see the world in a grain of sand and heaven in a wildflower; to hold infinity in the palm of your hand and spend eternity in an hour." The two are completely interpenetrating. What's he writing about? A moment of ontognormativity, a moment of the really real. That moment is exactly the moment that alleviates absurdity, because it resolves the perspectival clash that is the core of absurdity.
- 8.57** Loving the good is what actually alleviates absurdity, and there's nothing irrational about this, because absurdity is not a propositional argument. It's a perspectival clash. What about alienation? That's another aspect. Disconnection. Well, profound participation. That's the answer. Profound participation, profound contact, profound conformity. Destroy all the dichotomies. There you go.
- 8.58** Anxiety. Now, there's two kinds of anxiety. There's psychological—this is Tillich—there's psychological anxiety, and you need therapy for that. I don't know why I'm gesturing at you, but you're a therapist, right? And so we're not talking about that. We're talking about existential anxiety, when you feel like your whole existence might be meaningless. Now, existential and psychological anxiety can reinforce each other, so I'm making an analytic point here. I'm not making a causal point. And so, I'm not trying to do therapy. I'm not qualified. I'm trying to talk about this over here, existential anxiety.
- 8.59** Well, what you need is anagoge, because anagoge is optimal reciprocal opening. It is that which most alleviates existential anxiety. This is what is meant, I believe, when, in the Epistle of John, he says, "Love casts out fear." He doesn't mean fear. Fear is when there's a focal object. It's a bad translation. Like, when there's a tiger in here, you don't

want to—"I don't want to be afraid right now, so I'm going to love." No, because you're dead.

- 8.60** He's talking about existential anxiety, and love as reciprocal opening, profound participation, alleviates that. Because you get to the balance point between trying to control the world and realizing that the world needs to be, to some degree, uncontrollable, if you want to resonate with reality in realization.
- 8.61** Anguish. Deep grief. I've gone through grief multiple times in my life because I'm old. I mean deep grief. Parents, loss, marriage ending. I wouldn't wish grief on my worst enemy. But I'll tell you this. I went to one of the wisest people in my life when I was in one of these, and he said to me, "John, don't ever get involved with somebody who hasn't experienced grief in romantic relationships." And I went, "Why?" He said, "Because they're not fully human." I went, "Whoa."
- 8.62** That's what wise people do. They say things that sound right, but they're like, "What?" And I lived with this and lived with this. And then I heard the story of the Buddha and the woman whose child had died. Baby. And she brings the baby to the Buddha, and she says, "Will you resurrect him?" Now, the Buddha always refused to perform miracles. In fact, he said, "You know somebody's not one of my disciples, not one of my disciples, if they offer to perform a miracle."
- 8.63** So he refuses, he refuses, and she keeps begging him and begging him and begging him. And finally, she goes to leave, and he goes, "All right, I will resurrect your son, but first you have to do something for me." "Anything, anything." "I want you to go into your home—sorry, I want you to go into your hometown, and I want you to go to every house, and you need to bring for me a mustard seed." "I can do that. That's easy. I'll find somebody that has—" "Ah, one condition. It has to come from a house where nobody has tasted death. Nobody's experienced grief."
- 8.64** So she goes to the first house. She knocks on the door. "Do you have any mustard seeds?" "Yes." "Have you ever confronted grief? Have you ever experienced profound loss?" "Yeah, my mother died." Next house, "Yeah, my brother died." Next house, "Yeah, my son died." And then after she does a bunch of houses, she goes, "Oh." Remember, the mother-in-law and the daughter-in-law? She has one of those. And then she goes back to the Buddha, and she says, "Thank you."
- 8.65** You can't be freed from your mortality. That's inhuman. What do you need? What you need is ontornormativity. Why? Because we should not, and our culture is messed up about this, we should not try to isolate or preserve people from grief. If you do that, you are damaging their humanity. Grief is like a hole. It's a hole in my heart. Yes. Don't try and fill it. Grow around it, because if you grow around it, this becomes an eye through which I can un-self myself and see her when she is facing her finitude, and it is hurting her. I can recognize the reality of her suffering.

- 8.66** What I need is, I need something that will free me from the idolatry or the tyranny of grief. Tyranny is when I come to believe that the world is meaningless because of my grief. And what I need is, and what Desmond talks about is, when you have this experience that he's talking about, of ontonormativity, it's the intimate ultimate. It's ultimate, but it's a sensed presence. It's not something abstract. It is right here. It is closer to you than you are to yourself, because it reaches into your primordiality and recognizes your urge to ultimacy. So it's intimate. That saves you from the tyranny of grief.
- 8.67** There's also the possibility of the idolatry of grief. This is Miss Havisham in *Great Expectations*. She was jilted at the altar, and she continues to wear her wedding dress and won't let anybody take down the reception, and everything's cobwebbed and decaying, and she's falling apart, because she's idolized her grief. And people get locked, they can get locked into the tyranny or the idolatry of grief. The intimacy of ontonormativity liberates us from the tyranny, but the ultimacy of it liberates us from idolatry, because we realize this is not ultimate.
- 8.68** There's a great scene in *The Lord of the Rings*. Sam and Frodo are making their way, and they're deep in Mordor. Everything is dark, and ugh, and then the clouds part, and I believe it's Sam sees the stars, and he realizes there's something beyond all of his troubles. It doesn't do anything. It doesn't come in and save him from the grief that he's facing, but he realizes, "Oh, what I'm in isn't ultimate. There's something beyond it."
- 8.69** Ontonormativity can liberate you from the tyranny and the idolatry of grief. Not from grief, because you should not seek liberation from grief. That is wrong. It is to subvert your humanity. But you should seek that which can liberate you from its tyranny and its idolatry. Ontonormativity does this. So we can have a gnosis that addresses absurdity and alienation and anxiety and anguish. Everything that the nihilist is throwing in our face, we can face.
- 8.70** We can face despair with a faithfulness of being troth, entrusted, to what is true, to which we are true. Gnosis connects our urge to ultimacy and our gratitude to our primordiality within faithfulness, while affording us to love that square I drew of meta-meaning, meta-morality, meta-problem solving, and meta-desire satisfaction, ontonormativity. So now we've done the phenomenological argument, and we also had the cognitive argument. Now we're going to turn to the ontological argument by D. C. Schindler.
- 8.71** Ontology is the study of the structure of reality. This comes from a bunch of sources. He's been working on this for a lot of his career, and I've got to talk to David multiple times—a wonderful man, brilliant mind, warm heart. First is Plato's *Critique of Impure Reason*. Guess what? All goes back to Plato. There we go. Plato's *Critique of Impure Reason*, reason that is disconnected from ontonormativity.

- 8.72** A book called *The Catholicity of Reason*, which has nothing to do with being Catholic; it means the universality of reason. He has an essay in that book called "The Primacy of Beauty, The Centrality of Goodness, and The Ultimacy of Truth." And most recently, 2018, he has a book called *Love and the Postmodern Predicament*. Listen to the subtitle: *Rediscovering the Real in Beauty, Goodness, and Truth*. Highly recommend that book. It's the end of that whole line of development. It's the most accessible.
- 8.73** What have we gathered? The real is bound up with realization, contact, touching and being touched, realizing and being realized. This is the two senses of real. Confirmation. It's intelligible. I can make inferences about it. Surprise, it's inexhaustible. I can have insights about it. The two senses, realizing and being realized. Confirmation and surprise. Reality is communal in some way. This is what he's concluding from this.
- 8.74** You say, "I sort of see it, but what's the connection?" The thing that's still blocking us, potentially, is propositional tyranny, a picture that has us in its grip. Reality must be structured the way propositions are, because the only kind of knowing is propositional. This actually even goes back to Aristotle. And so, reality must have the structure of a proposition. There must be subjects with their predicates. That's the logical term. And if you don't like that, we'll do the grammatical term: nouns and verbs. That's how reality is, because I can describe it with sentences, propositions that can be true or false.
- 8.75** Where are the relations in that model? We've seen how fundamental relations are—connections, transjectivity, participation—the real relations of fittedness, adaptivity, affordance, relevance realization. Where are the relations? Nishida did this. He said, Nishida said, "I'm actually interested in what connects them. This is some kind of basho that makes all the logic possible."
- 8.76** What is that? Is that a subject? Is it a predicate? No. But something's holding them together. Well, is a relation—like, there's two things in a relation. Let's do a simple relation: "This is taller than that." Really simply, is the tallness in this? So, by itself, is it tall? Is the tallness in this? Nope. So the nouns don't possess the relation. It's nothing they're doing. Oh. You can say that the relation is made by both of them together, and you just lost, because you invoked this word, which is a relation term.
- 8.77** So what you're saying is, you know where the relation comes from? The relation. Haha. Bet you didn't think of that answer. And you're right, but not in the way you thought. This is the work of James Filler in a bunch of amazing books he's recently done. I've gotten to talk to James, amazing thinker. He basically runs through this argument. He says the people that came up with this argument, by the way, are the Neoplatonists. But he acknowledges equal arguments can be found in Zen and in other aspects of Buddhism, Indra's Net and things like that. The idea that relations are more real than substances.
- 8.78** We hear subjects, but what a substance means—so I won't keep using that word because it's confusing. We think of the world as made up of individual, autonomous

things. That's not reality. In fact, science keeps telling us that's not reality, and we're surprised each time. Everything is interpenetrating. Everything is relational. Look! Is this an individual thing? Is it? Tell me where it is. Do you believe that $E = mc^2$ is true? You'd better, because it makes atomic bombs happen. So it's true, right? It's really true. It's deeply true.

8.79 Where is it? Point to it. Where is it? Where should I go to find it? When is it happening? Does it happen on Tuesdays? Thursdays? Where is it? We're describing a relation. Look, it's a relation. Information is a relation. Patterns are relation. Forces are relations. Entanglement in quantum mechanics, which we think is at the most primordial, is pure relation. Relation is more real than individual autonomous things. This is why, ultimately, the fact-value dichotomy and other things don't work, because relationality takes priority over individual things.

8.80 Now, I'm really impressed by this argument. I mean, it's a really powerful argument, and it draws so many things together. Like I said, it's convergent. Neoplatonism is saying this, and Zen is saying—wow, science, Zen, Neoplatonism, all converging. The argument is really powerful. It goes so well with the fact that we've deconstructed all the dichotomies. It really points to participation, rather than the autonomous, isolated, alienated individual in an absurd world.

8.81 That's all good. But then I realized something. This is right insofar as it's much better than the old model, the Aristotelian independent individuals. Because I said to James, to his face, and he took it very seriously, and he goes, "Hmm." I said, "So what you've shown is," so I'm going to give you a technical term here: "relata". Relata are the things in the relation. These are the things related, and then there are relations. So let me just point. These are the relata, and the tallness is the relation. Is that OK?

8.82 And I said, "What you've shown is that I can't get relations from relata. That doesn't work." I said, "You've really shown that; and so, relations are more important." Yeah. I said, "But James, I can give you an exactly symmetrical argument. I can't get relata from relations. How do pure relations turn into the things that are related? And what distinguishes one relationship from another, other than the things that are related?" If I were to take away this, how would I know—so, here's a relation and here's another relation. When I take away these, what distinguishes the relation? Nothing. So look, I can't get the relata from the relations, and I can't get the relations from the relata.

8.83 Now, remember, this is like, I need to read the words in order to disambiguate the letters, and I need to read the letters in order to disambiguate the words? This is a chicken-and-egg problem. So the answer is, it's both. The answer is, it's both. What do I mean by that? I'm pushing you to the limit here, because we're doing, confronting the nihilist to the depths. We have to go to the limit. There's nothing short of that which would be intellectually responsible.

- 8.84** Here's the relata, here's the relations. They co-emerge from a common source. They co-emerge from being. If they have a common source, they have a common unity. What's our word for common unity? Community. This is what William Desmond means by the communal nature of being. Being is ultimately a community, and we are ultimately participating, communing, in community, the community of being. And we do that best both as ourselves and with others, because there are no persons without communities, and there are no communities without persons. They co-emerge.
- 8.85** Of course, I don't just mean a community with people. You have your community with the living world and your community with the physical world. Community: touching and being touched. Community: realizing and being realized. Everything is simultaneously for itself, so it doesn't get absorbed into my subjectivity, but also for me, so it enters into relationship to me, and we can participate in community. That's ontorelativity.
- 8.86** Now we have the phenomenological argument from Desmond, the cognitive argument about attention from Murdoch, and the ontological argument from Schindler. Let's put them together with everything we've been building. I'm going to hold my book because this is a complex diagram. And if I had given this to you at the beginning of the course, I imagine people would have just exploded. But now we can think about it.
- 8.87** So we have ultimacy. This is what calls us to self-transcendence, and thereby empowers voluntary necessity—reason, love, beauty, etc. Down here, we have our primordiality. This is the porosity of our participation. This is what we pervasively and profoundly presuppose. It is where we ultimately are standing for all of our understanding. So this, in that sense, grounds us, in the sense that we grow from it. We participate and emerge from it.
- 8.88** So this is how everything is emerging. This is how possibilities are shaped and called to us, and this is how they are emanating into and forming how possibility—look, this doesn't emerge. This is not an event. It is not a happening. It is not a growing up. "Physis", physics, means to grow up. It's not that, but it's still part of physics. Why? It constrains possibility. It limits what is possible. It informs reality. It puts it into a particular form. This is a formula. Do you understand? It emanates. It emerges. So, primordiality, emerging from, but the calling is emanating towards us. Possibility is being really shaped. Is that OK? This is information. This is energy.
- 8.89** What's happening, of course, is reality, conatus, shaping itself, taking place, emerging, self-organizing. This is actual realization. This is the for itself that's for others. This is the communing of being. This is the for itself for others. This draws down the ultimate; it draws up the primordial. That drawing-down of the ultimate is a kind of beauty. Things are shining in the way they can call to us and afford our aspiration.
- 8.90** But it also draws up the primordial, the beauty of something growing, like a child coming into existence or a plant growing. We find that beautiful. We also find it beautiful how things come together. No matter where we start, we start with beauty,

the primacy of beauty. No matter where we start, we're starting with beauty. But what we have is the ultimacy of truth and the centrality of goodness that is connecting the primordial and the ultimate: the ultimately real, the primordially real, the actually real in the really real.

- 8.91** Now you've seen this picture before. This is selection. This is variation. Feedback cycle. Remember evolution? Remember relevance realization? It's the same structure. It's the same grammar. Life, mind, being. On the side of relevance realization, we have top-down and— in your mind, top-down, bottom-up processing. Remember reading the cat? And it self-organizes. Relevance realization. Life. Being.
- 8.92** Things emerge from your unconscious, but they're constrained by the normativity of your character, and then you generate thoughts that you conceive and give birth to. Mind, life, being, all in community with each other, deep continuity. The really real and the co-evolution of reality and mind. That's how to understand the primacy of beauty, the ultimacy of truth, and then what holds it all together is the centrality of goodness. And that is the course, my students. We're done. So, questions?
- 8.93** First off, that was very good. My mind is turning still, but I wanted to just push back. I mean, from the last lecture, I had a question regarding community and the loop of ourselves and coming into the light and coming out, and how that's a progressive thing that we go through in life. We were talking about this during break, but to what extent is it our responsibility to help others reach that light, if we have felt that maybe we have internalized that for ourselves and now have maybe moved forward?
- 8.94** I mean, if you accept the argument, your responsibility to the realness of others is a kind of love that has to be experienced. However, remember, this is all within the container, I would argue, Plato would argue, of your finite transcendence. So one of the dichotomies, and the whole world's suffering it, and your republic is suffering it really bad, is between the left and the right, which are kind of losing all meaning that they used to have. It's just "the other side's evil," right?
- 8.95** But one could make the argument that, originally, what they were trying to do was to hold the two, the finite and the transcendent, together. The left, when it's at its best—and I'm not saying it's at its best anywhere right now, so I'm talking about what it could be, as a way of answering you—says, "We're all subject to finitude and fate. There are things that are going to happen to us beyond our control, and we have to exercise compassion towards each other. Because if we don't, we're not accepting our finitude. We're denying that we are finite. And we're denying that we are in community about our finitude."
- 8.96** But the right, when it's at its best, says, "Yes, but we are also called to virtue. We have a personal responsibility to cultivate wisdom and virtue, and we have to be enabled as individuals to cultivate wisdom and virtue and bring that into our community." That's when the right is at its best. And the idea is, if they are held together in opponent

processing, not adversarial processing—opponent processing, your body is filled with opponent processing. When it turns into adversarial processing, you know what that's called? Cancer.

- 8.97** I put it to you that your republic has a cancer because it's replaced the opponent processing of democracy with the cancer of "the other side has to be destroyed." You are my best chance of correcting my bias, and I am your best chance of you correcting your bias. We have a community together. That community means, I have to be responsible to you when fate overwhelms you. But I'm not responsible to the point where I'm torn away from my obligation to cultivate wisdom and virtue. That's how I would answer you.
- 8.98** Hi, so I liked what you were talking about with the noesis and gnosis of Neoplatonic, the imaginal place, and it made a connection in my head again, I guess, to Christ and his idea of going—it says he went into hell so that he can ascend to heaven. And is that related? So that's related to this nihilism?
- 8.99** Yeah, yeah, I think so. And I mean, Jonathan Pageau would be better on this than me, but I think—so, one of the things that's really interesting, I'm reading Introduction to Christianity by Ratzinger, the guy who became a Pope, and he says Christianity, the fact that Christianity and Platonism come together, he doesn't regard that as a coincidence. So Christianity picked up on the Christ myth, remember by myth, I mean our worldview; I don't mean a false story.
- 8.100** The Christians have a worldview, and in that worldview Christ comes and he descends and then goes back and then he will come back. So they picked up on how that was resonating with the Platonic story of the cave. And many of the Church Fathers see that connection that you've just seen. Now, what I would ask you to perhaps consider, in order to understand the possibility of mutually transformative dialogue across religious boundaries, is that other religions have come to things that are convergent.
- 8.101** Not the same—remember her and I talking in a mutual conversation, a mutual transformation— but they have done similar kinds of things, at least in a convergent manner. And you should accept that, because you're already accepting that Christianity and Platonism have converged, especially Neoplatonism.
- 8.102** Is it a good sign, since we are, a lot of the world is in a nihilistic state, the meaning crisis, is there hope that it can give birth to the ascension into maybe the Neoplatonic?
- 8.103** I think there's the advent of the sacred happening right now. I think things are trying to come together that previously didn't come together, to give us a renewal of the senses so we can re-inhabit the true, the good, and the beautiful, and the intelligible, and the real. We can fall in love with reality again. This, remember, I mentioned, you've got Jonathan Pageau and John Vervaeke and Michael Levin talking, and this is also happening.

- 8.104** So on the philosophical Silk Road, I did a tour through several places in Europe because I was trying to find the through line, the Neoplatonic through line, shared by Christianity, Judaism, and Islam. And then I also want to go to India and do Vedanta and Buddhism, and then I want to go to Japan and do Zen, which brought together Daoism and Buddhism, and then had the Kyoto school that took all of that and tried to bring it back to the Neoplatonic tradition in Europe.
- 8.105** That's because what I want to try and do is to afford the advent of the sacred, which I believe is the response that is happening from the primordial and the ultimate and the good, to the meaning crisis. I want to afford it as much as possible. I've committed to a real pilgrimage, like an actual pilgrimage about it, and I feel deeply in service to this because I—this is my rational hope to how to try and make a better world, not by myself or anything stupid like that, but contribute, participating in making a better world for all of you, including my kids.
- 8.106** I hope this question is not too personal. I was curious why you took the Neoplatonic way of being, instead of a religious way of being, in terms of—because I'm noticing a lot of religious metaphysics in the language, like talking about convergence, unity, what else, and so on. I'm just curious to why you found the Neoplatonic way of being the best way for you?
- 8.107** It's a personal question, but it's a question I'm very happy to have received, and I want to address. It's a great question, Lawrence. So first of all, Neoplatonism is the spiritual backbone of the Abrahamic West. It runs, it's a through line that runs through all of them; and if I want them to talk to each other, I need to find that through line and bring it alive again. So that's part of it. Secondly is, Neoplatonism actually sits on the overlap between philosophy, religion, and science, which is where I need to be in order to make this course. It's where I need to live in order to do what I'm proposing to you.
- 8.108** I actually am, and this will sound weird, I'm a Zen Neoplatonist. I want to bring together Zen and Neoplatonism in a communal opponent processing, not adversarial. Because what Zen does is prevent Neoplatonism from becoming too abstract and intellectual. And what Neoplatonism does is prevent Zen from becoming anti-intellectual and obscure. The two of them can hold each other in a tonos and thereby give me a way of doing a Silk Road from the East and the West. That's why. Thank you.